Lullaby of the Drowned

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32841610.

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

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Alternative Universe – Pirate, Mermaids, Sirens, Magicat Catra (She-Ra), Siren Adora (She-Ra), Siren Wooing Attempts, They're together but Adora's still trying to be romantic, Sexual Content, Magic Voice Stealing, Mentions of Blood, Mermaid-Typical Nudity, Sirens Eat Souls, so there's that, Implied/Referenced Drowning

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Summary

Adora and Catra were raised in the Pirate Horde together all their lives. After a lifetime of being told she would amount to nothing, Catra has finally been given her own ship to command – it only took Adora's ship sinking for Shadow Weaver to give Catra a chance. Avenging her lover is the only way Catra can imagine ever feeling at peace again. It is *odd* how familiar the siren they are hunting looks, though.
(Pirate Catra/Siren Adora AU)

Notes

I already have my first reference up of Merdora. Also, here's a bunch of pictures of brigantines, Catra's kind of ship.
This AU is set in a historical, vaguely magical Etheria (fae, sirens, etc exist but not spells or sorceresses), inspired both by what we see in the show and roughly the naval activities around the Golden Age of Piracy (beginning of the 18th century).

Catra the Siren Hunter

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra doesn't know why she comes down here so often. The room isn't even *l i.* lit her magicat vision is the only thing that lets her see in the dim light spilling into the back room of the cargo hold. It's just enough for the sides of the tank on the opposite end of the room to glisten as Catra settles down with her back against one of the beams framing the doorway. The ship sways and creaks around her, and she can hear Scorpia barking orders above deck distantly, but this part of the ship is the quietest.

There isn't much privacy to be had on a small brigantine out at sea. Even Catra's captain's quarters are noisy . Down here, in the deepest cargo hold at the stern of the boat, all the other noise is dampened. She can hear the ocean against the side of the ship, the rhythmic creak of wood, and for a moment, close her eyes and pretend she is back on a much larger ship. Hordak' s Man-of-War. The Black Garnet needed a large crew to run, but its size meant that she and Adora could always find somewhere relatively quiet to hide from prying eyes.

Catra closes her eyes, tilting her head back to lean against the beam and breathing in slowly, focusing on the scents of the sea, rations, wood, and gunpowder. Okay, her small brigantine doesn't smell quite the same way the Black Garnet did, but it' s close. If she can just ignore the crew above deck, she can picture Adora right beside her. Actually, maybe she can pretend this is the time they got stuck in the hidden storage space behind the galley just as a shift of the crew descended upon it to eat.

They had to stay quiet as a mouse to avoid any of the hybrids picking them up over the other noises and smells. If Shadow Weaver

found them in such a tight space together, she would have guessed what they were doing. Relationships aren't generally banned in the Horde, but theirs was. Women are an integral part of the Horde's structure, and Shadow Weaver's precious protégé, meant to take over her position as Quartermaster of the entire pirate fleet, couldn't be found dallying with a galley rat like Catra.

They were in the glorified closet for over an hour, maybe two. Pressed in tight proximity and forced to keep quiet, there really was only one thing left for them to do. Catra shivers, wrapping her arms around herself as she feels the ghost of Adora's soft lips against hers. If she were a believer in spirits, she would have had multiple reasons to think that Adora's was following hers by now, but Catra knows better than to put stock in myths like that.

There is magic in this world – she has *seen* it – but it doesn't reunite lovers who were torn apart. No, it does the tearing, sending sirens to drown Adora's ship on her first voyage as quartermaster. Catra was incensed when Shadow Weaver wouldn't transfer her to the same ship she appointed Adora to, instead keeping her back on the Black Garnet. Adora promised her that after she proved herself, she could put it to a vote and get Catra transferred with her, but she never got the chance.

They received the news just weeks after she left. Adora's ghost, so briefly summoned, vanishes from the room at the thought. Catra opens her eyes, glaring at the empty tank across from her. She's alone in the belly of the ship that Shadow Weaver only gave her to captain because the Horde is losing ships fast and she knows there is no greater motivator than revenge. Every Horde ship has a female captain or quartermaster who can take charge if a siren begins to sing and sway male crew members, but the problem used to be *a*.

It isn't anymore. Even with the precaution, there's not much one woman can do in the face of an entire crew suddenly hypnotized by one of the sea wretches' songs. The attack on Adora's ship was the first of a string. Maybe a pod of merfolk moved into the waters surrounding Seaworthy, but whatever the sudden cause, it's a

problem for everyone, the Horde included. Shadow Weaver scraped together the largest all-female crew she could assemble exclusively from personnel non-essential to other ships and, with Catra at the helm, ordered the crew to go siren hunting.

They aren't just doing this for the Horde. Merchants and navies will often pay for the heads of sirens. Catra's task is to capture as many as she can, muzzle them, and bring them to Sea Worthy to be killed and sold. Her trips down to this small tank room have nothing to do with her current mission though, just its cause – she misses Adora, and when she closes her eyes down here, she can pretend they're together again in that silent moment before their lips meet.

She closes her eyes and counts her breaths. With every one, her body expects to feel the gentle brush of Adora kneeling over her, reaching up to brush her mane aside, and then kissing her with the tenderness that Adora always reserved especially for their quiet, clandestine meetings below deck. Her heart *aches*. The atmosphere isn't quite right, but it's close and-

Singing. Beautiful, melodic, and distant - but growing closer. Catra's eyes snap open, her heart suddenly running in overdrive as adrenaline pounds through her. They've sailed into a siren's sights. It's finally time to act.

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The crew is scrambling above deck. Catra sweeps the horizon as she emerges from the bowels of the ship, already barking out orders.

"Entrapta! It's time to put your engineering to the test. Someone get a hand on the wheel!" Catra yells, making her way up to the elevated quarterdeck at the back of the ship. She hears a crow of excitement from their resident engineer sound from somewhere below deck,

along with a clatter as she no doubt scrambles to make her way up to the deck, but Catra ignores it. As long as the eccentric builder doesn't damage her ship, she doesn't care what she does.

"I've got him!" Scorpia's voice calls from the bow. Catra doesn't turn to look, focused on her task. She nods quickly to Bonnie at the helm as she crosses the quarterdeck to climb up onto the poop deck. Kyle is the only man on board. He will be easily swayed by the siren's song, but he alone isn't going to manage to sink the ship. He's here so they have someone easily restrained who can tell them what the siren is saying. Having a crew of immune women makes following their song harder.

Up on the poop deck is Entrapta's modified ballista. Capturing a siren is hard, but killing one is harder. Supposedly they can only be killed on land. Regardless, Shadow Weaver wasn't taking the risk. She gave Entrapta free reign to build her best siren-catching device, and she came up with this ballista, modified to shoot chain nets. It has a long line to allow them to haul the captured siren back up to their ship once she's wrapped in it.

"Bring him here!" Catra calls as she mans the ballista and does another sweep of the seas around them. The song sounds faint, but she doesn't know how far it carries. She can see a distant spot over the bow. Could the siren be lurking there, trying to run them aground on an island? In her periphery, Catra watches Scorpia haul a dazed Kyle across the open deck so he can be brought to where she doesn't have to shout. He isn't struggling, but Scorpia wisely restrains him anyway so Catra can interrogate him as she checks that the ballista is properly loaded.

"Can you hear her? What's she saying?" Catra asks, glancing at Kyle's expression as she prepares the ballista for firing. His eyes are hooded, but his pupils are expanding unnaturally quickly despite the glaring light of the sun beating down on the deck. He looks high as shit, or like a magicat that has just spotted a mouse. It's a ridiculous look on him. He turns his head, looking towards the bow. Catra's suspicion was correct.

"She's not saying anything, she's just singing. It's so beautiful. I want to hear more. Can we get closer? I want to see her," Kale says, his voice dreamy and wistful. It seems the siren has sung the gay right out of him. Catra will have to tell Rogelio about Kale turning into a tart for a bottom feeder the next time they dock. Sighing, she raises a hand and signals to Bonnie to lower the sails.

"Bring us towards the shore, but keep her slow! We just want to get close enough to get a shot. Ready the harpoons, but don't fire without my mark," Catra calls out. The entire crew, tense and waiting for orders, scrambles to follow them. Just because they're immune to sirens doesn't mean this isn't nerve-wracking. The creatures have sunk six ships this year, and four more had close encounters early on before they seemingly perfected their craft.

If Entrapta's ballista fails, they have the harpoons as backup. Failing at that, Catra has two pistols and deadeye aim. She'll happily put a test to the myth that the ocean magically heals fishfolk. Her hands remain steady as she takes up the handles of the ballista. Everyone eyes the sea around them as Bonnie brings them in slowly towards the island, growing larger before them. It appears to be dark and rocky, the perfect place to run a pirate aground.

Catra's distance vision might not be the best, but she's a predator, and she can pick up movement at a distance, especially the movements of something that doesn't belong. Something light – white, or yellow maybe, but sharply contrasting from the black cliffs of the island and darkness of the ocean – keeps surfacing every time the siren pauses its song to take a breath.

"Scorpia, shackle Kale so we don't have to worry about him," Catra orders before raising her voice to call her crew to attention. "We've got a pale one circling the island. Could be the siren that sunk the Devil's Mercy! Keep your eyes peeled when the song pauses. Bonnie, bring us in close enough to get a shot at her," she orders. She is met with a round of *ayes* that almost sound relieved. Any extra bit of information they have for this encounter makes it less

tense. Scorpia turns, dragging Kyle away towards the shackles already waiting at the railing.

With most of the sails lowered, they drift in slow to the island. Everyone is silent, tensely watching the ocean around them. The siren song can still be heard, the quality of it changing from apparent movement. It's *circling* them, like a predator tracking prey. Catra grits her teeth, pointing her ballista off the starboard side. With the siren circling like this, it is hard to aim for it, but Catra still doesn't *see* it. Its song is loud, beautiful and melodic, but it has an almost *insistent* quality to it.

"Please, we need to get closer! I need to see her. Bonnie, please!" Kyle begs. His shackles are metal and locked tight against the deck railing. He has no hope of breaking free and taking the controls for himself. Bonnie dutifully ignores him. The ship is almost at a standstill now, the island close enough for Catra to see the lichen and sea plants clinging to its rocks. Her heart beats in her ears alongside the pulsing siren song as the creature circles them, seemingly confused why they won't drown themselves.

Catra watches the water, but the siren isn't surfacing now. It's trying to get them to follow it. At the railing, Kyle struggles, beginning to beg Bonnie again to dash them against the rocks, but Catra ignores him. The rest of the crew waits, some at the sails and some at the railings, ready with their harpoons and scanning the waters. The song stops again. The fur on Catra's scruff bristles as she desperately scans the waters, searching for a pale shape-

On the left of the ship, a harpoon fires.

"I've got 'em!" Scorpia shouts, enthusiastic. The standoff ends, replaced with a scramble as everyone rushes to the port side of the boat. Catra curses, looking out over the railing, but apparently the mermaid is too close to the hull for the ballista to reach. The harpoons are aiming straight down as a second one fires, this time met with a splash and an ungodly screech. It feels like a knife in both

her ears. Catra abandons her post, rushing to the port side railing and looking down along with the rest of her crew.

The waters churn as a white tail with gold-dipped fins desperately beats against the side of the boat. The harpoon has speared through the siren's tail, blood running down its white scales as the crew works to haul on the two harpoon lines speared through it. Catra's heart is pounding, a sense of awe she wasn't expecting slowly dawning on her as she watches first the tail, and then the stomach and the torso of the creature emerge from the water.

It's topless, too savage to know to wear clothes. Its clawed hands are desperately trying to twist upward to cut at the lines. Catra catches sight of burning blue eyes and long, blonde hair, falling like a curtain down into the water beneath it as it is hauled fully out of the waters below, hissing and snarling like a beast. It doesn't just look like a woman. It looks like- she looks like-

The creature opens its mouth and unleashes a deadly screech. Catra, along with the rest of the crew, cries out and scrambles to cover her ears, screwing her eyes shut. The sound *hits* , like a spike being driven into her skull through each of her ears, no other sound penetrating through the note of ground glass against her ear drums. She gasps for air, every instinct in her body telling her to get away from that sound-

It cuts off. A moment later, she registers there was a splash, and the rest of her crew is groaning with pain. Catra opens her eyes, staring at the two blood-soaked harpoon spears hanging off the side of the ship that were in the siren. A small chunk of white-scaled flesh still clings to one. Blood smears on the side of the ship from its thrashing tail, but the creature is gone. Catra lowers her shaking hands from her ears. No song fills the air. Apparently the wretch knows when to run from a fight.

Catra swallows, her heart pounding as her crew slowly begins to recover around her. It seems this is going to be even harder than she anticipated.

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Catra's captain cabin isn't large. It's private and nicely-finished, which is better than the other crew quarters, but if Shadow Weaver had always intended for Catra to captain this ship, she probably would have had to built like a shack. As it is, the furniture is the bare minimum. Catra lays in her hammock that night and closes her eyes, imagining she's back in her and Adora's shared hammock. It seems magic really is torturing her – first it takes Adora from her, and now the first siren she encounters practically wears her face.

She didn't get a good look at it, Catra reminds herself. Surely the siren looks quite different when she isn't thrashing wildly. She matches the description of the siren two ships escaped from early on and that the Devil's Mercy later sunk too. All the others either didn't have survivors to tell the tale or didn't spot their seductor. It's possible that the Horde's sudden siren problem could be down to just one of the creatures moving into the area. That would be Catra's luck – there's no way Shadow Weaver would believe her that it's just one.

If Catra even manages to capture her, Shadow Weaver would probably grow furious when Catra fails to find another and take her ship command from her, if her crew doesn't do it first. Pirate ships are democracies to some degree. Part of what has made the Horde so successful is borrowing some of the structure and rank of a navy, but they wouldn't attract members if they didn't offer the perks of voting that the pirate life generally offers. If they find Catra to be an incompetent captain, they can always vote to replace her and take whatever retribution comes from the Horde for doing it while out at sea without approval.

Shadow Weaver always warned her that it would happen if she ever *did* give Catra the ship that she so desperately wanted. Catra and

Adora always wanted to be the captain and quartermaster of their own ship, but Shadow Weaver said she couldn't have a mutiny from Catra's poor leadership become a stain on Adora's record. Catra sighs, rolling over in her hammock. It isn't comfortable, but neither was her and Adora's old one. It's familiar, and that's the closest thing she has to comfort right now.

Seeing a siren with some of Adora's traits deeply unsettled her. Those creatures took Adora from her, they have no right to look so human, much less like her. Catra barely saw her. She doesn't know why she's so certain that she would see Adora in the creature. Her hair and skin – what parts of it weren't covered by scales, anyway – were the same color as Adora's, but Adora's eyes were never that blue, and she didn't have claws, fangs, or flared ears like a finfolk. They probably aren't even that similar.

It's a testament to how badly Catra's heart is aching for her missing lover. Any small thing reminds her of Adora. In the day she has to be a strong, capable leader, but at night, she wraps her arms around herself in her bed and dreams of the one person who she has ever trusted to hold her.

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"You and I both know what you're capable of at the helm," Catra tells Bonnie. Bonnie immediately scoffs, sending her a *not it* look.

"Flattery isn't going to make me know the Halfmoon better. It takes time to learn a ship. I'm not eager to play chicken with a cliff face," Bonnie returns. Catra's tail twitches, her annoyance rising, but she forces it down. She can't yell at her crew. Well, she can, but not about this and not right after a siren slipped through her fingers. She'd rather return to Shadow Weaver empty-handed than prove her right and have her crew mutiny beneath her.

"You aim for the side of the island. We cruise by, and I stand ready at the ballista. We'll never head straight for it, we just need to get close enough that I can get a shot. It has range. I have faith in your skills, Bonnie. You could pull this off even in a man-of-war. Halfmoon will manage. She's fast," Catra returns. Clearly the harpoons aren't going to be enough, not unless they catch the siren just right. They sailed away from the island after the siren encounter, but in the light of the next day, Catra has formed a plan.

She understands why Bonnie is dubious to return to face the cliffs head on like the siren *wants*, but this is their mission. They need to catch the siren, and that means getting close enough for the ballista net to be within range without having her so close to the hull that it blocks the net from reaching her. Swinging past the island quickly is their best bet. No one really knows how intelligent sirens are, but they're sentient, and Catra isn't going to take the risk on her recognizing them and fleeing – if she's even still there.

Bonnie looks dubious, but slowly, she nods. Catra grins, clapping her on the shoulder and squeezing. Captains have to be charismatic. If they come down hard on disobedience, they have to be equally rewarding of compliance. Hordak is an asshole, but the manpower he has thanks to the man-of-war he defected from the Primary Navy with is enough to sway people to his side by itself. Catra doesn't have that kind of power at her back. She has to make her people *like* her. It's the last thing that she feels up to after losing Adora, but it's a means to an end, and Catra has to avenge her.

"Good man. I know you can do it. Scorpia! Get the navy sails from below deck. It's time to dress Halfmoon up like someone she isn't," Catra says, praising Bonnie before she turns to call for her quartermaster. Scorpia immediately drops the bag she was carrying in her scramble to salute to Catra despite how it isn't necessary given the fact that Catra doesn't even *have* a rank within the Horde itself. Her captaincy is a fluke, but Scorpia has seemingly been so excited to get her shot at quartermastery that she has been ignoring that detail and sucking up to Catra like no other.

She definitely has a crush on her, but Catra really isn't prepared to deal with that. She has been propositioned a few times over the years, but she always swiftly turned them down. She couldn't say that she was already taken then and she can't say that she's widowed now. She isn't looking to fall into someone else's bed when she still imagines Adora's ghost lying in bed with her at night. The best she can do is discourage the attention while taking advantage of how eager to please Scorpia is.

"Aye, captain!" she calls cheerily, dropping her salute and hurrying to go get the Halfmoon's fake Primary Navy colors. They mostly use them to get close enough to strike, but in this case, Catra is hoping they will fool the siren into thinking they're a different ship until they get close enough to fire. Even a wild animal is likely to avoid a creature that has bitten them once already. Catra doesn't want her to spook when she sees them returning.

If the siren isn't there, they'll return to their aimless sailing through the areas of the sea that have seen an increase in siren activity, but Catra has high hopes for this plan. Maybe it's not that realistic, but she just *needs* to capture this siren in particular. If they get her into the tank downstairs, Catra can finally get a close look at her and confirm that she really doesn't look like Adora. Her mind is desperate and playing tricks – it has to be.

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The siren is there. Catra can see her seemingly sunning herself – or maybe laying down dead – on the rocks surrounding the island as the ship approaches. She gave the crew their orders while they were out of earshot. They're to continue their business up on the deck, but to be as silent as they can. Kyle is already shackled and gagged down below. Scorpia lies in wait near the stern with a harpoon, squatting out of sight, and Entrapta is crouched down near the bow

with a prototype of her hand-launcher. It doesn't have the same range as the ballista, but hopefully they won't need it.

Either the siren really is dead, or she just takes awhile to notice them. The white-and-gold form on the rocks doesn't move as the ship approaches the island. They're sailing a little too close for comfort to get within range, but Catra just has to hope there aren't any hidden rocks beneath the water's surface and that the siren isn't overly-cautious of another brigantine sailing unnaturally close to her island after the incident yesterday.

Catra has her ballista trained on the siren on the rocks, but its too far to risk the shot and blow their chances. Her crew are all exchanging glances down on the deck as they nervously go about their duties, guns and harpoons loaded but holstered as they wait for the signal. Catra watches the island grow nearer, the rocks coming into focus slowly. They're getting close now, the shadow of the mast stretching out towards the siren-

She jolts up, almost into a sitting position. Catra' s finger twitches on the trigger, but it isn't enough to accidentally fire. She holds her breath, sights trained on the siren as she stares up at the shadow of the ship beginning to loom over her. For a moment, they both hold deadly still, assessing their opponent. Then the siren suddenly launches forward, using her arms and the strength of her powerful tail to dive off the rock, towards the water. Catra scrambles, jerking the ballista to follow and yanking on the handles, firing half-blind.

"Harpoons!" she calls, the net going hurtling through the air towards the pale shape trying to dive beneath the waves. The tow line arcs over the side of the ship and then there's a warbling cry just as Entrapta and Scorpia leap up, the rest of crew scrambling for their weapons and towards the starboard side. Catra follows the rush, scrambling to lean over the rail and scan the sea.

Floating in the waves, between the ship and the rocks, is a writhing mass of white scales and splashing water. The siren moved quicker than Catra anticipated, getting close to the ship, but the modified

payload on the ballista was also heavier and dropped quickly. It was sheer fucking luck, but the siren is ensnared, at least partially. They have to act quick if they want to keep her that way, though. This is where they lost her before.

"Hold harpoons! We don't want to damage the net. Entrapta, chain her again, and Scorpia, ready the net! We need to get her on board quickly. Someone give me a hand with this tow line. And stop the ship!" Catra orders, gesturing in the air as she turns towards the line. Her crew scrambles to follow her orders, an excited murmur spreading through them. They aren't ready to cheer yet, but this shows promise.

Entrapta lines up her shot, sticking her tongue out a little as she does so, and fires. Angry screeching bellows out from the thrashing mass in the water below, but Catra watches this time as the net wraps around the struggling creature. The writhing doesn't stop, but she must be more restricted, because the splashing dies down. Catra lets out a breath as she reaches for the tow line to begin hauling the siren closer as Scorpia readies the net to lift her out of the water.

It's going to be a fight getting her below deck and muzzled, but it's time to finally see what they're dealing with.

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Getting the siren up on the deck is a process. It's like fighting a shark. Even with two chain nets wrapped around her, pinning her arms to her sides and limiting her movements, the creature has a powerful tail that she thrashes against the chains, and then against the metal wire net they lift her out of the water by. They learned their lesson last time of not just using the tow lines. She fights, trying to worm her way over to the edge of the net so she can flop down into

the water below. Catra swears as she yanks on the ballista tow line to once again pull her back from the edge of the net.

When she reaches the deck, the siren is hissing, singing, and *screaming*. Catra's head is ringing from the sound. Some of her crew are stumbling as they all hurry to get the siren down onto the deck. She flops against it with the clink of chains and a wet *thud* where she makes direct contact. For a moment, the air leaves her lungs, and the head-splitting sounds stop. Catra can finally relax a little, her arms burning from the fight of hauling her in. She doubles over with the tow line still in her hands, panting as she looks the siren up and down.

The tail is as big as a shark, white scales that catch the sun with a golden glint giving way to torso sculpted after a god. She is muscled and topless, her chest heaving as she lies on her stomach, gasping for air. Her arms, pinned against herself by the chains, fade to white at the wrists, with golden coloring at the fingertips and matching claws meant for eviscerating decorating each hand. Her enormous mass of golden-blonde hair, almost as long as her tail, reflects the sun almost blindingly as she seems to get her breath back and begins struggling again, wrapping herself in not only the net, but her own hair now.

She screeches again, that terrible ground-glass-on-ear-drums sound from their first encounter. Catra flinches, feeling herself whimper but unable to hear it over the screech. She can't let go of the tow rope and cover her ears like the rest of her crew, she has to hang on and keep the siren still. The siren writhes, fighting her restraints, but Catra doesn't let go, yanking on the tow rope and forcing her to awkwardly flop over onto her back. At last, they are face-to-face up close, and both of them freeze.

The screech dies. Catra registers the pain retreating vaguely, but her head doesn't stop pounding as she locks eyes with a vibrant blue set. The siren's mouth falls open in a gape as she stares back at Catra with the same recognition. Her hair is as big as Catra herself now, but it doesn't matter. The blue of her eyes is different, almost

glowing with magic, but it doesn't matter. She doesn't have legs anymore and her hands end in claws, but *it doesn't matter*.

She's different now, mythical and muscled and *magic*, but Catra has always known her better than she knew herself. Her hands shake as she drops the tow line, but the siren makes no move to escape now. Catra loves one woman in the world, and she knows her. This isn't just a siren – this is Adora. Catra swallows, reaching out almost absently and snatching the gun Bonnie has aimed at the siren out of her hand.

"Hey, she's still dangerous!" Bonnie protests, but Catra ignores her, walking forward with purpose so she can crouch over Adora. Adora watches her, eyes wide and transfixed as Catra crouches down to her level and reaches out with the barrel of the gun, tilting Adora's face up to the sun to get a better look at her within the net. Her ears are elongated, almost fins with a white fade at their tips, but despite all the changes, her face is the same. Catra glances down. And her tits. Her tits haven't changed either.

"Looks like you're mine now, Adora," Catra teases, seductive and sickeningly sweet from the *joy* pounding through her heart as she makes eye contact with her lost love again. She's purring, she realizes, as the siren flushes. That wide-eyed, turned-on expression could only be worn by Adora. Catra has heard of drowned women becoming sirens before, but she always put it in the *bullshit* column along with spirits. Now, the proof lies in front of her on the deck. Adora's cheeks blaze, her ears twitching as she swallows and then ever-so-slightly *nods*.

Catra doesn't know how much of Adora is inside this siren, but clearly she remembers Catra, and she isn't about to give that up. She grins, straightening up and turning the pistol to aim up at the sky as she holds it back out towards Bonnie. Her entire crew is gaping at her, seemingly too stunned to move, but then again, she did seemingly tame a siren with her presence alone. Adora is still, her tail thumping a little against the deck, but the movement is as if she is curious rather than trying to escape.

"Get this one away from me, ladies. This one won't give us anymore trouble. Scorpia, help me carry her down to the tank where she'll be more comfortable. The rest of you, let's get this ship swung back towards Sea Worthy. And someone uncuff Adora," Catra orders as Bonnie finally takes her gun back from her. The crew exchange glances, all seeming incredulous. Bonnie is the only one on deck who knew Adora before, and instead of staring at Catra, she stares at the siren, her mouth a bit agape.

"That can't be her," she whispers in shock. Catra makes burning eye contact with Adora. Her blue eyes practically pulse with magic as the sunlight glints blindingly off of her, like nature is telling Catra to look away and not examine her too hard, but Catra isn't taking her eyes off her lover for anything now that she's here before her. Adora hasn't said a word. Bonnie could be right that it isn't *really* Adora, but that's her body, and the siren has her memories, Catra is sure of that much. It's enough for her to hope.

"It is. Get her down to the tank so I can take these chains off of her," Catra returns. The rest of the crew looks nervous now, unaware of who Adora is or why she's so important, but after a moment of shifting awkwardly around them, Catra looks up and snaps, "Back to work! That's an order." Reluctantly, the crew begins to move, including Scorpia, who finally starts forward to lift Adora up and carry her below deck.

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"So, heh, you know a siren?" Scorpia tries, her voice cautious. Catra ignores her stumbling attempt at small talk, continuing to work on unwrapping Adora from the three nets trapping her. Adora seems happy to lay out on the floor of the cargo hold and let Catra work by the light of two lanterns hung on either side of the tank. Once she has Adora freed, she'll help her into it, but this has to be the priority.

The metal mesh cut her in a few places and Catra wants to get it off her as quickly as possible so she can assess her injuries.

"I mean, now I know why they put you in charge of the siren-hunting mission! I just thought it's something you would have mentioned. Useful inside knowledge and all," Scorpia continues, apparently undeterred by Catra's silence. Catra glares down at the net beneath her. She wants it off Adora. She wants Adora freed and *taking,* but the fact that she hasn't tried yet kind of tells Catra all she needs to know about Adora's ability to do so anymore without it coming out as an ungodly screech.

That's going to make it harder to figure out what the hell is going on, but right now Catra's priority is freeing Adora. She can't imagine having to untie a siren that was fighting her the whole way. If there are others in the area, she doesn't know how the hell they're going to capture them and go about getting them in the tank, but Catra is careful not to damage the metal net so they can reuse it as she finally frees Adora from her first layer.

"There you go. Feel better?" she asks her , ignoring Scorpia still standing in the doorway. Adora blinks up at the ceiling, lifting her head to look down. Carefully, she rolls to the side, rolling herself off the metal mesh entirely and sighing with relief. The grateful look she sends Catra is so painfully familiar it makes her heart stutter, a small breath escaping her before she gets ahold of herself and moves to follow Adora so she can untangle her chains now.

"Um, so, the muzzle?" Scorpia tacks on, a bit weakly . She sounds at a loss for words. Catra sighs, turning her head to glare at Scorpia. Scorpia is appropriately cowed, pushing off from where she was awkwardly leaning against the doorframe and hurrying to stand at attention. "Not that I'm questioning your judgement, captain! Just asking if I should go fetch it, sir! Ma'am! Uh-" Scorpia scrambles. On the floor, Adora snorts, eyeing the scorpioni with seeming amusement. Catra sighs, exasperated as she turns back to Adora and carefully shifts a chain off her shoulder.

"The only person she can sway on board is Kyle, and he's not even strong enough to turn the wheel most days. She's not going to hurt us, anyway. Now go change the colors back to the Horde's and make sure we're on a course for Sea Worthy. We need to find out where the Black Garnet is and pay her a visit before we return to our mission," Catra orders. In truth, she has no idea if there's more mission to go on, but either way Shadow Weaver will want to know about her protégé being turned into a siren.

Just days ago, Catra was thinking about how she had no power on her own. Hordak has a man-of-war that makes people sit up and take notice of him, but even he will have to fear a siren. If Adora didn't lose herself to whatever magic took her over – and it doesn't seem like it from how she grabs Catra's hand and holds it when it passes close enough to her pinned arm to do so – then she will probably follow Catra's orders. They might finally have a bargaining chip. How much is Hordak willing to give to have a siren on his side?

"Uh, yes, sir. Right away," Scorpia responds, saluting and holding it for a long time. Catra doesn't acknowledge her. Eventually Scorpia gives up, dropping the salute and turning away to actually follow through on the orders. Catra waits until she is gone, her footsteps audible on the deck above, to drop both her hands to each of Adora's. In the dark of the cargo hold, with the ship swaying around them, Adora takes her hands in her own once more. Catra lets out a shaking breath, looking up to make eye contact with her glowing, unnatural blue.

The colour may be different, but Adora's passion isn't as she smiles to Catra encouragingly, struggling to sit up a little with the chains still half wrapped around her. Catra pulls on her hands, helping her up. Once upright, her heart skips a beat as Adora leans forward and nuzzles their cheeks together. Adora is wet, smearing ocean water and salt against Catra's cheek, but she doesn't care, not when Adora finishes the movement by turning her head and kissing Catra just like she used to.

The kiss is gentle, soft and so *loving*. Adora's embraces were always the gentlest touches that Catra ever felt. Adora kisses her the same way now despite how she has apparently risen from the dead since their last embrace. The how and why doesn't matter, not when Catra can hold her again. Catra may be a pirate who hates water and doesn't know how to swim, but she'll do just about anything to have Adora back in her life, magic siren or not. They'll work it out.

Adora pulls back, falling back against the floor with a wet thud. She smiles up at Catra, obviously pleased. Catra swallows, smiling back at her, though hers is smaller. This is a lot to take in for her. With Adora not talking, Catra's mind is already spiraling worrying how much of Adora was lost in the transformation. From the kiss, Catra is at least certain that this *is* Adora, but how much does she remember? She was luring ships to their death. She could be half-animal for all Catra knows now.

After a slow breath, she returns to unchaining Adora. Those worries can't be her primary concern right now. If Adora could speak, she would have done it up on the deck. They'll have to find a way to communicate, and that will take time. Adora is bleeding right now, and that has to be Catra's priority. Adora lies happily on the floor of the cargo hold and lets her work.

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This ship is the smallest one Shadow Weaver had available that could support a tank of this size in addition to the usual supplies. Catra opens the hatch and helps Adora haul herself up and into it by her arms. If the siren they had captured was fighting them, the crew would be helping her, but Catra wants to be alone with Adora. She watches her lover sink into the water with relief, a trail of air bubbles breaking the surface from her happy sigh. The tank is probably the siren equivalent of a fishbowl, but it has to be better than the dry

deck surface. Carefully, Catra climbs down the scaffolding and looks inside.

The dim lantern light glints off of Adora's white and golden scales. The few cuts the mesh left trail tendrils of blood like jellyfish tentacles as she calmly moves through the water. Her large eyes glow a hypnotic blue in the low light. She slowly blinks at Catra through the glass. Catra remembers the writhing, screaming *monster* of earlier and finds no trace of her in the beautiful mermaid before her, her plumed tail slowly moving through the water.

Adora opens her mouth, but no words come out. She *sings*. It isn't the same sound that tried to lure them to their doom yesterday. It is a beautiful, high note, almost human and yet beyond their capabilities. The sound of an angel, perhaps. The pitch rises and falls like a melody, eerie and effervescent as Catra raises a hand and places it against the glass. Adora mirrors her action, the tone of her song almost mournful as it trails off into silence.

Only in its absence does Catra realize the sound made the fur on the back of her neck bristle. She didn't understand the message, but it clearly isn't meant to be speech, at least not in any language known to her. She swallows, looking down at their hands separated by the glass. It is only beginning to sink in that Adora really is here – Catra isn't *alone* anymore – but she already knows that she will do absolutely everything to keep them together from now on.

"You can still understand me, at least. We'll figure this out," Catra assures her, her voice quiet. On the other side of the glass, Adora gazes back at her with soft, hopeful eyes, nodding eagerly as she slowly beats her tail to get her entire body closer to the glass. Catra glances down her body and realizes the shallow wounds are already healing over before her eyes. There is no trace of a scar from where harpoons speared her just two days ago.

"What happened to you, Adora?" Catra asks, her tone as desperate as she feels. Adora just looks back at her with soft, mournful eyes. She can't answer.

Chapter End Notes

I've done research on boats, but I'm not going to use a lot of vernacular because while Catra should know it, I also want this fic to be readable for the average person. I've also done research on pirates/the era I'm drawing inspiration from, but I make no claims of attempting historical accuracy.
I've done this for some shorter fics before, but this fic is going to switch off POVs for each chapter, following Catra for this first chapter and Adora for the second, etc.
The chapter count on this is just a rough estimate. I've also rated this as M because I have no explicit smut planned, though there will be sexual content throughout the fic.

Adora the Siren

Chapter Notes

> If you're looking for a moral high ground, you won't find it in this fic. Adora and Catra were raised as pirates lmao.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She drowned. Adora wants to just say that, to tell Catra the truth about every minute they have been apart, but she can't speak anymore, at least not with words. She knows only songs. Catra stays with her for a while, watching as Adora presses herself up against the tank, swims in circles in the small space, and then sets to detangling her hair with her claws. Eventually a call above deck causes Catra to twitch her ears and she looks up, looking back down to Adora with a sigh.

"I've got to go check on my crew . I'll be back once I'm sure things are settled. Can you avoid singing? It' s going to freak them out. We have a mutiny and I really don't want them to try to use it on you," Catra tells her. Adora pouts at the mention of Catra leaving and then cringes when the image of a siren *mutiny* forms in her mind. She nods, abandoning her quest to unknot her hair for a moment so she can press her hand against the glass again. Catra raises her own hand, mirroring the gesture. Her expression is pained.

"I'll be back as soon as everything is in order and we're headed back towards Seaworthy," Catra promises her , taking a reluctant step back and turning away to collect one of the lanterns beside the tank. Adora has night vision to rival Catra's own now, but she is grateful that Catra leaves her a lantern as she sends one last glance her way and then disappears into the rest of the cargo hold. Adora wilts a little with her lover departed, sinking down in the tank. Sullenly, she returns to detangling her hair with her fingers.

Normally it doesn't knot, but being up on the deck was bad for her in a number of ways. She doesn't know how or why Catra is here, commanding a ship with a tank and supplies for siren hunting, but they're reunited, no matter how unpleasant the moment before they realized who they were each facing down was. Adora isn't used to using her newly-bestowed magic for healing and she feels tired. She has enough left in her magic reserves for a few more tricks, but she and Catra are going to have to figure out how to communicate before Adora's magic gets too low.

She doesn't know what Catra's plan is here, but she would guess this tank doesn't exist for the off-chance that Adora was turned into a siren rather than drowned. Something – or someone – else is meant to go here, and Adora can't stay comfortable in such a small space for long anyway. She'll have to start using her magic just to heal her cramped body. If Catra can get a more comfortable net to haul her up to the deck with, then Adora will be far better off just following along the side of the boat and climbing aboard when she wants to touch Catra – although that's kind of *a*

She has been searching for her for weeks. She will forever be grateful to Mara for giving her the kiss of life and turning her into a siren instead of letting her drown with the rest of her ship, but the distance that now being a creature of the sea enforces between them is going to be hard. Luckily, Catra is a pirate and sailor through-and-through. She might not know how to swim and be afraid of the ocean, but that just means she's braver than every other sailor, conquering her fear everyday like she does.

Catra doesn't know anything else. She is going to spend her life out at sea, so Adora can spend hers following her, and if Catra does happen to get shipwrecked, Adora will be right there beside her to save her. The whole reason she was targeting horde ships was in search for Catra. There isn't any way for a siren to communicate other than a song, at least not without stealing a voice, and so all she could do was call out to horde ships and hope she stumbled upon Catra.

She knew it was a slim chance – Catra had been stationed on the Black Garnet her entire life thus far – but every time she saw a Horde ship she had to try. After seeing everything the Horde is capable of, they were one of the few ships she didn't feel guilty sinking, and it let her take inventory of those on board to make sure Catra didn't count among them. Besides, she needed the magic she gained from eating the sailors. She needs to make sure she always has enough stored to save Catra if needed.

Catra is giving a speech above deck right now. Adora can hear it distantly, but between the two decks over her head and the water in the tank, she has no idea what it is about. She recognizes her lover's tones and that's it. There are other voices, piping up with what seem to be questions, but any specifics are lost. Hair untangled, Adora swims idly in a loop around the tank. It really is small. Brigantines are built to be quick, but Adora can now easily outstrip this ship swimming alongside it. It wouldn't even be difficult to keep up with, and she'd had room to move.

If it sinks while she's in this tank, she might not be able to escape it in time to kiss Catra. The kiss of life was the worst kiss Adora has ever had in her life – even her and Catra's first kiss at thirteen, clumsy and harsh enough that Adora ended up with a bloodspot on her lip afterwards, was better than being drowned – but Adora will give it to Catra if it ever becomes necessary. Mara breathed magic into her at the last second, giving her life again, but up until that moment the kiss felt like dying – it was dying.

Adora isn't eager to do it to Catra, but at least then they could be together in the same environment and un-life again. Catra's speech is still going. Adora swims to the tank's hatch – by which she means she barely beats her tail one and she has reached it in the small space – and reaches up to press against it. Latched shut. Yeah, that's going to be a problem. The tank is already feeling suffocating for more reasons than just the small size. She just has to hope that Catra returns soon.

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It's hard to tell time down in the hold – there's no windows and the crew deck above her filters out the daylight on the main deck – but Catra must not come back for an hour or two, maybe even three. Adora sees someone come down to the cargo deck through the open doorway, but all she sees is distant movement, some things being hauled around, and then the footsteps retreat. Eventually, another set of footsteps approaches and Catra rounds the corner, entering the tank room again. Adora instantly perks up, rising in the tank and pressing insistently against the hatch, sending Catra a pleading look.

Catra's eyes are greedy, roaming over Adora as she saunters into the room with a lantern in-hand. She hangs it on the wall before approaching the tank, but she never takes her eyes off Adora, as if she can't stand to look away again. Adora doesn't want anything to separate them again – despite meeting other sirens over the last few months, she has been lonely and hollow without Catra – but she also wants the hatch open. She pulls her hand back and pounds against it once insistently. Catra's ears twitch, swiveling back to listen for something as she quickly shakes her head.

"Shh, don't do that. The crew is already uneasy about you being down here. I need you to be the model prisoner if we don't want a mutiny on our hands, alright? I managed to pump them full of euphoria over capturing a siren, but they aren't happy about my decision to leave you unmuzzled. They don't believe you remember who you are," Catra tells her as she hangs the lantern and approaches the tank. Adora frowns. None of that is good news – especially not the word *prisoner* – but if Catra needs her to reign herself in to make the rest of the crew comfortable, she can do that.

She has all new instincts to go with her transformation – she *eats popcorn* now, there have been a lot of changes over the last few months – but she is still herself, no more wild than Catra is. She

knows she would be dubious if her captain promised her that the siren in the hold wasn't going to be a problem. The only man she spotted on board was male, so this particular ship doesn't have much to worry about, but she supposes she could sing and lure another ship to crash into them to free herself. Adora doesn't particularly care what they're worried about, not when Catra is climbing the scaffolding at the side of the tank and sliding open the lock on the hatch.

She eagerly reaches up, forcing the hatch open before Catra can even reach to do it herself. Catra blinks down her, surprised, before her expression softens into a smile and she settles down to sit on the steps so she can be right beside the hatch. Adora eagerly pulls herself up by her arms through the hatch. It takes some wiggling and arranging, but eventually she ends up with her torso out of the water, dropping her head into Catra's lap and trilling happily when Catra allows it despite her wet hair trailing down into the tank along with her tail. Catra hates the water, but she *smiles* down at Adora as Adora settles into her softness.

Adora has missed embracing her lover like nothing else. She sighs, her eyes falling closed as she breathes in Catra's familiar scent. It's a bit different now, but so are her senses themselves, so she just might be able to pick up on layers to it that she couldn't before. She nestles into Catra, her heartrate slowing as a quiet peace spreads through her. If she had the words to, she would tell Catra that she loves her and assure her how much she has missed her, but sirens can't speak on their own. The other sirens told her how to steal a voice, but she hasn't done it yet.

She didn't have enough magic for it for a long time and it was low on her priority list compared to finding Catra again. Now she wishes she had prioritized it higher. Her only thoughts were *find Catra*. She didn't consider the confusion once she succeeded. Adora turns her head to rest her cheek against Catra's lap so she can look up at her. Catra's expression is pinched. Adora can see the love in her eyes that Catra

has always looked at her with, but she can also see her wondering – and, likely, *crying*.

Adora gives a small, gentle trill that makes Catra both smile a little with amusement and deepen her frown. She thinks the sound is cute, probably, but it showcases the changes that have happened since they were last together. Carefully, Catra reaches down and pets over her wet hair. Adora's eyes slip closed without her meaning for them too, her entire body crying out with relief at the touch. She has been starved for Catra's embrace after all this time at the bottom of the sea. She nuzzles up into the touch, chasing the affection. Catra's next breath is a little sharp.

"I can't believe you're swimming around naked like an idiot," Catra says, her tone teasing, but emotion lurks behind it. Adora opens her eyes to make eye contact with Catra. Her gaze is searching. So much is different and she wants to know why. Adora wants to open her mouth and just *speak*, but she has tried already, and all that comes out is unnatural screeching. It would hurt Catra's ears and upset the crew. Catra sighs, her gaze trailing down Adora's body to where her tail disappears into the tank.

"Do you think you could hold a pen with your fingers webbed now? I need to *know*," Catra asks her, her gaze desperate as she meets Adora's eyes again. Adora swallows, pressing the side of her cheek harder down into Catra's lap just to feel Catra beneath her. She doesn't want her to leave to get fetch paper and ink to find out. At the same time, Adora knows how lost and useless she would be feeling if this had happened to Catra instead. She would want to do anything she could to understand and help.

The problem is she doesn't really know the answer. She shrugs a little. She used to have beautiful penmanship. It was something Shadow Weaver always complimented her on, preferring it over Catra's blocky scrawl. Catra tried to change her handwriting to make it more similar to Adora's – to what Shadow Weaver wanted – but Shadow Weaver always sneered at it and called it a poor imitation. Catra sighs, frustrated, looking away towards the darkness of the

cargo hold. Adora bites her lip with her sharp teeth. Her teeth are fangs to match Catra's own now.

Actually, she has claws to match Catra's too. Adora pulls back a little, instantly pulling Catra's attention back to her. Catra's eyes lock onto her, burning as she watches Adora sink down a little into the tank so she has one hand free to lay on its surface and gently scratch at it. Adora looks up, meeting Catra's eyes and silently begging her to understand. Catra frowns, her gaze flicking between Adora's hand and her face, but no light of realization dawns in her eyes. Frustration bubbles in Adora, but she shifts her hand to the edge of the metal hatch and focuses.

Painstakingly, she carves the letters of Catra's name with her index claw. She doesn't know why sirens carve things, but they just do. After Mara drowned her, she brought her to a community on the ocean floor to learn about what she was now before she would let Adora set out on her journey to reunite with her lover. The rock surfaces in Salineas were carved with decoration, murals, and words in varying languages. Adora herself carves now, almost absently, often into bones.

It just feels right. She might not have the fingers to easily wield a pen– it would be difficult to not soak the paper anyway – but she can still communicate. She looks up, making pointed eye contact with Catra again as Catra frowns and leans forward. The light must finally catch her carving right, because she watches understanding and then subsequent excitement blossom in Catra's eyes. She lights up, her eyes snapping to Adora's to make eye contact with her again.

"Can you carve into wood?" she asks. Adora scoffs, a sound not dissimilar to Catra's chuffs. She sends Catra a look that makes it clear that would be insultingly simple. If she can manage solid rock, she thinks she can manage a piece of lumber. Catra grins, shifting to pull away and make her way back down to the floor. "Wait here," she orders. As much as Adora doesn't want Catra to leave, she nods, settling back down into her tank. Catra rushes off, eager for them to be able to communicate.

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The first thing Catra asks her is if she remembers everything. Adora doesn't need to carve to answer that, she just nods. Catra bites her lip, seeming unsure. Clearly she wants to believe Adora, but she is torn on it. Adora looks down at the wood cutting Catra brought her, thinking over what is relatively quick to carve that she could use to show she didn't lose herself in the ocean. After a moment of hesitating, she settles on *Emi e* .

When she turns the wood to show Catra what she has done, she watches her eyes go wide and her tail lash to the side before wrapping around her legs as if to soothe herself. Catra draws in a sharp breath, emotion heavy in her eyes. She reaches for Adora, taking her hand in her own and squeezing for several long moments to ground herself. Adora squeezes back, mentally lamenting the fact that they can't lace their fingers together, but at least they can have this. After a few moments of steadying breathing, Catra seems ready to continue.

"How'd this happen?" she asks softly . Adora's heart sinks. That's hard to answer, at least in carving. How does she explain that every being in the universe has a tiny spark of magic, of life? That women naturally carry more within themselves that makes them immune to siren songs? That sirens are capable of sharing their magic and transforming others through the worst kiss in history? That Adora spent just long enough at the bottom of the sea to understand herself before she went chasing after her lover?

She takes awhile to carve a few key phrases. *Sea* and *drowned* and *adme* . The addition of *shi ngf ou* at the end might not be as necessary, but she needs Catra to know it. She can't imagine what the last few months have been like, knowing that Adora's ship sank or disappeared and they might never see each

other again. Catra's eyes go wide when she reads the last part, her breath hitching a little before her eyes snap up to hungrily roam over Adora's face, as if searching for confirmation that her carving is truthful.

"All the Horde ship sinkings? Was that all you?" Catra asks, a bit breathless. There's no way for Adora to know that for sure – Salineas isn't close, but it isn't far either, and anyone could have wandered this way – but she nods. She is sure that Catra is referring to her spate of sinkings as she searched for her. Catra looks somewhat touched. "Shadow Weaver put together this crew to hunt the sirens harassing us. She thinks selling their heads will fetch a small fortune," Catra tells her. Adora cringes, recoiling a little. Catra rolls her eyes, thudding her tail once against the scaffolding.

"Obviously I'm not going to let them kill *you*. We lost a lot of people, Adora, she was getting desperate. But I need to tell her about you. The crew is uneasy. If I bring you back and convince her we have a siren on our side, she'll call off the hunt and ban them from hurting you," Catra tells her. Adora bites her lip, but after a moment, she nods. She's a siren now. She's practically immortal. Piracy and wealth feel unimportant now, and after her experience as quartermaster on a Horde vessel, she wouldn't call herself a believer in the cause regardless.

No matter how she feels about it, she is sticking with Catra, so as long as Catra is a captain in the Horde, Adora is stuck with them. It would be advantageous anyway. Shadow Weaver can get a no-kill rule issued across the entire Horde fleet for the white-and-gold siren. Adora has been shot at by pissed off Horde captains enough for her to want that, and it would be logical for Shadow Weaver to court the favor of a siren who might be convinced to not only leave her ships alone, but sink others for her.

"I'll take care of you, Adora. I won't let anyone hurt you. We'll dock at Seaworthy to find out where the Black Garnet is right now, and then we'll head straight there," Catra assures her, reaching out to pet her hair. Adora leans into the touch eagerly. She's starved for Catra's

affection after all this time. She can tell that Catra is going through the same thing, but it's hard for Adora to touch her when she's in this tank. It would be far easier if Catra was on land at a coast, or down in a small boat on the water. All she wants to do is cuddle, but she has other needs she has to communicate.

Open, she carves into the wood and then pointedly drums on the open hatch of the tank as she shows it to Catra. It takes Catra a second to realize, but she cringes and nods. Adora's biggest priority is making sure that she can get out of the tank if something happens and she needs to, but the water in the tank is already suffocating. As long as the hatch stays open, she can surface and easily breathe in the air she needs, but she can't do that when it's latched shut. The water can't reoxygenate with it closed either.

"I'll leave the hatch open from now on and inform the crew it should stay that way. You may lose some water if the seas get rough, though," Catra promises her. Adora nods. She doesn't mind that. She takes her log back, carefully carving, *need to have voice*. It takes so long to communicate this way, and there's only so much room on the wood to carve legibly. When Catra reads it, Adora watches her eyes go wide and excitement perk her up.

"Will you be able to talk then?" she questions, looking up to meet Adora's eyes eagerly. She's *hungry* to be able to talk again. Adora nods, watching Catra draw in a quick breath in response. "How do you do it?" she asks. Adora cringes a little. Reluctantly, she adds to the carving: *kill*. It's more complicated than that, she needs to have enough magic stored and the other sirens mentioned something about needing time to adjust and make it her own, but she can tell Catra all that once she has it. Catra's mouth presses into a grim line as she reads the word.

"A woman, I assume? Preferably a human?" she asks. Adora nods reluctantly. She doesn't know if species matters, but it will probably be best to stick to a human anyway. She didn't exactly expect Catra to be disgusted by her, but she's still surprised when Catra just nods, matter of fact. "We'll find you someone in Seaworthy. Shouldn't be

too difficult to find a scumbag you won't feel too guilty about there," Catra tells her. Adora blinks in surprise at her for a long moment before she slowly nods back.

She wasn't expecting that, but she's grateful. It seems her lover is as eager to get them back to something approaching normal as she is. Slowly sinking down into the water, Adora trills to herself quietly. The corner of Catra's lips quirk up, but the conflict that was there the last time Adora trilled has lessened. They have a path forward – they'll make this work.

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Catra promises Adora she doesn't want to leave her for a second, but she's the captain and she has duties on the ship. She has to leave, and more painfully, she has to sleep elsewhere.

"The crew already doesn't trust this call. They'll think I've gone mad if I abandon my quarters to sleep down here with you. It's just until we meet with Shadow Weaver and she puts out the protection order," Catra assures her before she leaves that night. Adora understands her logic, but she still whines involuntarily as Catra pulls away. She hates watching Catra leave. She hates the small tank down in the hold. She's with Catra, but they're kept separated by the glass and water.

It's miserable, but she keeps reminding herself it's temporary. The hatch isn't enough for much oxygen to get in the water. Adora spends most of her time with her arms hooked over the edge of the hatch so her head is above water and she can breathe through her nose, absently beating her tail in the water beneath her. She can only pull oxygen from the water if it's there to begin with. The ocean water they filled the tank with is long dead by now, stagnant and depleted of air.

Adora hears bits and pieces of the lecture Catra gives the crew in the morning about the siren being a valuable asset against other ships and Adora needing air that she can't breathe without the tank open – there's a threat in there as well about how Adora's worth more than anyone on board can dream of and how Catra will extract payment in flesh if that money is lost to her – so Adora isn't too worried about someone closing the tank on her, but she still feels a spike of concern when she notices someone else lurking in the cargo hold shortly after, watching her.

The spike lessens when she realizes it's *Kyle*. She blinks at him, surprised to find him eying her from a dark corner of the cargo hold. He would be completely hidden from a human's sight, but Adora hasn't been human in months. She feels suddenly self-conscious about her nakedness for the first time. It never mattered when she was down in the ocean – the only people who saw her did it in the seconds before their last moments – but it's different when it's someone she used to know before.

Adora has her arms hooked over the edge of the tank, but she shifts to fold them over her chest and sends a glare Kyle's way. Kyle clearly realizes he is caught. He squeaks, scrambling out of sight. Adora sighs, hunching her shoulders. She knows he probably didn't care about her nakedness – the boy is almost as gay as she is – but it still feels weird to have him looking. After a moment, Kyle remerges from the darkness, this time stepping nervously into the doorway of the tank room. He is looking down at his feet.

"I wasn't, um, trying to be creepy. I just wanted to check on you. When you sang before, I could hear it, and it was weird having someone else in my head like that. It was hard to believe it was you," he explains clumsily, glancing up at her face to gauge her reaction as he talks, but he mostly keeps his gaze fixed down, apparently as aware of her nakedness as she is. Adora can't help but cringe a little. It was *terrifying* when Mara began to sing and her entire crew suddenly turned as one around her.

Adora tried to fight them, but she was the only woman on board. Rank meant nothing to them. Before she could assess where the siren was and fire on her to hopefully end the song, she found herself swarmed. The crew, already resistant to such a young – and female – quartermaster, realized she was going to try to stop them from following the siren. They attacked her and threw her overboard before she ever had a chance.

She can't imagine what it is like to have that compulsion in your own head – at least afterwards, when you come back to yourself. She wants to tell Kyle she isn't going to hurt him or make him hurt others, but the best she can do is press her lips together and stay silent, sending him a pleading look. He glances up, catching it and holding her gaze for a long moment before looking away again, clearing his throat and shifting awkwardly.

"I know you probably can't speak without influencing me. So, uh, thanks for not doing that. You were just looking for Catra, weren't you?" he says. Adora blinks at him, surprised, but she nods. She doesn't think even Catra realized that until Adora told her. Kyle grew up as powder monkey with them, alongside Bonnie and Rogelio, who seems to be missing. He, like everyone else who got within eyeshot of them, knows how Adora feels about Catra. Their relationship might have been secret, but their feelings never could be.

"I'll see if we have any scraps I can make some clothes for you from. The others didn't know you before, but I believe that you won't hurt us," Kyle tells her, awkwardly shuffling backwards and waving as he speaks. He's trying to make a clean getaway and failing. Adora shifts a little, keeping one arm braced across her chest and raising her other hand to wave goodbye to him, offering him what she hopes is a warm smile. It seems to galvanize him at least. Kyle beams back before he turns and climbs out of the cargo hold.

That was certainly *interesting*. Adora doesn't know how she feels about clothes – the other sirens didn't wear them and hers quickly tore and disintegrated in the water – but she would like to be covered for as long as she is going to be in this tank, so if Kyle actually does

return to bring her something, she'll probably take him up on it. She certainly doesn't want the people she *doesn't* know on board to come and gawk at her while she's caged and topless.

She takes a breath and sinks down into the suffocating water. She has to balance breathing with not drying out right now. Catra is doing something above deck, probably, but she hopes she'll come visit her soon. Maybe once Adora is covered Catra will be willing to let her out to swim alongside the ship. Adora has a feeling Catra won't want her to see the light of day until then.

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Catra materializes shortly after he leaves, looking worried.

"What do you eat now? Meat?" she asks. Adora pauses. Right, she's been in here for at least half a day. A human would certainly be hungry by now. Adora is okay, she could last for weeks on her current magic stores, actually, but she'd prefer not to use those for something so frivolous. *Meat* isn't exactly accurate, but she nods. Adora's carving log is sitting on the floor of the room, but she doesn't know how to carve something that conveys her current dietary needs anyway.

Catra disappears back into the hold. Adora calls after her with a quiet trill that sounds more sad than she intended, but she doesn't want Catra to go when she just returned. Luckily, Catra returns quickly, carrying dried and salted meat. Adora realizes her mistake, wrinkling up her nose and sinking down into the tank. Catra furrows her brow, looking at the meat in her hand and then at Adora. She holds the meat out, apparently trying to wave it enticingly before her, but Adora rolls her eyes and looks away.

"Oh, come on, don't tell me it has to be *alive*," Catra scoffs, her tone somewhat teasing. Adora turns her head and makes eye contact with her, watching Catra's expression slowly lose its amusement as she realizes. "*Seriously*?" she asks. Adora cringes a little, but she nods. Alive is a lot simpler to say than explaining that she needs their soul, not their flesh. Every creature has a small spark of magic in it, but dead things don't keep theirs. Catra looks down at the meat in her hand and then looks back to Adora.

"How often do you need to eat? Are you hungry?" she asks. Adora shakes her head and then holds up her hands and counts up to four on her fingers. Catra raises a brow at her, sending her a look that tells Adora what she thinks of her charade skills. "Every four days?" she asks, sounding incredulous. Adora shakes her head, waving her hand vaguely. "Every few days," Catra amends, her tone no less disbelieving. Adora grimaces, nodding and then shaking her head. Catra is half there, but she looks befuddled.

"Every few hours," she tries. That would be more reasonable for most animals, but no. Adora sends her a withering look that she hasn't earned, but it tells her that she's getting further off. Catra stares at her. "Don't tell me we're talking weeks," she returns. Adora feels herself light up, nodding quickly. Catra gapes at her. Adora just shrugs. When you eat a ship full of souls at a time, it lasts. It's been a few weeks already, but she can go for longer if she needs to.

After a moment of staring, Catra shakes her head with disbelief, reaching up with her free hand to push her mane back. Her red bandana mostly keeps it out of her face, but she tends to smooth her hair when she needs to think. She looks down at the meat in her head with a twist to her mouth and then shrugs, taking a bite of it herself. She looks thoughtful as she chews. Adora swims a slow, short lap around the tank, coming to rest right in front of Catra again. Catra sighs when she finishes eating chewing, shrugging a little.

"We're only a week away from Seaworthy. Can you manage that? We can try to fish something along the way too," Catra tells her. Adora nods. Most animals don't have enough magic to be worth the

trouble, but her magic stores will easily last her until she gets her hands on a voice anyway. She doesn't want Catra to worry too much when she'll be okay. She swims up to the hatch, just about out of air in the small tank, but she also wants to touch Catra.

Catra quirks a smile, moving to climb up the scaffolding. She settles beside the hatch, chewing on the meat that has now become her lunch as Adora settles with her head in Catra's lap again. Catra pets over her wet hair with her free hand, no care for how wet Adora is getting her clothes as long as they're cuddling. Catra spends her lunch cuddling Adora and for a few minutes, despite the awkward position, it's almost like old times again.

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Adora is *dying* in the small tank. Not literally, but maybe. There's no air, no room to maneuver, and though it takes a day or two, slowly but surely the rest of the crew begins filtering down to gawk at her, though they don't dare to do much more than stare and whisper to one another before they return to their duties. Adora is grateful that one of her first visitors amongst the crew was Bonnie, with Kyle in tow, carrying his attempt to make siren clothes from their limited supplies on board.

The top is basically a rag with line attached, but it covers her chest without getting close enough to her neck to risk suffocating her gills – not that they're much use to her in the dead water of the tank anyway – so Adora will take it. It won't hold up for long, but given that she's hardly moving in the cramped space, it's not getting a lot of wear on it. She's grateful to be covered when Catra's crew slips down to gawk at her. Catra spends a lot of time down in the hold with her, but she has duties.

When Catra is by her side, it's easy to get caught up in her presence, or in frustration over the physical gap between them now. When she's alone, Adora feels like she is trapped in a fishbowl. On the third day, she carves *I entrim* into her log and desperately shows it to Catra. To her disappointment, Catra frowns, clearly not understanding, and looks down into the tank. Adora sighs, gesturing out towards the cargo hold and then pointing up at the deck above them.

Carving takes time, and they don't just have a ton of wood lying around for Adora to mark up anyway. She is mostly reliant on charades. Catra knows her, and she guesses the general pantomimes quickly, but there isn't a good way to convey the answers to most of Catra's questions now. Something as simple as *hedek* however, Catra gets. Adora watches Catra's eyes widen with realization. For a moment, victory sparks in her chest, but to her dismay, Catra's ears pin back and she quickly turns her face away.

Adora frowns, fighting the feeling of dread threatening to rise in her chest. There has to be a reason why Catra is looking like that. There's no reason to jump to conclusions, but Adora's heart is already racing. Catra understands that Adora wants out, and for some reason, she doesn't want to give it to her. Catra shifts, turning a little to turn her back to Adora. Adora gives a gentle, questioning chirrup. Catra's ears twitch, but she hunches her shoulder and wraps her tail around herself, not turning back around.

"The crew would lose it. They already don't feel safe with you locked in the hold. If I let you out, they would throw us both overboard and run off with the ship before you could start singing," Catra says, her voice tense. Adora feels a bitter taste rise in her throat. That isn't *all*. Catra has never given a single shit what others think. Democracy or no, Shadow Weaver placed Catra in charge of this ship. The Horde allows voting, but at the end of the day, Hordak and Shadow Weaver's word is law. If you've got a problem with that, you can go back to scraping by without their fleet backing you. Mutinies are rare.

Adora lets out a low hiss. The noise is quiet, but insistent. Catra's shoulders just hunch further. Catra is definitely worried about what the crew thinks – she has talked about it a *lot* for some reason, despite how out of character it is for her to worry about other's opinions – but that isn't the reason why she's reluctant. If it were, she would be bitching about the crew being closeminded and wanting to lock Adora up. Catra's shoulders rise and fall for several moments as she continues to not look at Adora.

"The last time I took my eyes off of you, you fucking *died*," Adora. We can't even talk to settle things. Can you blame me for being scared to just... let you go again?" Catra asks, her voice rough and low. Adora can't help but recoil a little, sinking down into the water. Catra's ears twitch. She heard the movement of the water. Adora swallows, slowly drifting back. She really can't blame Catra for that, but at the same time, she's outright admitting that she is thinking of Adora like a prisoner she doesn't want to risk giving freedom.

It isn't that she thinks Adora will abuse that freedom, she assures herself. Catra's just a bit traumatized after spending months alone, and Adora hasn't even been able to tell Catra that she loves her since reuniting. It doesn't make the situation any easier. This tank isn't fucking sustainable. Adora can hardly imagine managing the next few days as they sail to Seaworthy in this tiny space. Her body aches from cramps. She wants to swim alongside the ship, feel the sun, and taste freedom.

"I can't, Adora. You need to stay in there, at least for now. We'll talk about it when you have a voice again," Catra tells her, unfurling quickly from her ball and standing abruptly. Adora warbles a little, panic gripping her heart as she realizes Catra is *leaving*, but it doesn't stop her. Catra flees the room before Adora can even put up a protest. Shame radiates from her as she disappears into the darkness of the hold. Adora's throat feels tight, like she's suffocating, and this time it isn't from the tank.

She could free herself, technically. She could drag herself out by her arms. It would be hard and the crew would probably start screaming

and shooting once they saw her doing it, but she could. Instead, she goes limp, feeling as dead as the water in the tank.

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Catra doesn't return for a long time. Adora thought it was evening when Catra last visited, but it's hard to keep track of time. She can't easily ask and Catra only happens to mention it every now and again. Adora's worry only grows as the time passes. All she can do is hang off the hatch to breath in the stale air of the hold or swim in slow circles. Her tail aches with stiffness, her arms, shoulders, and back are sore from hanging off the tank, and the water feels gross on her skin. The glass is beginning to cloud.

Adora doesn't think she can really get sick anymore, but if she can, the tank puts her at risk. She needs to communicate to Catra how bad it is. Surely she'll understand then. Adora isn't going anywhere. She bought a ring for Catra on her first time on shore stationed away from Shadow Weaver. She stashed it in her trunk and it was there for just three days before they sank. The ring is waiting for Catra still in a small cove down in Salineas. Mara helped her scour the shipwreck for it before they went there and promised it would be safe in the cavern. She knows that Catra is afraid, but Adora is always going to come back to her.

As the hours pass, Adora gets bold – or maybe just distressed enough to act out. She thinks she has been very understanding about this whole thing. Catra is in a difficult position with her crew and Adora has done everything she could to follow orders and avoid upsetting them. She has been the perfect prisoner, but after the confirmation that she truly is trapped, she feels choked. The water is dead and her heartbeat keeps randomly racing as her mind warns her that *thee' somegi bee* . The ocean is just a few feet away and yet out of reach.

She lifts herself up by her arms, dragging herself halfway out of the tank like she has done many times to crawl into Catra's lap. This time, she doesn't stop. It's hard to drag the weight of her tail out of the water and up over the lip of the tank. The weight only grows greater with every inch she pulls free. She's lucky she was strong before the transformation and that becoming a siren only increased her muscle mass. She still feels like a slug as she drags herself halfway down the scaffolding and then feels a painful twinge from her tail fin.

It hurts anyway – in the cramped space, she keeps knocking it against the sides of the tank, and it's starting to get a bit tattered as a result – but it has to furl up to make it through the opening hatch of the tank and that kind of flexibility is painful. She looks back over her shoulder and realizes it's *bleeding*. It aches, it's too big to fit through the opening easily, and if she does manage to pull it through on her own, getting it back in is going to even more painful. She sighs, feeling the fight leak away from her in an instant.

It only takes a few moments to push herself back in with her arms. Gravity takes over with the majority of her tail in the tank and she slides back in far easier than she dragged herself out. She takes a big breath as she goes so she can just go limp in the water. Her muscles need the relaxation. That was a terrible idea. Her entire body hurts in all new ways now. She doesn't know what she thought she was doing anyway – there's no way she could quietly drag herself through the cargo hold, into the crew deck, up onto the main deck, and then over the railing of the ship without getting spotted.

The crew would have freaked out – *she* would have, thinking Adora was leaving her. They likely would have tried to net or chain her again. She's in enough pain as it is. She whines a little, involuntary and vulnerable. This can't go on, that's why she asked Catra to let her out. Still, unless she gets truly desperate, she doesn't think she should try to escape on her own. It likely wouldn't work anyway. She's powerful in the sea, but on the ship's deck, a human could easily stop her.

Adora just feels defeated, and in a low moment, she finds it difficult to contain herself. She looks at the clouding on the tank and decides she can't take it anymore. Catra is asleep, she has to be, but Adora is *going* to get the clouding off the glass while she's gone.

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Her cuticles are bleeding on her right hand. Adora eyes her fingers with a listless curiosity. She's aware that's definitely a bad sign of her general state, but she can't do much about it – about anything, so she just returns to scratching at the glass. Her quest to clean it off ended the moment she scratched it on accident. Ever since, she has given into her new neurosis. She has managed to create an impressive amount of surface-level scratchings to fulfill her urge to carve.

It's the patterns of waves, she thinks. She isn't really sure. The lines just curve and run into each other, covering a good fifth of the glass now. She knows that she's weakening it, but honestly, she won't mind if it breaks. Catra will *have* to let her out then. She has nothing else to do and she's losing herself in the dark hold. The lantern Catra left her burned out awhile ago. It's just Adora, the scent of the cargo and musk from the sea, and the suffocating water of the tank.

There are bits of green floating in it, something beginning to grow despite the salt water and Adora's tail constantly agitating it. She keeps staying down in the water to the point of near suffocation rather than breaking her carving groove to surface for air, but logic abandoned her before sunrise. She's fairly certain it is day again now. There's been commotion on the deck for awhile now. It's nothing serious – people sound frustrated or excited, but not angry – so she pays it no mind except to assure herself that Catra has her hands full with whatever it is.

That's the only reason she hasn't come down to see Adora. It has to be. Cheers – and jeers, so someone won and someone lost – erupt from above as Adora finishes the structure of a large spiral on the tank. Now she'll decorate around it until she has filled this big space just like she did the corner that she started in. Eventually she' s going to run out of tank, but she's pretty sure that moment is going to be her breaking point, so she's trying not to think about it.

She hears footsteps overhead, but she hears that all the time. She doesn't think twice about it until she sees movement out in the hold. Adora blinks up, squinting through the scratched glass and darkness to make out the form of ears as Catra approaches the tank room, something large in her arms. Adora can't help her breath of relief, but it's all the air she has left and forces her to look away to surface again.

Part of her wants to stay down in the tank and give Catra the same cold shoulder that she gave Adora just for asking to not be a *prisoner*, but Adora could never do that. She can be petty when she wants to be, but she can't ignore Catra. She knows that Catra has reasons for doing this, even if they aren't totally logical and are, maybe, a bit fucked up. Catra finally steps into the tank room and Adora peers at her in the dark.

Catra seems sheepish, but her expression is the last thing on Adora's mind. She now sees the likely source of the earlier commotion. Catra is carrying what seems to be a dazed and gently wriggling seal pup. Adora blinks at it in shock as Catra sends her wide doe eyes, climbing the scaffolding with the thing in her arms. Adora is surprised that Catra managed to catch one of the creatures, though from its limp fin she can guess it was hurt already and slower than the rest.

"Move over," Catra prompts her, her tone weirdly questioning like she's expecting Adora to refuse. Adora frowns, but she ducks down into the water and watches Catra drop the seal in the water. Maybe live seal pups sell well? They should only be three or four days from Seaworthy. If Catra wants to have anything to sell at market, now will

be the time. Adora feels herself perk up a little. Maybe Catra will let her out now that she needs the tank for something else.

"I know you said that you can make it to Seaworthy, but you were trying to lure us in when we met, so don't lie to me that you just ate," Catra says, her voice quiet as she continues to look at Adora with those big, round eyes. Adora blinks at her, turning her head and suddenly realizing what the seal is for. She gapes, first at it with its round baby face, and then up at Catra. Yes, she eats men's souls, but she isn't a fucking *monster*. Catra's brow furrows. She bites her lip, looking concerned as she glances between the seal and Adora.

"One second. Let me get us light," she tells her, turning and making her way back down to the floor. She disappears into the cargo hold. Adora watches her go and then turns to the seal, who seems to be extremely confused. It's a boy, she thinks, but he isn't old enough to know. This is her first time meeting a seal since transforming, but she's met a few sharks, and the sirens down in the colony taught her a bit about communicating with them. Most sea life that's intelligent enough to share a thought is the same.

It's magic that lets sirens communicate with other sea life. The seal is just lost. He wants his family. The world is dangerous when his mother isn't there. Adora doesn't know how Catra expects her to *eat* him. He's slowly sinking in the strange water, wiggling his little fins and looking around to keep an eye out for predators, though he doesn't seem to have registered Adora as one. She may qualify, but not to him.

She reaches out for him. He wiggles his fins a little wildly, made anxious by her approach, but she mentally assures him he'll be alright. Thoughts and emotions get simplified when they're passed down to the sea creatures. He gets the level of the assurance that he is capable of understanding. What he does know is that something is taking him in and protecting him from predators. By the time that Catra returns, Adora has the pup cradled in her arms and she thinks she might have adopted him.

"*Sir ob*y?" Catra questions, incredulous, when she lights the lantern and holds it up to the tank to see Adora hugging the pup. Adora frowns, sending her a glare and flaring her ear fins at Catra. It's *f lk*of *f* in siren, but it just results in Catra raising a brow and flicking her gaze between the pup in Adora's arms and her stern expression. She's annoyed at Catra for leaving her all night, but she needs her to know she *f lk*ed*p* in expecting Adora to eat a creature like this.

"Adora, we've *h*e*d* seal meat before. It's good," Catra points out. Adora blinks at her. Catra is right that they've eaten seal – only once, at a formal dinner with Shadow Weaver that felt like it could easily result in the end of their careers, or *l i* e*s*, if they said the wrong thing – but they never met the seal beforehand and Adora couldn't communicate with fish back then. She isn't eating this baby. She pointedly turns her back on Catra, beating her tail dismissively as she faces the back wall.

She winces when her tail scrapes against the side of the glass from the maneuver. Okay, her carving might have occupied her hands and calmed her mind for a while, but it has a maj*r* downside, and now hitting her tail against the glass isn't just bruising, it *p*a*s* her. She shivers as she feels a warm rush through her, magic awakening and darting through her veins to fix the injury. Behind her, Catra draws in a sharp breath, the light of the lantern moving as if Catra is squatting. She has spotted the carvings, then.

"Adora, what did you do?" she asks.

Chapter End Notes

> Catra handed Adora TH$ and really expected her to eat it smh. That's her son now (k).

Catra the Bounty Hunter (Apparently)

Chapter Notes

> CWs for this chapter: Implied/Referenced Slavery (Typical of pirates and the era), and an uncomfortable flirting/sexual situation involving Catra choosing to do things she doesn't actually want to with someone other than Adora (She's acting, for a good reason).

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora looks *h* . It takes her tail scraping against the glass – glass that Adora has *h* – for Catra to register it, too caught up in her internal shame spiral at going to bed without coming back for her to notice it, but now that she sees it, she doesn't know how she missed it once the lantern was lit. Adora looks so different now, but despite her tail, finned ears, and white hands, she shouldn't look lifeless like this.

She was golden and shining up on the deck when they caught her. She glowed like the sun, reflecting its beams blindingly. Now, her skin is pale, greenish in tone, though it's hard to tell in the dark hold. Her hair is drab, sapped of its warmth. The tank water is cloudy , but squinting, Catra can see streaks in Adora' s white scales that she thinks might be blood. Her tail, a beautiful plumage just days ago, is tattered and, now it has hit the side of the tank, bleeding.

Catra watches blood cloud from the scrape as Adora winces. Catra draws in a sharp breath, but any words she could say die in her throat as the scrape wound closes over before her very eyes. It heals instantly, and tellingly, the scales around it are a clear, vibrant white, slowly fading away into the streaky mottled colour the rest of Adora has become. Adora has magic to heal herself, maybe she has even been using it this entire time, but she isn't *w* .

‘Adora, what did you do?’ Catra asks, her eyes landing on Adora’s bloody cuticles and then darting back to the tank’s glass. The scratches move in swirling patterns across the surface, so it doesn’t look like Adora was desperately scratching to get out, but nothing about this is good. Catra was so relieved when she reunited with Adora, but the creature before her now is what she feared she had found – a living corpse, perhaps driven by compulsion.

There are myths of drowned women turning into sirens, but those myths have never said if the women were still themselves afterwards. Catra was terrified that the creature in her hold was just a corpse wearing Adora’s face. Without the ability to speak to one another, it was impossible to know. Every shared moment between them helped to convince Catra that this really could be *her* Adora, but the fear flared again when Adora asked to leave.

What if she doesn’t come back? What if her instincts are stronger than they seem and she tries to drown them again, or flees? Catra couldn’t take the risk. She *couldn’t* lose Adora again. She didn’t want her to be a prisoner, just to keep her close until she had a voice and Catra could determine how much of her survived the shipwreck. She could have found a more permanent solution. There’s a large lagoon in Seaworthy she could temporarily release Adora into so she can get some air as a stop-gap measure.

It seems they’re past stop-gaps now. Catra knew the water in the tank was lacking oxygen. Adora told her that. She didn’t realize it wasn’t something that being able to surface at the hatch could fix. The quality of the water and Adora’s bloody scales show her how wrong she was. Adora hunches her shoulders, wrapping around the seal pup – seemingly too tightly. The seal gives a small, affronted noise and wriggles free. Adora doesn’t even reach out for it, despite it fleeing to a corner of the tank well within her reach.

Adora wraps her arms around herself instead. For the first time since they caught her, she opens her mouth and *sings*. It’s a single note, mournful and sad. Catra feels her heart drop along with her ears, emotion threatening to choke her throat. The song might sound

nothing like Adora's old singing voice, but Catra knows that is her lover, and she is in pain. Catra looks down at the swirling scratches starting from the bottom of the tank.

They fill her with as much fear as they do urgency to free Adora. Is it a sign that her mental state is declining? Well, definitely, but is it recoverable? Catra is faced with a choice – keep Adora close and *suffering*, or risk letting her go. The longer she waits, the worse Adora gets and the more likely it is that she doesn't come back. Catra would certainly think twice about returning to someone who has tried to keep her prisoner, and she isn't a *zombie*.

The song is still going. Catra doesn't know if it's just a sound or an actual cry for help, but she knows its magic wouldn't effect her anyway. No, her heart is breaking all on its own as Adora cries in a long, mournful note. Catra feels transfixed. She isn't the only one. The seal pup emerges from its corner and swims up to nudge at Adora as if trying to comfort her. Behind her, Catra hears a commotion as footsteps make their way down the stairs into the hold.

Catra swallows, bracing herself as she turns to face her crew, no doubt panicked by the siren none of them trust beginning to sing again. She's surprised to find Kyle hurrying through the cargo hold, Lonnie hot on his tail. Catra's dread only deepens, fear over what Adora is making Kyle do gripping her, but Kyle draws to a halt in the doorway, panting. He braces his hands on his knees, catching his breath for a moment, before he looks up to make eye contact with Catra. He looks as distraught as Catra feels.

"We have to help her. She's not – she's not making me say that. She just sounds miserable. A goldfish gets more room to swim," Kyle begs, looking between Catra and Adora in the tank. Catra's heart is in her throat. She turns, looking back over her shoulder at Adora as Lonnie finally catches up with Kyle and wraps a preventative arm around his chest. She was probably worried that Adora was compelling him, but Catra believes him. He's just worried – that's Kyle for you.

Adora's mournful note finally ended as she spoke, stopping almost abruptly. She was listening. She still has her arms wrapped around herself, though she has reached out with one hand to pet the seal pup pestering her to make sure she is okay. Maybe she was singing to speak to it – it's certainly acting weird now – but it doesn't really matter why she did it. The sound was tragic, breaking Catra's heart into pieces. No matter how scared she is for her, she knows that Adora never would have caged her if the roles were reversed.

Catra swallows, starting forward and carefully climbing the tank's scaffolding. She watches Adora through the open hatch as she climbs. Her ears twitch, but she doesn't look up. Crucially, she doesn't look away either. From her new angle, Catra can see just how upset she looks. She looks like she could be crying, though it would be impossible to tell underwater, and her shoulders don't shake. Catra swallows, bracing one of her arms on the side of the tank and then taking a deep breath before she reaches out with the other.

Adora swallows, her breath hitching before she turns and looks up at Catra. Catra offers her a small smile, doing her best to look encouraging despite how she isn't sure about this decision at all. Adora blinks up at her with eyes just as large as the seal's, almost like she's expecting Catra to take the hand back. She has fucked up *so bad*. They're lovers. Trusting each other is their whole thing. Catra should have already let Adora out without even being prompted. Despite knowing it, she's still terrified.

She can't stop her head racing with *what if she doesn't know herself?* Adora already left her once. She promised Catra that if she proved herself on just one job then her crew would join her motion to have Catra transferred on board with them and then the two of them could be free together on their own ship, but Catra could hardly stand the idea of them being separated. Still, the assignment came straight from Shadow Weaver. There was nothing they could do but hope, and then Adora *did*

Her thoughts are spiraling. She has to stop them. Catra swallows, tearing her eyes away from Adora to look back to Bonnie, lurking dubiously in the doorway and eying Adora's tank. She and Bonnie have already exchanged their doubts and worries about how much of Adora is still in the naked woman they pulled up onto the deck, but Bonnie was stationed with them on the Black Garnet for years. She knows Adora. Catra knows Adora is still herself at least somewhat – she has to trust that is enough for Adora to come back to her.

She hates trusting. Bonnie makes eye contact with her. She knows Catra's intentions. Her mouth is pressed in a line. If there's one thing Bonnie is, it's loyal. Maybe not to Catra in particular – they've been bullies and rivals to each other as much as they've been friends – but it doesn't matter as long as Catra is her superior. Bonnie will back her choice here with the rest of the crew, she just won't necessarily be happy about it. Yeah, well, neither is Catra. She looks to Kyle instead.

"Have Scorpia prepare the lifeboat. We won't untie it, just lower it into the water as a conveyer. Then send her straight down here," Catra orders him. Kyle's shoulders sag with relief. He nods quickly, turning and slipping out of Bonnie's awkward half-hold, half-hug to scamper back out of the cargo hold. Bonnie's expression doesn't shift as she lets him go. She's waiting for her own orders. Catra doesn't know what those are yet. She swallows, bracing herself, and looks back to Adora.

Adora is looking up at her with giant puppy eyes. Actually, with baby seal eyes. The pup is looking up at Catra with the exact same expression. Catra forces herself to roll her eyes, pointedly waving the hand she has outstretched. That look is earned, but maybe if she pretends that it isn't, Adora will forgive her for it. Adora glances down at her hand, hope in her eyes, and then shifts. To Catra's surprise, she grabs the seal and holds it up to Catra.

"Uh," Catra says, confused as she shifts back to pick the seal pup up in both her hands. The seal blinks at her, wiggling its flippers a little and beating its tail uselessly once. It releases a sound crossed

between a bark and a hiccup. Catra turns, looking back down at Adora, and is startled when she reaches out of the water with both hands and braces them on either side of the tank to haul herself up out of the water. Yeah, *no*.

"Bonnie, take this," Catra orders, turning and holding the seal pup out at arm's length. She went to a lot of fucking trouble to catch it as an apology gift and she doesn't know what they're doing with it yet, but right now her primary concern is helping her girlfriend. Bonnie hurries forward, taking the wet seal as Catra turns back to the tank. Adora hauls herself up, flopping up and out of the water to land stretched out over the top on the flat of her stomach. Catra winces, reaching down to place her hands on Adora's shoulders.

"Just wait, okay? We need to prep the boat. You're only going to hurt yourself dragging through the hold. We'll get you back to the water," Catra assures her, squeezing gently. She's not a fucking siren expert, but Adora's top half seems to be much the same, and her muscles are tense as rock. She bites her lip as Adora shifts to look up at her pleadingly. Catra raises a hand, stroking Adora's face. Despite the sad look in her eyes, Adora leans into her touch.

"It's going to be okay. Just a few minutes. I *promise*," Catra tells her. She sounds desperate, but she is. She knew she fucked up when she went to bed anxious, but she worried that if she went to see Adora before sleeping then she would ask to be let out again. Catra hated telling her *no*. She didn't want Adora to be a prisoner and as long as Adora didn't ask to leave, she wasn't. They could both pretend she had a choice. Catra knew from the second she pulled Adora out of the water that she wasn't letting her go again.

Catra twisted herself in knots overnight worrying. She told herself that in the morning, Adora would see how difficult this was on her and she wouldn't ask again, at least not until she had a voice to ask with. She didn't think enough about how hard this was on *Adora*. Catra had to deal with rediscovering the woman she loves and caging her, but Adora has been stuck in the aquatic equivalent of a closet for four days without food, light, or proper water.

Adora looks up her with big doe eyes for a long minute and then she softens, leaning into Catra's hand and shifting closer to wrap her arms around her. Catra swallows, but she hugs Adora back despite how wet she is – or the fact that the water *smells*. She wrinkles her nose, but she doesn't pull away. She has had Adora's head in her lap over the last few days, but she hasn't been out of the tank enough for a hug like this. Until Scorpia is done prepping the boat, Catra is going to hug her girlfriend. Smells aside, she has *missed* this.

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When Scorpia comes down, she has a mild panic both at seeing Adora out of her tank and at seeing her looking *half dead*. Catra glares her into submission and Scorpia gives up her protests, holding out her arms. Catra helps pull Adora from her tank and down into Scorpia's waiting arms. Bonnie picks up the bulk of her tail and Catra painstakingly frees Adora's tail plumage, large and so mystical before, but now tattered and streaked with blood.

The darkness of the hold must have been obscuring some of this, but Catra also didn't want to see it. She told herself it would be fine. It's not fine. She isn't really supporting Adora's weight, that's mostly on Scorpia and Bonnie, but she has her work cut out for her just carrying the end of her tail regardless. Protecting her fins from getting hit on something is hard enough before they reach the second deck and find the crew beginning to crowd around to gawk as they drag a half-dead siren up into the light of day.

"You can't be serious. She'll sink us-" Octavia starts to protest, but she cuts off when Catra whips her head around and snarls, baring her fangs. The crew is wise, and they part to let them through. Kyle trails behind them, mostly useless, just carrying the seal pup in his arms after Bonnie passed it off to him to free her hands. The crew on

the top deck all mutters when their procession reaches the deck, but no one tries to slow them as they carry Adora to the lifeboat and carefully lay her down.

Catra swallows as she lays out her tail and looks down at her lover. She looks ill. Her skin is pale, her fins are bedraggled as if afflicted with fin rot, and her tail looks bruised and bloodied. Even her "shirt," mangy to begin with, is stained grey and green from the tank water. Adora's eyes are screwed shut, the sun blinding to her as she takes a few deep breaths. Catra takes one of her own, steeling herself, and then carefully climbs into the boat beside her.

"In the water. Now. And if anyone fucks with the line, I'll shoot you in the head from the boat and then crawl up the hull with my claws to finish the job as painfully as I can while keeping you alive," Catra orders, turning to glare at the crew on deck. Bonnie and Kyle exchange glances and then Bonnie hurries to start lowering the boat. The lifeboat is small, just big enough to support their crew without capsizing. It would suck to actually be stranded in it. Adora's tail doesn't fit very well.

Catra carefully wedges herself onto a bench seat at the bow, reaching down and lightly laying her hand over Adora's eyes. Adora makes a quiet, questioning chirp as the boat begins to lower. Catra glances up, squinting at the sun to determine its angle and then shifts her hand to rest on Adora's forehead, cupping it to lessen the glaring light for Adora's poorly-adjusted eyes as the boat lowers down to the water. Adora releases another small sound, seemingly realizing what Catra is doing.

She blinks her eyes open. Her eyes are really fucking enchanting. Catra forgot what they were like on that first day. She wonders how long it took for their spark to die. With the light shining down on her again, Adora's scales that haven't totally faded glitter weakly in the sun. Despite her state, Adora gazes up at her with soft eyes. She looks touched. Catra doesn't deserve that tenderness right now. She swallows, looking up as the waves lap against the bottom of the boat. Hitting the water jolts her.

her hand skitters off Adora's forehead as she jerks to the side, scrabbling to catch herself. She quickly turns back to Adora to find her squinting with one eye open, trying to sit up on her own. Catra rushes to support her shoulder, helping her as she sits up awkwardly. The lifeboat rocks in a way that makes Catra nervous, but she's already fucking wet anyway and she's only going to get more so. The only reason to worry about staying out of the water is to keep her pistol's gunpowder dry.

"Take it slow. Try not to capsize us," Catra tells her. The Halfmoon isn't anchored, the water is far too deep for that, but the sails are up and they're just drifting. Someone on the deck must have done it at Kyle's insistence when he rushed up for Scorpia. Catra will have to take it easy on him for a bit after this. Adora smiles a little to her, the expression weak as she slowly blinks her eyes open and takes in a deep breath of the sea air. Catra breathes a bit easier seeing the calm spread on Adora's face.

"There you go. I'll wait right here for you when you're ready," she praises, running a hand down Adora's back to pet her just like Adora always did to calm her. Shuffling a little closer, Catra wraps Adora up into a hug. Adora slumps weakly against her, seeming grateful for the support so she can go limp as she just breathes for a long moment. Catra's heart is racing, but hope is blossoming in her chest at the fact that Adora didn't just immediately jump out of the boat and take off.

Adora draws in a breath and pulls back. Catra lets her go reluctantly, her brow furrowing as Adora turns her face towards the sun and draws in another calming breath. For a moment, it's peaceful. The sea breeze ruffles her fur, tugs weakly at Adora's wet hair, and is almost enough for her to forget the terrible smell of the tank clinging to them both. Then the moment shatters as Adora suddenly lurches, throwing herself over the side of the boat in one smooth arch.

Catra's heart plummets. She scrambles to brace herself as the boat rocks, but Adora was smart with how she threw herself, and after the initial rock, the boat settles, bobbing in the waters as Adora plunges

straight down. Catra watches her tail disappear into the murky sea with dread rising in her throat. It's hard to breathe, but she forces each breath in and out. Adora doesn't reappear after a few seconds, or as the long moments stretch on.

She'll come back. She has to.

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The wait is excruciating, especially knowing half the ship is watching out the windows or from up on the deck while the other half is debating if she has gone mad. Catra can't hear them very well over the sound of the sea, but she still hears their voices and catches words every now and again. *Have they gone to get another one?* is one of their chief concerns, but it's the furthest thing from an issue on Catra's mind. She doesn't care about other sirens, just this one.

Part of her wonders how long she should wait – if it would be a sign of the weakness in her heart to give up on Adora coming back or if that is already proved by how long she *has* waited, being sprayed as the lifeboat bobs along the side of the ship. On her own, the boat is fairly roomy. Well, no, it's not, but Catra has as much legroom – if not more – as Adora has had for four days. She isn't enjoying it, her heart twisting in knots as she listens to her crew call her crazy and *mad*. Her own heart agrees with them.

She keeps staring over the edge. Eventually, every glint of sunlight off the water tricks her brain into envisioning golden hair swimming back up out of the darkness towards her. Catra forces herself back from the edge, sitting on the bench and picking at her clothes. They stink of the stagnant water. That tank is terrible. It was built to be sturdy – it had to withstand sirens trying to escape, after all – but

apparently it was a bit too strong, locking in dead air and bacteria too.

It's a deathtrap of metal and glass. The only reason Adora was able to endure it so long was that she could have the hatch open and breathe that way. Catra swallows, staring up at the sky and wondering if she just deserves to be left at this point. She certainly hurt Adora in a way a lover never should. It was for her own good, blah blah – either Adora is herself, or she isn't. If she isn't, she isn't better off as Catra's kept pet.

She isn't better off keeping her, looking in Adora's face and knowing the lights aren't on. The only benefit of being with Catra is that she could keep Adora safe – other ships might fire on her out in the sea – but if it's making her sick, she isn't really keeping her alive. Catra listens to the waves lapping against the boat, letting her eyes drift close as the sun beams down on her, drying her clothes but doing nothing for their smell.

She is as miserable emotionally as she is as a person. She just wants Adora back. She would give Adora her own fucking voice just to hear her say *I love you* again. Apparently Catra wouldn't have the heartbeat to hear the words of assurance afterward, though, so instead she stares up at the sky and tries to tell her hyperactive heart to fuck right off to the numb ditch it has been wallowing in for all the months since Adora stepped off the Black Garnet for the last time ever.

Catra is so zoned out, she doesn't notice the abnormal splash at the side of the bed until a hand creeps over the edge of the boat. She jumps out of her fucking skin at the movement, squeaking as Adora's other hand pins her first over the edge and she pops her head up, blinking at Catra with wide eyes. She glances down at Catra's bushed up tail and then looks back up at her, sending her an apologetic look. Catra was starting to lose her mind, but it really hasn't been that long since she disappeared.

Despite that, Adora already looks better. It's probably some magic bullshit. Color is starting to flush her skin again. Her hair shines in the sunlight. Her tail disappears down into the murky sea, so Catra can't see if it looks any better, but she hopes so. Adora has already lost the top she made for her – actually, Catra notices that she has it clutched in her hand once she gets over Adora's breasts just being *out*, water lapping between them. The absolute last thing she should do after all this is ogle her, but Adora has always affected her.

Adora *knows* it too. She smirks a little, releasing a sound not dissimilar to a coo as she drops the failed attempt at a shirt into the bottom of the boat. The sound makes her ears twitch, which is new, but so are the ears themselves. Catra swallows, reaching down for the top and spreading it out to dry on the bench. Adora swam hard enough for one of her's stitches to break, apparently, because one of the strings is only connected on one side.

"Feeling better?" Catra forces herself to ask, looking up to meet Adora's eyes. She expects to see something there – bitterness, resentment, maybe blame – but instead she just finds sparkling crystals boring right into her soul. Adora doesn't break eye contact as she nods and then reaches up, her hand raising towards Catra. Catra swallows, swaying forward within reach. Adora's hand is wet and cold on the back of her neck as she slips it beneath her mane and tugs Catra down to meet her.

It's only their second kiss since reuniting. It was difficult to get in a good position for it when Adora was in the tank, and Catra felt guilty for wanting it when she didn't even know how aware Adora was. She is, ultimately, selfish though. She can't pull away once Adora has offered it. She kisses Adora back with just as much passion as Adora meets her with – which is, shockingly, a lot. Adora kisses her like she wants to devour her, licking into her mouth in a way Catra isn't used to her doing unless they're both undressed.

Adora may be naked technically, but it's a dirty kiss for the moment – or *ever* – and it sends a shiver down Catra's back as her spine ridge fluffs up a little with excitement. It's probably just the contrast of the

last half hour of distress with the warm heat of Adora's mouth. She tastes like *shit*, salt and seawater mixing unpleasantly with the taste of whatever is making Catra's shirt stink right now, but Catra has never cared less about the taste in her life.

If tasting what Adora was forced to live in for the last few days is the price of kissing her, then Catra will take it. She certainly deserves to have to put up with *something* to get the wicked movement of Adora's tongue against hers again. When Adora finally releases her neck, sinking back down into the water up to her chin, she is grinning despite how the next wave crashes over her head. She doesn't seem to give a shit, trilling happily as she swims backwards, casually doing a backflip just beneath the surface.

Catra watches, a bit stunned. She knows she has to be flushed. Her mouth is still hanging open from when she parted her lips in a heartbeat to make way for Adora's tongue. Adora is still grinning as she casually *circles* the boat beneath the surface of the water. Catra can't help that her tail is still puffed out, the tip twitching with interest. She should stop this though – they certainly aren't doing anything more until they can talk, and they're *never* doing it in front of her crew.

Adora pauses as she circles in front of her again, her smirk turning deadly before she peaks her tongue, flicking it almost like a snake, which might be off-putting if it didn't show off how fucking *long* it is now. Catra has no idea how that helps Adora drown ships, but she certainly isn't turned off by it. No, she's already thinking about all the ways that can be practically applied – and that's what Adora *wanted* her to do, she can tell by her shit-eating grin.

"I'm, uh, glad you're feeling better," Catra coughs out, her voice a bit hoarse. Fuck, she's a *mess*, but Adora is definitely still in there. The relief is making her meltdown just as much as Adora's sudden advances are. Adora's smirk softens a little. She reaches up for the edge of the boat again, making it rock as she pulls herself a few inches out of the water to drop a soft kiss to Catra's knuckles

gripping the side to brace herself. Catra's heart beats rapidly in her chest as she watches Adora sink down into the water again.

Her smile is small now, but assuring and hopeful. Catra swallows, flinching a little when a wave hits the boat and splashes up at her. Adora frowns, bobbing up above the surface as she glances almost nervously at the bow of the lifeboat and then back to Catra. Catra takes a breath, forcing her tail still. No longer electrified by Adora's kiss, her fur is standing back down. Suddenly self-conscious, Catra glances up towards the edge of the boat. She watches two heads quickly duck away, but three more just stay, unashamed of their spying. Catra sighs, turning to look back at Adora.

"We need to get moving again. Are you okay?" Catra asks, biting her lip. Adora immediately looks concerned, glancing between the boat and Catra. She doesn't need words for Catra to know she's worried about being brought back up. Catra is, not for the first time, floored at how fucking stupid she is. Adora was fucking dying up in that tank, and not only is she expecting Catra's insensitive ass to send her back, she's preparing to argue about it.

Adora is a siren and she's in water. If she didn't want to be caught, there's nothing Catra could do to chase her down – at least not without busting out the harpoons again, which she definitely isn't going to fucking do. She still hasn't even apologized for that. It seemed like something Adora would want her voice for. At least that's the justification she told herself while she was lying in bed last night, feeling like shit. Catra looks away, tightening her grip on the edge of the boat as she steels herself.

"I'm sorry. For everything. Just stay close to the ship, please? Sing if you need anything. Actually, just sing anyway. Then I'll know you're here," Catra asks her, staring determinedly at a distant cloud. Adora makes a quiet, yet pleased sound that would have Catra's ears pinned back if they weren't already from shame, but aside from flinching a little, she doesn't move. After a moment of silence, she feels Adora's lips press against the knuckles on the hand that she didn't kiss before.

Catra lets out a shaking breath, turning her head to look down at Adora, blinking her eyes a little rapidly for *no reason at all*. Adora's expression is nothing but soft and encouraging as she nods now that Catra is looking. Catra lets out a breath, her shoulders falling a little as some of her internal tension releases. Adora looks touched, which is just all kinds of fucked up. Now that Adora is here and not leaving, all of Catra's worries seem stupid, and the actions she took because of them are just cruel in retrospect.

Adora reaches up, placing a hand over Catra's own on the edge of the boat, and opens her mouth. The same mournful note from when she was down in the hold pours out, though it is significantly less heartbreaking. Catra can tell the sound is the same, so probably the meaning is too, but the emotion from before is lacking. She blinks at Adora as she closes her mouth and looks up at Catra with big doe eyes. It takes a minute of Adora looking at her beseechingly, but it clicks.

"That sounds means you need something? All others are just you saying hi?" she asks. Adora smiles instantly, nodding with obvious excitement that Catra guessed it so quickly. Catra is kind of excited too, and not just because it means they can skip a round of charades. Despite being a fucking moron, she still knows Adora, at least when her fears aren't getting in the way. Taking a breath, she leans down. Adora tilts her face up to meet her. She is too low in the water for Catra to actually kiss her – she'd get sea water to the face – but Catra pecks the top of her head before she pulls back.

"Stay close," she repeats one last time, in a near whisper. Adora nods, her expression all too understanding. Catra forces herself to finally pull away and look up to the people *still* spying on her from above deck. She jerks her head up to them and the heads exchange glances before withdrawing. A moment later, the boat shudders as it begins to lift out of the water. Catra looks back down, watching Adora swim in slow circles below her, all the while sending her that soft, encouraging smile.

Before she left for her last job, Adora asked Catra to trust her. Catra is just going to have to keep on doing it.

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"So, when were you going to tell us you're fucking the siren?" is the first question Catra hears as she climbs out of the lifeboat and helps Bonnie go about securing it to the side of the ship. They're going to be using it too much over the next few days to tie it sloppily and have it get damaged. Catra grits her teeth, finishing her knot before she turns around to fix an icy glare on the gathered crowd, which is the entire crew now.

"Adora has been my lover since before some of you were sailing. And don't forget, she's a siren, which means all she eats now is *pope*. Get out of line and you're going in the fucking water. If something happens to her, Shadow Weaver's wrath will be the least of your concerns. Are we clear?" Catra declares, staring down the crowd. Some of that information was already known to members of her crew.

Given how they've been muttering amongst themselves, Catra's shocked that her and Adora's relationship status hadn't made the light of day already. Like she said: Bonnie is loyal. She tries to focus on that, because it's easier than dealing with the heartbroken look on Scorpia's face. In her first debrief with the crew after "capturing" Adora, she had to explain that Adora was once Shadow Weaver's protégé, but they lost her in a shipwreck.

Every sailor knows the myths about sirens, including how they're made. After a moment of everyone exchanging glances and shifting nervously, no one challenges her, but to her surprise, a hand sticks up near the back of the group – a scrawny, white, human hand. Catra raises a brow at Kyle, still holding the amiable seal pup tucked

under his arm like a sack. It was surprisingly easy to handle after they managed to catch it, but this is ridiculous.

"Yes, Kyle?" she prompts. She has no idea why he raises his hand during these things. They're usually more of a *Hey I got one!* kind of thing when there isn't the threat of being fed to a siren hanging over everyone's head. Kyle drops his hand, untucking the seal pup and holding it out proudly in front of him. The seal pup burps, or something. It makes a noise. It's small, and kind of cute, and kind of stupid sounding. Catra's raised brow only climbs higher.

"If she only eats humans, does that mean she doesn't want Oswald?" he asks. Catra stares at him while Bonnie facepalms to the side.

"You named the seal Oswald? *Already*?" she asks, incredulous. Kyle blinks at her with wide, twink eyes before he nods once, a bit empathetically. Catra looks down at the seal. If Adora didn't want it, she was kind of assuming the crew could eat it, but it isn't like she knows anything about preparing seal anyway. They aren't hurting for food, and they're only days away from docking. With a sigh, she waves her hand in the air.

"Sure, fine, you can keep it for now. Just leave it with your boyfriend when we dock. I'm not wasting rations on it for one day after that," she tells him. Kyle cheers. From down in the water below, Catra hears Adora give a happy, echoing call in response. She doesn't know if Adora could even hear what they're cheering about, but the sound makes Catra smile. Adora's in a place to be happy again – that's better than she's been for the last four days.

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Catra spends a lot of her time looking over the rail of the ship. Adora is only visible about half the time. If Catra stops to actually hang over the edge of the rail and watch her, Adora will flip over to float on her back, lazily beating her tail and smiling up at Catra in all her naked glory. Catra went down in the lifeboat again before she went to bed that first night with Adora in the water. She asked Adora if she needed a break, even if it was just spent in the lifeboat, but Adora just shook her head.

Adora is far better down in the water than she was in the tank. On only her second day back in the sea, her tail appears to start healing, the colour clarifying and some of the majesty of her plume returning. On the third, her tail fins already seemed healed, even if they hadn't returned to their full majesty. Her hair is golden again too. She waves happily when Catra looks over the railing. Catra goes down in the lifeboat every morning and evening while the helmsman shifts are changing, but they have to stop the boat for her to do it, so she can't just hang out with Adora down there like she would like to.

She has to settle for looking over the railing or closing her eyes and listening for Adora's calls – sometimes joyous, and sometimes lazy, but never sad – echoing up from the water around them. Adora is true to her word, and she sings often. It unnerved the crew at first, but between Catra explaining that she has been instructed to sing so they can keep an eye on her and Adora never having a fucking clue what she's saying, they move on from being worried by it to just being annoyed by the noise.

Before they approach Seaworthy on the fourth day, Catra goes down to speak with Adora one last time. She'll have to stay out of sight in the port if she wants to avoid causing a panic and possibly getting a bounty placed on her head. Luckily, Seaworthy is built around a lagoon. There's a thin spit of land that separates it from the ocean that stretches out of sight of the main settlement. Adora can pull herself across it by her arms and then meet them inside Seaworthy at night. She'll have help.

I have to spend the afternoon being a good captain, but Kyle and Lonnie will meet you at the land crossing and help you into the lagoon after sunset. Follow them to the shrine by Rogelio's house and wait. I'll lure someone there when it's dark enough that they won't spot you in the water," Catra tells Adora, reaching out to pet the top of her head. Adora has her hands hooked over the edge of the boat to anchor herself as she happily leans into the touch. She nods, blinking up at Catra with her wide blue eyes.

"Just be careful, alright? If you hear anyone who isn't me, Kyle, Lonnie, or Ro, then hide. I'll get you a proper asshole to steal from, don't worry," Catra assures her . Adora snorts, sending bubbles up in the water. Her face is only above the water when a wave isn't splashing, but she doesn't ever seem bothered by the water. Now that she's back in the ocean, her gills are prominent, actually working and flaring as she breathes.

"We'll be able to talk tonight," Catra whispers, mostly to herself as she decides *fuck it* and dips her hand down beneath the waves to press her fingers underneath Adora's chin. She can see the burning excitement in Adora's eyes as she beats her tail and raises up out of the water, nuzzling her wet face against Catra's cheek and stealing a quick kiss because she starts to sink down again. It's barely a brush of lips, but it makes Catra yearn.

She opens her eyes to find Adora in the water, smiling at her softly. Adora nods. It's the closest thing to promising they can talk that they'll get right now. Catra blows out a breath. Almost there. Tonight she'll finally found out what happened – and who she has been kissing.

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Adora waves to them up on deck as she splits off. Seaworthy is visible down the coast and she can't risk singing and being overheard as she follows the inlet that will take her to the land spit. If it weren't for the trees, it would be visible from the deck, but Catra just has to let her lover disappear in the water and know that best case scenario is she doesn't see her for several more hours. As much as Adora is her priority, there's no hope of her lurking unnoticed in the waterways during the day.

Catra spends the day being a captain. She gets them docked, gives everyone duties to see to before they can take their shore leave, and assigns them trade-off shifts guarding the boat. This may be a Horde-friendly port, but nearly everybody here is a criminal, and someone sneaking on board to stowaway or steal is one of the better scenarios should someone not be stationed to guard the ship. Catra leaves Scorpia in charge of the Halfmoon. Scorpia has been avoiding her for the last three days. She's acting *hurt*.

Catra knows what she is upset about, but she always resisted every one of Scorpia's advances, and she doesn't owe her an explanation for who she loves. Catra never led her on or even wanted her attention. She isn't fucking apologizing for not spilling out her heart about a secret and doomed romance. What she can do is give Scorpia authority while she's on shore, offering her power and authority. It's a rare gift in the Horde, and it shows that Catra believes in her as quartermaster, even if she has no interest in her as a lover.

Catra is hoping to find a better solution for transporting – or at least *hiding* with – Adora while docked, but that will have to wait until the second day when they can talk and Adora can tell her what she needs. Catra has to spend today negotiating their resupply with the funds leftover from their initial allotment and hunting down information on the Black Garnet. When the sun goes down, she'll head to a tavern and see if she can't find a mark for Adora.

It's a bad town. She's sure she'll be able to find someone for her, even when limited to a human woman. The only reason Catra and Adora haven't killed despite being in the Horde for so long is that

they weren't given assignments off the Black Garnet until recently. There will be a gullible scumbag somewhere here, and the tavern is a good place to start. Catra just has to resist the urge to run off to check on Adora until tonight.

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The Black Garnet is, mercifully, nearby. The Primary Navy is moving in on a cluster of islands nearby, and Hordak wants to send a powerful message about who the waters belong to. The area is only a week away, but hunting down the ship might take longer. Rations for another three weeks secured, Catra heads to her least favourite of all the taverns in Seaworthy. It's the one she has been to the most, but only because it's known for its tavern brawls.

She was fucked up after losing Adora. She spent a few weeks on shore while Shadow Weaver put together the Halfmoon's crew. She went out nearly every night, drinking when she could afford it, mooching or stealing off others when she couldn't, and fought as much as she drank. It didn't make her feel any real emotions, but the adrenaline was something at least.

At the end of the night she would stumble back to Rogelio's house, stuff herself under the coffee table, and sleep for a few hours before getting up to go crawling to the dock to make a few coins hauling goods all day. Catra was drunk or hungover most of the time, but she remembers what the other patrons were like. It was full of unsavory types. It takes her only a few minutes of keeping her ears open to find a potential mark.

A woman in the back corner of the bar is bragging about the money from her last *good* one. Catra cringes at the words. It has slaver written all over it. Shadow Weaver claims that the Horde only has slave ships because it captured them and liberated their occupants,

but Catra knows fucking better. She was "cargo" once. The conditions are awful. Catra's first memory starts in the cargo hold. She nearly starved on that ship, but it ended up saving her life.

One day she realized she was skinny enough that she might slip free of her shackles. She's pretty sure she broke something in the process, but when she realized they were docking, she took her chance. She managed to yank herself free and make a run for it. Unfortunately, they weren't docking on land. Catra didn't know that until she managed to sneak up onto the main deck and saw the Black Garnet looming over them, a ship that easily dwarfed their own.

It was the last place she wanted to go – they were dealing with the slavers, clearly – but she knew it wouldn't be long before her captors discovered her missing and searched their own ship for her. She had no hope if she stayed. The Black Garnet was big enough that she might get lost on it – and lost she was. She spent hours, maybe even days, hiding in a crate, paralyzed by fear and wondering if she was going to starve to death there before a blonde ponytail popped up over the lip and the widest blue eyes she had ever seen blinked at her.

Shadow Weaver definitely suspected where Catra came from – the Black Garnet hadn't docked in weeks – but Adora took to Catra immediately, so Shadow Weaver allowed it. She never intended for her to go anywhere in the Horde, though. Maybe, Catra sometimes fantasized at night, Shadow Weaver was *afraid* of her - afraid if she gave her a ship that Catra would turn it against the people who stole her away. It never mattered. Catra knew she couldn't fight the entire Horde.

Slavery is illegal, but criminals always exist. Catra might not be able to fight the Horde, but she can take care of this *one* slaver. She is older, maybe in her fifties. Catra doesn't need any additional excuse to target her, but for the catharsis of it, she imagines her as the one who ran the slave ship that took her away from her home and

brought her here, to this cesspool of a tavern, with a dead-but-undead lover lurking in the lagoon.

She orders a drink and downs most of it. She needs the mug for her ruse, but she was raised as a pirate, and a good pirate doesn't waste alcohol – especially not alcohol they *paid* for. A single mug isn't enough to make her anything more than pleasantly warm, but the woman doesn't need to know that she has only had one. Catra hops off her barstool, mug in hand, and carefully teeters over towards the woman. She practically falls into her lap trying to lean against the table with a total lack of coordination.

"Get the fuck out of my face," the woman sneers when Catra stumbles into her. Catra thinks of every time she and Adora ducked into a closet together and looks up at the woman with wide, blown out eyes and flushed cheeks. She giggles a little, absently shoving her empty tankard onto the table so she can catch herself with both hands as she sways.

"I think I need help," she stage-whispers, ending her words with a giggle. Catra isn't really a giggly drunk, but she's been plastered enough times and dealt with other drunks to fake it. The woman looks annoyed, but she eyes Catra with vague interest. She sees a potential mark. Good, that's exactly what Catra wants her to think. Catra pouts, letting her ears droop as she does so. She doesn't think this woman is going to be swayed by sad-eyes, but it's part of the act.

"I live- I live by the water. I can't walk there. I'll fall. And you're- you've got that- you're hot. Walk me home?" Catra asks, slurring her words and giggling a little as she fails to find words for what the woman is. She is fairly attractive, but the idea of doing anything with a woman like her makes Catra want to throw up in her mouth. All Catra has to do is lure her to the secluded waterway near Rogelio's house, though. The woman looks her over, and then the corner of her mouth quirks up, self-satisfied.

"You certainly need someone to take care of you, sweetheart. Are magicats as flexible as I've heard?" she asks, reaching for her own mug and downing its remaining contents. Catra is glad she looks away so she misses the slight twitch that she knows her face must give at that. Yes, they are, and that flexibility is exactly what let her free herself from her restraints the last time she dealt with a slaver. She can't wait for Adora to eat this woman or whatever it is she has to do.

"I can eat myself out. Not that I don't prefer someone else's help," Catra says, making her voice distant and floaty. It's the kind of taking the prompt and running with it only a wasted person would do. She gets lost midsentence, finishing off with another giggle and ducking her face like she has just realized what she said. The woman's mouth actually falls open for a moment before she manages to collect herself, smirking again as she eyes Catra.

"Sweetheart, I can definitely take you home," she returns.

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She's pretty sure the woman is intending to steal from her house. Catra was worried she would try to take her back to her own ship, but she follows Catra's slurred instructions as she leads her back towards Rogelio's house. She hates the arm around her waist and how she nuzzles into the woman's side as they walk. She's good at acting, but the urge to slide her claws out in preparation of defending herself is strong. She's relieved when she spots the bridge that leads to the shrine.

"Wait, here," she mumbles, slapping her hand limply against the woman's side to get her attention. The woman raises her eyebrow, glancing at the shrine Catra has vaguely gestured at.

"That's not your house, sweetheart," she tells her. Catra wants to punch her in the face, but instead she giggles and lurches away from the woman, toward the bridge.

"Nooo. But the plants around it make its little beach-thingy private. And I've always wanted skinny dip there," Catra tells her, sticking out her tongue and wagging it at the woman as she stumbles over to the bridge and leans up against its post. The last thing she wants to do is get in the water, but the woman needs to end up there, preferably without a splash. If she has any interest in Catra as anything other than a target, this will be the best way to do it.

Luckily for her, the woman likes the idea. A smirk spreads on her face as she saunters forward and wraps an arm around her waist again, this time tugging Catra onto the bridge with her. When Catra giggles this time, there's actually genuine joy there. As long as Adora hasn't been caught, hasn't run off, and is ready to do what needs to be done, then this is almost over. There's a lot of conditionals on it, but Catra is so fed up with dealing with this woman.

"Aw, kitty cat's not afraid to get wet?" the woman teases her, crooning as they cross the small bridge. Yeah, Catra wants to murder this woman herself. It takes everything in her not to twitch as they finally cross into the relative privacy of the shrine's island, surrounded by stalked grass almost as tall as Catra is. The small beach at the back of the stone shrine faces out to the lagoon, the uninhabited beach, and then the open ocean on the other side of it. It really is a good spot to go skinny-dipping, but also for a siren to lurk.

"Maybe I already am," Catra stage whispers, and then she tears herself away again and makes for the beach with a stumbling run. In truth, she just can't keep up the teasing expression right after saying something like that, and she wants to get this *over with*. She pulls at her shirt as soon as she comes to a stumbling halt at the edge of the shore. She tosses it over the plant stalks to her left, letting the plants suspend it over the grit-covered ground as she goes for her belt next.

She still has three loose coins in her waist pouch, but it's not enough to be worth stealing really, and the woman knows it. Catra felt her feeling the pouch as they made their way out of the crowded streets around the bar and into the barren shanty area where a number of the homes are. She's following Catra now either to steal from her house or just because she wants to actually fuck her . The woman certainly wastes no time in slipping up behind her and feeling up her bare torso when she catches up.

Fuck is Catra not interested. She scans the dark waters around the shrine as she drops her belt into the silt beside her. She sees a few glints that could be hints of something golden beneath the surface, but that also could be the lights from the lanterns around town reflecting off the water. She swallows. She doesn't know what she's going to do if Adora's not there for a *number* of reasons. She giggles loudly as the woman's hand make their way to her chest, dropping her own hands to her waistband and hooking her thumbs inside.

"*Please* tell me you're getting in the water with me," she practically whines. Sounding bratty is the only way she can cover up her discomfort. The woman chuckles behind her, but she takes a half step back. Catra suppresses the urge to give a sigh of relief as the hands fall away so the woman can undress herself.

"Oh, I'm not missing this," she assures.

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Catra hates the water. She doesn't even know how to swim. She still only stays on the shore for a second after stripping all the way. She doesn't want the woman to *touch* her. She darts into the gently lapping waves, wading up to her waist as the woman calls quietly to her to slow down as she hurries to strip herself. Catra doesn't want to get within arm's reach of the woman again.

“What are you going to do about it?” she calls back, her tone bratty and teasing. She has her back to the woman and she is all but grimacing as she looks out at the shore on the other side of the lagoon. As soon as the woman gets within arm’s reach, it’s time for a fucking mood swing. Hope and a good bit of fear spikes in Catra’s chest when she swears she feels something brush against her ankle, but when she looks down, there’s nothing but black water next to her.

“Oh, brats like you need to be taught a lesson-” the woman starts to say, her voice growing too close for comfort. She’s cut off by a splash of water, a half-strangled yell, and then a wave hits Catra’s back as utter silence suspends in the air. Catra whips around, blinking back at the shore. Her clothes mingle with the woman’s on the sand and amongst the reeds, but behind her is nothing but a stretch of black water. Every other trace of the other woman is gone.

Her heart racing, Catra wades back to shore. She supposes now she just waits.

Chapter End Notes

> In Catra’s defense she knows fuckall about taking care of fish, but I could hear my aquarium-loving ex screaming all the way from NYC as I wrote Adora in the tank. No one was expecting to care about the sirens’ quality of life going into this, okay.

Adora the People-Eater

Chapter Notes

> Picking up right after the last chapter, so we're dealing with mentions of that Very Bad Lady still at the beginning.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora watches the woman touch Catra with her blood boiling. Catra's expression is nearly a grimace. She isn't enjoying it. Adora wants to maul her, but she knows that Catra is actually the one helping her. Catra is going through this for Adora's benefit, luring this woman into the waters so she can take her voice without a commotion. Adora doesn't know who she is, but she does know one thing she has done, and that is grope Catra – while she was obviously pretending to be drunk, too.

It's enough for Adora. The woman's voice is low and husky when she calls out to Catra, and all Adora can think is *you touched her*. She circles past Catra before the woman can get close enough to touch her again, launching up out of the water with her claws out and jaws already open. She rips the woman's throat out before she even drags her fully beneath the surface. Once she has a taste of her magic, the animal instinct takes her over, but she isn't going to devour this woman right in front of Catra.

She digs her claws in and swims away with the woman's body in her clutches. Not far, but close enough that Catra won't see any blood or viscera. Adora needed the woman's throat for her voice, but she needs her heart to consume her soul. It's magic that sustains her, not flesh, but taking another being's magic means killing them too. She knows, logically, that she isn't starving, but it feels like it as she rips into the woman's chest and intakes her first real boost of magic since she used up so much of her stores healing.

She caught some fish as she swam, but most animals have miniscule amounts of magic. Intelligence seems to be tied to how much a creature has. Adora can't survive off fish. She doesn't actually need that much magic to survive when she's in a healthy environment, but ever since she figured out how even half of this works, she has been determined to have full magic stores. It takes a lot of magic to turn someone. She needed to have it on hand just in case she found Catra.

She doesn't have that kind of power left after all the healing – stealing the voice takes energy too, settling awkwardly in her throat like a lump she has to adjust to – but she' s feeling good as she swims back to the island and finds Catra huddled on the shore, still naked. Logically , Adora knows she probably didn't want to put on her clothes while she was still wet and get them soaked. However , the instinctual part of Adora's brain that triggers when feeding just sees *naked* and acts accordingly.

She practically bursts out of the water. She doesn't want to scare Catra, but the momentum carries her up the beach to flop down beside her as Catra squeaks and scrambles away for the half second before her brain registers that it's Adora. Adora feels a painful squeeze in her chest at the sight of Catra *afraid* of her like that, but she reminds herself that she just startled her , and there's no way Catra was able to see what horrible things she just did.

Even if she did, that woman deserved it. She was clearly a predator. She touched Catra and made her uncomfortable. Adora put a stop to it. Even thinking about it makes anger want to well up in her chest, but right now, Catra's heart racing with fear – with *shared adrenaline* , Adora assures herself, she isn't afraid of Adora – has to be her priority. Catra might know that she is a people-eating monster, but she didn't have to see it. Adora finally has a voice now, and she can use it to distract her from all that.

"Catra. Catra, Catra, Catra, Catra," she gushes forward, feeling excitement dance across her skin at every uttered syllable. The voice doesn't sound quite like her own, too rough and a little growly ,

but it isn't the woman's exactly either. It will take some time to get settled in her throat. Her magic will warp it into her own tones eventually, but at least she can *talk* again. Catra blushes, her ears and tail twitching. She is still breathing heavily from her panic, but she slowly turns back towards Adora, seemingly unconcerned with her own nakedness as her tongue darts out to wet her lips.

"You can talk now? Say anything?" she asks, her voice low, scratchy, and hopeful. Adora grins, rolling over onto her side to face Catra and get a bit closer as she reaches out her hand. Catra still looks flustered, glancing down at Adora's hand before taking it. She seems nervous for some reason, which Adora doesn't understand, but it's probably lingering nerves from dealing with that woman and then being frightened immediately afterwards. Hopefully it has nothing to do with how Adora got this voice.

"Yeah. I love you. See?" Adora returns, the words coming out a bit breathier – and squeakier – than she intended, but she's still adjusting to using human language again. Catra's breath hitches, her entire body swaying closer to Adora, seemingly on instinct. Adora grins, wriggling closer and sitting up properly on the beach. They're both wet and covered in sand, but Adora has plans for them to get even dirtier before they leave. She finally has Catra alone where she can touch her, and even better, she can *speak* to her.

"I missed you so much. I was always looking for you. It killed me to be with you again and not be able to tell you how much I love you. I was singing it to you all the time in the water, but you couldn't understand," Adora gushes out, all the words that she has been holding back spilling forth in an avalanche. Catra's breath hitches, happiness dancing in her eyes that Adora hasn't seen since they were back on the Black Garnet together. "Catra. I love you. *I love* Catra. My beautiful captain," she keeps going, breathless and excited.

Her voice sounds weird, but it's the least of her concerns when Catra melts, releasing a small, almost wounded sound before she throws herself forward to wrap her arms around Adora. Adora hugs her back

tightly, reaching for her and rearranging her to drag their bodies together. Sand from the bank is trapped between them and Catra is going to be uncomfortable and disgusted once they get past this emotional part and she realizes she is wet and gritty , but she wraps around Adora in turn as they press from collarbone to ankle, the water of the lagoon lapping at their legs.

"Shh. It' s okay. I'm right here. I'm never leaving you,"Adora assures her, dropping a kiss into her hair. Her voice sounds like she has been chain-smoking cigars, but she doesn't even care. What's important right now is saying everything to Catra that she hasn't been able to over the last week. Adora would have been utterly lost if it was Catra's ship that sank instead. She doesn't *want* to imagine how bad the last few months have been for Catra, but she can assure her now that she won't ever have to go through it again. Catra's breaths are labored as she buries her face against Adora's shoulder. She's trying not to cry.

"No matter what happens, if we ever get really separated, we'll meet back up on this bank, okay? You don't have to worry about us getting separated. We'll both make our way back here and know how to find each other,"Adora tells her . She has been thinking about it while following alongside the shallmoon. Sometimes when she dived down, or just zoned out, she lost sight of the ship. She always panicked. She can't lose Catra again, not after all this. It may come that they drift apart in the vast sea, but if they both know where they can find each other again, it won't matter. They just have to follow the shoreline.

Catra draws in a sharp breath, and then she's shifting. She raises her head from Adora's shoulder and kisses her hard enough to force her back, the embrace desperate and needy. Adora squeaks a little with surprise, but she quickly recovers, hugging Catra tight and kissing her back with just as much passion. This is her lover , and now, she'll always be able to find her again. Their embraces have been far more infrequent than Adora would like thanks to the

physical barriers between them, but they can overcome that with communication now.

"*Yes*. Please. I can't be a fucking widow again," Catra breathes to her between kisses, unwilling to pull back. Her kiss is hungry, but the words break Adora's heart. She squeezes Catra tightly, kissing her back for a long moment to assure her, but she can't let those words go unanswered either. She raises one hand, cupping Catra's cheek. She rubs her thumb against it as she gently pulls back to make eye contact with her. Catra immediately releases a sound of protest, trying to lean forward to continue the kiss, but Adora holds her back. She needs to see her face for this.

"I bought you a ring on my first shore leave. I recovered it from the wreck. I don't know how the water will have damaged it, but I stashed it so I could come back and get it for you," Adora tells her, searching Catra's face as her eyes go wide and she draws in a sharp breath. Adora loves Catra with all her heart, but she's worried about broaching this topic so soon after she fucking lost someone. Adora is far from wife material now. Catra deserves someone she can lie in bed with and who doesn't have to *murder* other people to survive. Tears prick at Catra's eyes as she stares back at Adora. Adora swallows, unsure what that means.

"I mean, if you don't want it, it's not like sirens can even get married anyway, right? Or, it's- fine-" Adora starts in a rush, panic gripping her, but she cuts off when Catra kisses her, messy and rushed. If anything, the desperation of before has only *compounded*. Adora does her best to just keep up, letting Catra have her way with her mouth as she shifts them, pinning Adora down on her back and shifting to straddle her with her hands on her shoulders, like she's afraid Adora is going wriggle away. As if Adora is going anywhere when Catra is on top of her.

"Of course I want it, you stupid fucking dumbass. You know how scared I've been? First I was alone, and then you were back, but you couldn't talk and I couldn't tell how much you remembered or if you could even consent. I was scared you'd have some stupid fish

instinct that would tell you to swim away from danger – from *me*," Catra rushes out, pulling back to look down at Adora with wide eyes. Adora swallows, blinking up at Catra. She can hear the fear shaking her voice. She reaches up, lightly placing her hands over Catra's own on her shoulders and squeezing.

"I remember everything, Catra. I do have some weird instincts now. My biology is different. I run on magic and *celestus*. But I'm me. My body transformed, but my mind is the same. I am. And every part of me has always loved every part of you," Adora returns, reaching up to cup Catra's cheek, petting her gently and stroking at the base of her ear with her fingertips. Catra was always calmed by that before, eagerly leaning into the touch, and she does so now, a purr Adora has hardly heard starting in her chest. Adora can see the relief on her face, Catra's eyes shining as they search her own.

"I love you too. Always, Adora, fish tail or not. I was just so scared that you were lost to me," Catra tells her. Adora shakes her head, sliding her hand around to cup the base of Catra's neck and pull her down into a kiss. This time Adora leads, kissing her slow and gentle. She licks into her mouth, drinking in every breath from Catra's warm mouth. She wants to treat her with the same gentleness she would always turn on Catra after a day of punishments, lash marks fresh on her back or her fingers worked to the bone. That was physical torture, but for months now, Catra has been going through a psychological one.

It was hard on Adora and she knew that she lived. Adjusting to her new body was hard, but Catra was adjusting to life without Adora and seemingly no hope of finding her again. Adora is going to have to ask her the story of how she became captain some other time, but right now, her priority is the woman in her arms. They're alone for the first time in days. Adora can kiss her slow, licking her tongue forward and slowly turning the kiss filthy, reclaiming what is hers.

Adora hasn't forgotten her bubbling rage at seeing the other woman touch an unhappy Catra. Adora has an all-new level of lung capacity now, and she doesn't pull back until Catra does, panting and flushed.

her tail is lashing behind her, splashing in the water Adora's tail is still trailing into. Her eyes are blown out in the darkness, her fur fluffed a little as she gasps for breath. She looks a little bit *stunned*. Slowly, Adora feels a smirk pull up at the corner of her lips.

"I can consent, too. Just to answer your question," Adora tells her, leering a little. Catra releases an interested, flustered, and obviously involuntary trill, shuddering a little as she flushes even more. Adora grins, already wriggling down on the bank. She needs to get more into the water anyway or she's going to dry out, but Catra just swallows and shifts a little to let Adora slide down beneath her until Catra is kneeling just above the water's edge, her shins in the water along with Adora's body. Adora grins as she reaches up for Catra's hips and pulls her down to settle over her face.

Adora has been thinking about what Catra would taste like on her new tongue for weeks. The answer is just as good as she imagined.

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The lagoon water isn't as nice as the ocean, but it's breathable. It's far better than the tank at least. As they lay in the sand afterwards, Catra lying parallel to the water so she can dry off a little before she puts on her clothes and stumbles to Rogelio's for a proper bath, they talk logistics. At least once Catra is recovered. Adora is *satisfied* with the results of her initial experimentation, and Catra managed to keep her sounds down to sighs, whimpers, and gentle moans. No one is coming looking for them.

"You sure you'll be good in here for another day?" Catra asks her. Adora rolls her eyes and nods. Her throat is getting a bit scratchy, not used to being used like this and needing more water than she has been getting, so she has started to carefully save her words. It will take awhile to get used to her new voice, but as long as she can

use it to sing Catra's praises, she doesn't care. She's down in the water now, her arms folded just beyond the waves so she can rest her chin on them. Every now and then the water laps enough from the ocean breeze to splash over her gills. It feels nice.

"Okay . I'll see what I can find for you tomorrow. If I find something early, we'll leave for the Sea of Sigh in the afternoon. I'll come see you in the morning and in the afternoon regardless. We'll go from there," Catra tells her , reaching out and stroking Adora's hair, which is mostly dry on the crown of her head at this point. Adora sighs, leaning into the touch. The lagoon won't be that bad to lurk in for a day. Adora's not actually looking forward to leaving it, but that's mostly because of where they're going.

"What if we *di dnt*," she pouts. It isn't really a question, she just doesn't want to sail a week away to see Shadow Weaver. Catra pauses, blinking at her. She seems stunned. Adora sighs, looking away. "That ship I was on? It was miserable. The crew weren't just assholes, they were monsters. Every single one of them was a murderer and proud of it. We already dealt with a lot on the Black Garnet, but on that ship... it was worse. I was afraid to be alone with some of them, Catra," Adora tells her .

She can't look Catra in the eye as she admits it. She can't even say what she was afraid of, but the men bragged about all their crimes. Murder wasn't the worst amongst them. Adora has lost count of how many men she has drowned in shipwrecks now, but after her weeks as the only woman on a small Horde ship, she didn't feel bad like she should. She was targeting Horde ships to find Catra, but she needed to eat, and she wasn't about to feast on a merchant sailor just trying to get by .

She and Catra never got a choice about being part of the Horde. Adora was – supposedly – the daughter of a member of the Horde who died raiding a ship. Shadow Weaver took pity on her, about to be chucked off the Black Garnet for being parentless and likely left to die as a helpless infant, and from that day on she was her protégé. Adora never got a choice, and given what Catra has muttered late at

night about her own origins before they met, she has long feared something more sinister happened to her.

Shadow Weaver was a monster. She did everything she could to raise Adora not to think that, but eventually her words couldn't outweigh the scars gathering on Catra's back. No matter what poison she whispered, Adora would never understand how she could hurt someone so caring, so passionate, so *young* when Shadow Weaver set her sights on her. She still never considered leaving. They would have their own ship one day, and then it wouldn't matter.

Her words worked to some degree. Adora doesn't mind stealing. Even killing doesn't rankle her like she knows it should, not when she also knows that her victims aren't innocent. It's her cruelty and all the other crimes that add up and make Adora resistant to returning. She doesn't want to sail back to Shadow Weaver. She certainly doesn't want to help her. She risks a glance to Catra. Catra looks angry. She has filled in the blanks, but her brow is still wrinkled.

"No one can do anything to you now , Adora. What else are we going to do? My crew is hard. I'd just end up tossed in the ocean if I tried to abandon them. I spent a few weeks on land after your ship sank. Every day I wondered if I was going to eat and that was when I was already living with Rogelio for free. I don't know how to be anything but a pirate. We have to go back," Catra tells her . Adora presses her mouth in a thin line, looking away again. She hates hearing that for many reasons. She opens her mouth to argue, but Catra cuts her off.

"We lived through *hell* to get here, Adora. Count the scars on my back. That's how I earned this ship. I'm not giving it up. I won't let anyone do anything to you, okay? We'll meet her and get her to call off the bounty on your head. She'll probably just assign us to go drown other ships and steal their goods. I get the money, you get souls to eat. It's a win-win," she tells Adora. Adora sighs, staring at the swaying reeds. When Catra says it like that, it sounds so simple.

Adora doesn't know how she feels about using her powers on other ships – actually, she does, but she's in denial about it since it seems to be in her future. Catra is right though. She went through so fucking much to earn this ship. Adora has held her as she tried to not cry herself to sleep on rough nights. Adora is going to have to drown people to live anyway. She tells herself it's okay when it's the Horde, but it's still a life.

She has to eat. Catra has to as well, and that means she needs money. An all-female crew teaming up with a siren sounds like something out of a novel. It sounds badass. They'll be damn near unstoppable if they decide to do this. Maybe after they've established themselves, they can break off on their own and only target ships that deserve it. The invading Primary Navy, other pirates, slavers, just anything but innocents. She sighs, but she looks back to Catra and she nods.

"Okay . But please don't get on the Black Garnet. Have her come to the ship. I won't be able to help you, and I don't trust her," Adora agrees. Catra's expression softens and she nods, leaning forward to kiss Adora's forehead. Adora leans into the touch. She might not be thrilled about this plan, but as long she and Catra are together, things will be okay.

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Catra comes to see her in the morning, but she has errands to run and captain duties while they're still in port. Adora spends the day in the deeper parts of the lagoon, especially where the plant life is thick and can obscure her. After their conversation yesterday, Adora can't help but imagine a life outside of the Horde, no lives hanging on their consciouses. The problem is that Adora would always have to kill anyway. It's an unattainable dream.

She still dreams about it, hiding amongst the reeds. She rather likes the lagoon, despite its water being less alive than the ocean. It's quiet and calm, far calmer than the sea. The surface ripples, but no currents try to tug at her. More importantly, people are around her for the first time in months. She has to avoid them, but they walk over bridges and platforms spanning the lagoon and wade into its water when they can't be bothered to walk to where a bridge spans it.

Everybody here is used to living amongst the water ways. As a creature of them now, Adora loves being able to be so close to others again. Catra was so far away up on her ship deck, but she's close as Adora follows her path along the waterways until she starts approaching others and Adora is forced to retreat to the distant shrine to avoid the light of day. She needs to stay hidden, but it's still nice. It's the perfect place to just stay and be, but that isn't in the cards for them.

Catra appears midday to tell her they're leaving – not only Seawothy, but also Kyle. Given Catra's future plans for their ship – pending Shadow Weaver's approval, at least – he would be a liability to bring along. He was living with Rogelio before Catra brought him along as bait in the first place. Now he can be with his boyfriend and they can fall into their old routine of working in the shipyard while waiting for Bonnie to stop in between voyages. He comes to help Adora over the land spit shortly after Catra leaves and waves goodbye to her cheerily, promising to take care of Oswald, as she swims out to meet the sailfmoon.

Catra's shopping trip was successful. Now she has a solid – and more importantly, soft – canvas net to easily lift Adora in and out of the water with. Adora isn't getting back in that tank, but Catra doesn't ask her to. The crew emptied it and filled it with extra fresh water for the journey while they were in port. Instead, Catra goes shopping for something. She didn't have a hard goal in mind, just something large that can be filled with water. She ended up buying a trough. Adora can't live in it, but that's not the intent.

They've already filled it with ocean water, and it has a valve on the side for easy emptying to avoid the stagnation problem of the tank. Adora meets back up with the ship after a bit of swimming around the coastline blind, and the canvas net lowers into the water. Adora climbs into it easily. It's like being back in their old hammock as Catra lifts her up out of the water. She grins at her girlfriend as she reaches the deck, reaching out her arms for her and pulling her close once the net is settled on the deck.

"I love you. You're the most gorgeous pirate in the whole world," Adora praises, uncaring about the crew watching as she scatters kisses along the side of Catra's face. Catra pulls a face and pretends to try to wiggle away from her wet embrace, but she's purring as she hugs Adora back. Healthy and energetic, Adora can easily drag herself to Catra's private quarters with just her arms. She knows it looks ridiculous, but it still feels more dignified than being carried, and the less work they make for the crew, the less likely they are to get resentful.

Adora can't spend more than an hour in the trough – it only submerges her as much as a large tub would, her tail trailing out over the edge and her head leaned back against the edge – but it gives her time to just hang out and be with Catra as they sail on for the Sea of Sigh. Catra's eyes are soft as she watches Adora settle into the tub, moving to close her door and then crossing over to frame Adora's face with her hands, pressing kisses all across her face. Adora trills, nudging up happily into the touch.

"I love you too, you know. I've just got to be the big bad pirate in front of the crew," Catra tells her between kisses. Adora trills again, entirely too fond of the woman above her. She tilts her chin, a high note of satisfaction singing out when Catra takes the prompt and bends to kiss her for real. Being a siren has changed her a lot, including her sex drive, but Adora still watched sirens kiss each other as part of their relationships down in Salineas. Adora may only be interested in sex for how it makes Catra feel now, but she loves

kissing her just as much as before. The fact that Catra tastes amazing in every regard only helps.

"Bonnie has watched you chase your own tail," Adora points out when they part. It was back when she was really little and her tail first got long enough to chase, but still, "badass pirate" is quite a front for Catra to put on, especially with this crew. Catra lets out an affronted scoff, a high squeak in it as she puffs up in indignation. It's fucking adorable. It doesn't help her case, but it does make Adora grin.

"She has also watched me hit a bottle on the crow's nest with a handgun. Stop insulting your wife," Catra returns. Adora would keep teasing her, but she's grinning too hard at the word *wife* to reply. It might not be official, but there isn't really a structure for overseeing marriage out on the high seas. If they say they're married, then they are. No one else gets a say in it.

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Adora comes up to the tub three times a day. They still have to stop – or at least slow – the ship for her to get in it, but it's not as disruptive as the lifeboat method. Now that she is healthy, Adora can just jump straight down from the edge of the deck when she starts getting too dry. Even better, she and Catra get a lot longer together when they do this. It is less comfortable for Adora than being in the water beside the lifeboat was, but it is way more comfortable for Catra, and they can touch, kiss, and hug far more easily.

It is a trade-off, but this way they can talk. Catra sits leaned against one side of the tub, her hand trailed inside to hold Adora's, as she quietly tells Adora about her weeks of mourning on the Black Garnet before Shadow Weaver kicked her off. She had Catra take a trip on the ship Bonnie was on at the time, dropping her off at Seaworthy.

She had no assignment. Shadow Weaver just told her to pull herself together, and that she would call on her when she had a gap on a crew that need filling.

It was weeks more before she found out that she had an upcoming assignment – in that time, she had to wonder if Shadow Weaver would ever assign her at all or if she had been tossed aside completely. Finding out she was finally getting a captaincy was exciting, but she had to wait even longer for Shadow Weaver to put together the rest of the crew, get them a ship, and get everyone gathered in Seaworthy. Catra spent the months when Adora was figuring out her new powers utterly lost, scraping by however she could and mostly surviving by the mercy of her friends providing her somewhere safe to stay.

Adora tells her about her months in turn – about being drowned, about the worst kiss in history that still makes Catra indignant despite how Adora describes it as such, and her few weeks down in the hidden merkingdom of Salineas. They don't have a government, not really, they're just a community that has built a life on the ocean floor. Sometimes they work together to drown ships – they don't need to eat that much if they aren't using their magic, so it's easy to share the crew of a ship between them – but some of them are more independent, like Adora is, at least for now.

They showed Adora the ropes with a group hunt as she adjusted to her abilities, and then she returned to the waters where the Black Garnet had last been sailing to hunt for Catra. It wasn't there, but Adora knew it was unlikely it would be. From then on, everything she did was in search of her lost lover. She skims over what she did with the ships she sank, explaining that she needed to make sure she had full magic stores and that she was hunting for Catra. She is nervous to admit it – to say what she has *done* – and she flinches when Catra pulls a face.

"Wait, were you planning to tell me? I'm one of the ocean, Adora," she asks, a high strain in her voice. Adora blinks, surprised that is what she was upset about, and quickly looks away.

"Not *planning* on it, I just wanted to be ready. Ships sink. Can you honestly tell me you'd rather be dead than a siren?" I was willing to do whatever let us stay together," Adora returns. Catra's nose twitches and she looks away. Her mouth is turned down in a conflicted pout, but she says nothing. She thought Adora was dead – she knows what it is like to go through that loss. Adora *is* going to turn Catra if she has to in order to save her, but even in the event of shipwreck, they don't have to jump straight to the kiss. Adora can help her to the surface if need be.

"I just want to have the magic on hand if we do end up needing it. It saved me once already. Between what I used up in the tank, healing, it depleting naturally, and using it to adjust my new voice, I'm getting low already. I'll need to bring another ship down in a week or two, and I don't have enough to turn you right now," Adora explains to her. Catra winces at the mention of the tank, wrapping an arm around herself and nodding as she looks down guiltily.

"I'm sorry, by the way. For the tank and the fucking harpoons and telling you *no*. I didn't realize how bad it was, and I was just so scared of losing you again," Catra whispers. Adora feels her breath hitch. In all their years together, Catra has rarely apologized, or at least not with words. Adora reaches out, taking Catra's hands in both of her own and squeezing gently.

"It's okay. You didn't even know it was me at first. As long as you don't try to put me in a tank again, we'll be fine," Adora promises her, trying to inject some humor in her voice. Catra snorts, shaking her head a little as she looks up to make eye contact with Adora again. After a moment, she pushes up from her spot beside the trough, sitting on a chair. Adora blinks in surprise as Catra reaches for the hem of her shirt and whips it off.

Watching Catra inexplicably strip, Adora forgets herself, letting out a flustered note that trembles a little at the end as Catra's belt hits the floor. Catra smirks as she pulls off her pants and steps out of them. Adora flushes as her underwear joins them on the floor. A moment

later, Catra steps into the trough, carefully setting her foot beside Adora and then climbing in on top of her, water be damned.

Adora is flustered having a naked Catra on top of her, but after Catra has settled in and gotten comfortable, she wraps her arms around her and cuddles her close. Catra hates the water. She hates the beach, and sand. She still doesn't hesitate to endure it to settle into Adora's arms, beginning to purr as she cuddles against Adora's chest. Adora trills, nuzzling against Catra happily. Yes, they have barriers now, but they can make it work.

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It takes them six days to reach the Sea of Sigh. In that time, they catch up with each other, Adora's new voice starts sounding like her own again – at least to her ears, Catra insists it still isn't quite there, but Adora is learning how to speak again without it sounding like broken glass at least – and the crew seems to grow more comfortable with her presence. Part of it is that she can talk now, even if she hardly does it in front of them.

They seem more at ease after Bonnie strikes up a teasing conversation with her about her nakedness while pulling Adora's net up out of the water. It has Adora embarrassed and covering her chest with one arm, shooting back that fabric kind of falls apart after long enough underwater, but the conversation seems to hammer in for the rest of the crew that she is capable of things like shame and higher thought.

She's capable of more than they know, but she's keeping that close to her chest. Her lover is incredulous enough when Adora tells Catra about some of her abilities. When they reach the Sea of Sigh, Adora starts getting bold, venturing further from the ship than she has dared before. Catra is more comfortable with Adora disappearing

now, sure she'll come back and knowing how to find her if she doesn't. The freedom lets her scout for the Black Garnet.

She doesn't find it, but she finds the next best thing: dolphins. They're smart. She swims with them for a few minutes, acclimatizing to the group. She listens to them, getting a rough baring on a nearby coral reef, two islands, and a "large animal" in the water that startled them earlier. From their impression of it, Adora thinks it's a ship, which means it could be the Black Garnet. It's only a rough idea, but it's a lead.

Now she just has to find the Halfmoon again.

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She swims back to where she thinks she left the Halfmoon and then swims on based on where she thinks its heading should have taken it, but she finds nothing there. She tries not to panic. She and Catra can and will find each other again if she loses the ship. Sirens have an innate sense of direction that puts her old navigation abilities to shame, but she can only predict where the Halfmoon should be by now. If it changed course, she's fucked.

She circles out from where she thinks it should be, anxiety buzzing in her chest. It makes her feel sick as she alternates between hoping that Catra has noticed her missing and stopped and praying that she hasn't because then she'll be worried. Adora sings a mournful song as she swims. She has to let the terrible anxiety in her chest out somehow, and she can only hope that her lost lover will hear her begging for her and follow the sound.

When she feels a large disturbance in the water up ahead, her heart leaps in her chest. She puts on a burst of speed, swimming eagerly forward and leaping above the waves to get a look. Her heart drops

all over again when she sees not the Halfmoon, but the Black Garnet. The sun is setting by now. The massive, black ship looms over Adora, blocking the quickly-vanishing sunlight. The paint is chipped all over the hull, and lanterns and candles glitter in the portholes, up in the crow's nest, and across the deck.

The Black Garnet is giant, an imposing figure against the pink-stained sky that has signaled the death of countless sailors before Adora. She swallows, sinking down so only her eyes are peeking out of the water. She's not a sailor anymore. She doesn't know if that raises or lowers her chances. Worse yet, this isn't the Halfmoon. Catra has changed her course. Perhaps she has even doubled back, aware she has lost Adora and sailing back for Seaworthy. It wouldn't make a lot of sense, though.

Catra has come all this way already. Meeting with Shadow Weaver and explaining the situation makes more sense, but if she is aware that she has lost Adora, she would have right to be nervous about walking into a meeting with Shadow Weaver empty-handed. They promised to stick together, but Catra has always been insecure. Adora would never leave Catra alone for a meeting with Shadow Weaver. She has to trust that Catra knows that and hasn't doubled back.

Her best bet is to stay with the Black Garnet. If she found it so close to where the Halfmoon should be, it's possible Catra will find it soon. Adora doesn't know how long she should wait – a day or two, probably – before doubling back to Seaworthy herself, but Catra was headed here. It is Adora's best bet. If she can safely stay out of sight, then she can follow the ship until she's certain Catra would have found it by now. If she has doubled back for Seaworthy, she will still be there even if Adora delays before returning.

As she ducks beneath the water to swim in the Black Garnet's wake, she is infinitely grateful that she and Catra set that meeting spot. A moment like this is exactly what she feared.

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Following the Black Garnet is nerve-wracking. If anyone on board spots a siren, it will become hunting season in a heartbeat. The ship is bristling with cannons. At every moment, Adora has to keep her ears peeled and her mouth shut. She hates it. Her week of swimming along the Halfmoon, happily singing whenever she wanted to and then riding a hammock up into Catra's waiting arms, feels like a daydream compared to following the black behemoth.

The sun sets and the seas darken around her. Adora's heart feels wrung out without Catra. The upside to running on magic is she is kind of immortal, as long as she sustains herself, but the downside is that when her mood turns, it makes her feel ill. Her magic buzzes darkly in her chest, clouded by her anxiety. She is so tense, she almost screams when the ship horn rings out, shattering the night. She barely manages to hold down the noise that would give her away, her heart racing.

That horn only means one thing – another ship is approaching, and they have a limited window to signal from the crow's nest that they're friendly with the Horde. At night, normally it is done via covering and uncovering a lantern in the crow's nest to flash a light in the Horde's secret signal pattern. Adora's heart whimpers in her chest. Maybe, just maybe, it's the one ship she wants to see. She dives beneath the man-of-war, beating her tail to overtake it as she circles around to the side where other ships dock.

The darkness of night is working to her advantage now, though she knows she still sticks out with her golden hair and white tail. Carefully, she peeks just her eyes above the waves and peers around. On the horizon, she sees a ship approaching, a flame flickering in its crow nest. It's a Horde ship at least, and it looks to be around the right size and shape to be Catra's brigantine. Adora isn't waiting. Her heart is racing now with the possibility. She dives

beneath the waves, the sick feeling that was in her chest gone as excitement buzzes beneath her skin.

That energy fuels her as she swims quickly towards the ship on the horizon. She can't risk surfacing too early and getting spotted by the wrong people. Most hulls look the same beneath the surface, but it doesn't look like it *is not* the Halfmoon, so she just has hope as she dives under the ship and surfaces on the other side, as close to the hull as she can. She turns, looking up at the side of the ship, and feels relief flood through her at the familiar sight of the Halfmoon's hull.

She can't sing, it's too risky this close to the Black Garnet. She can't stay silent either. She chirps instead. It's a sound a number of other creatures can make, but it causes a scramble on deck. A moment later, Catra flings herself against the railing, gripping it tight as she leans over it to search the waves. Adora feels breathless, raising her hand to wave up at her lover. Up on the deck, Catra breaks into a huge, relieved grin. A moment later, her laughter rings out on the wind.

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Adora stays in the water. As much as she wants to come up and see Catra after being separated for half a day, they don't trust Shadow Weaver not to pull something, so Adora should stay where she is mobile and can dive straight down to escape. Bonnie leans over the railing to wave at her as Catra disappears to go through docking procedures and request a meeting with Shadow Weaver. Adora can just barely detect her voice drifting over from the other side of the ship as Catra initiates the process, whatever it is.

Adora keeps the Halfmoon between her and the Black Garnet. It gives her a safe place to surface, even if she has to stay quiet to not

cause panic on their neighboring ship. With the half moon still, she can safely dive down and enjoy the calmness of deeper waters, though she surfaces frequently so she doesn't miss Shadow Weaver's arrival. The moon is sinking low in the sky, though the night is still dark, when Adora resurfaces and hears voices up on deck.

She can't understand them from down here. She chirrups a little to signal her presence and the voices immediately pause. A moment later, a familiar black figure looms over the railing, Catra by her side. This time, Adora doesn't grin and wave. She is low in the water, anxious, and she just blinks up at the pair and gives a soft warble of greeting, her ear fins flexing with the sound. Shadow Weaver looks down at her for a long moment. From the water, Adora can't make out her body language.

"I knew you were too incompetent to captain a ship, but this is below even my expectations," Shadow Weaver sneers. Adora feels her heart plummet, gaping up at them as Shadow Weaver pushes off the railing and disappears from her sight line. She's still talking, but it's too low for Adora to make out the words now. Catra, to Adora's dismay, doesn't seem surprised. She grips the railing tightly, her mouth pressed into a thin line as she makes eye contact with Adora. Her eyes are burning. Shadow Weaver's voice rises again, audible above the wind for a moment.

"—*ever* letting her out of the tank again-" Shadow Weaver says, before her words become inaudible again. Catra doesn't even twitch. She was expecting the words. Adora was only below the surface for a few minutes, but an argument clearly started in that time. Catra doesn't break eye contact with Adora. With her back shielding her from Shadow Weaver, she mouths one word to Adora. *Run*. Adora swallows. To her dismay, Catra pushes off the railing and turns away before Adora can shake her head.

Shadow Weaver wants her back in the tank. She can't survive in there. Catra is telling her to run to save herself, but Catra is clearly upset. Shadow Weaver was likely chewing her out while Adora was

beneath the waves. If Adora vanishes, she doesn't doubt that Catra will be punished. They're arguing up on the deck, but Adora can't understand the words over the billowing sea breeze. There's a low utterance, and then Catra releases a yell of frustration.

"*No*. I'm not fucking doing it. You're not locking her away," Catra yells, her voice twisted and angry. Immediately, Shadow Weaver's voice hurries to silence her, too low for Adora to understand. She's trying to stop Catra from warning Adora away, but Adora already got the message – this isn't going to Catra's plan. Shadow Weaver wants Adora locked up and muzzled as if she was any other siren. Adora's heart pounds in her chest as Catra snarls on the deck above. A half second later, Catra's voice becomes a muffled yell. A fight has begun and they're trying to *silence her*.

Catra worked so hard for this ship. She gave blood, sweat, and tears to go anywhere in the Horde. Adora was willing to agree to just about anything to let her keep it. She can't let her get hurt, though. She opens her mouth and calls out, a desperate, begging warble. She hears Catra's muffled yelling in response. There's no words, but she's desperate. Adora dives beneath the waves, her song changing to a call to arms as she surfaces on the other side of the Halfmoon and looks up to the bridge extended between it and the Black Garnet.

There's yelling up on the deck, but Adora pours all her energy into the song, amplifying it with her magic until it drowns out every other sound, the air quivering with it. There's a long, terrifying moment where she has no idea what happened on deck, and then a body goes sailing over the railing and gunshots ring out in the midst of the song. It's a man's body, so it at least isn't part of the Halfmoon's crew. Adora doesn't stop singing, *can't* sing, as gunshots fire not only from the Halfmoon, but behind her on the Black Garnet. A moment later, the boom of a canon rings out and the side of the Halfmoon explodes.

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Adora dives, never silencing her song as she swims swiftly away from the sinking Halfmoon. The canons should be aimed at her, and if she draws them away, it gives Catra and her ship the best chance at survival. Adora swims from the stern to the bow of the Black Garnet, singing all the while and listening to the sounds of gunshots, explosions, and yelling on board. Adora's song is a roar, anguish and hurt in her chest as she orders *ladies, hold of the sea*. It feels like twisted magic in her chest.

She has never drowned a ship like this before. She didn't even know that she could, but as she doubles back towards the Halfmoon, diving beneath the waves to avoid cannon fire, she commands the sailors to tear their own ship apart. Explosions rock it. There are women on board, but they're a small percentage compared to the men, and Adora is terrified and enraged. She pours that emotion into her song, into the men, and the Black Garnet rocks in the water until a large explosion near the stern blows out a hole in it.

It can't be recovered from, but it's also *too close* to where the Halfmoon is docked. Adora screeches, a horribly violent sound that spikes in the middle of her song as she bellows it, thrashing her tail for a speed boost to double back to the Halfmoon again. It's already half-sunken between the canon shot and the damage of the second explosion. There are people scrambling on the deck. Adora desperately circles the wreck, never daring to silence her song and have the entire crew of the Black Garnet turn on her. Now that she has started this, she has to finish it, but she needs to find Catra.

She can't have gotten shot. She can't be dead. Adora doesn't have the magic to raise her, and she doesn't know if it would even work when the cause of death was something other than drowning. She circles the wreck, breaching above the waves to scan the wreckage before diving down again to search for Catra's profile in the water below. The sea vibrates with her song and the explosions still

emanating from the Black Garnet, but it's pitch black from the dark night.

A profile. Short and not Catra, but familiar. Adora dives for it, still singing as she grips Bonnie's shoulder. She digs her claws in, breaking flesh, but she needs to grip her and she thinks Bonnie would prefer scars to drowning. She is dazed, not even thrashing as Adora pulls her back up to the surface. When she breaks it, still singing, she reaches down with both hands and raises Bonnie up above the waves. Mercifully, she isn't so unconscious that she doesn't cough, choking on water before she gasps in the air.

Adora turns her head, scanning the waves as Bonnie hauls in air. The Halfmoon has almost completely disappeared below the surface. Only half the deck and the mast remain above the waves, slowly dragging down beneath them. Adora needs to search for Catra, but she also can't abandon Bonnie to drown. She is unconscious. There is blood in the water, but it isn't coming from her, so something during the wreck must have knocked her out. If only she had a boat-

The lifeboat. Adora drops Bonnie in an instant. She'll float for a moment, and that's all she needs to do. Adora swims for the deck of the Halfmoon. In the water, she sees pirates from the Black Garnet that must have been on the deck when the Halfmoon sank. Shadow Weaver had a show of force with her. No wonder the fight broke out so quickly. She thought she could silence Catra before Adora figured out what was going on.

Adora swims along the deck until she reaches where the lifeboat is tied. Slicing through the ropes is a simple matter – grabbing the boat and beating her tail as hard as she can to fight the weight of the water holding it halfway beneath the waves is not. She has to pull it up sideways, carefully righting it once it breaks the surface so the water pours out. It still has some in it, but as long as it remains buoyant, she doesn't care.

She pauses her song for a moment to gasp for air. The night is filled with explosions and screaming. Adora gulps in air and then bellows out again, diving beneath the waves to return to where she left Bonnie. She is sinking again. Adora grabs her , desperately hauling her back to the boat and flinging her over the edge. She doesn't wait for Bonnie to gasp for air or for the lifeboat to stop rocking – she swims past, her head spinning from lack of oxygen and her heart pounding.

She has to find Catra.

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It takes several moments of desperately searching the waves, but Adora's heart leaps when she catches sight of a bedraggled form limp against a section of board that Adora thinks used to be the bridge between boats. Adora is breathless, her chest aching. When she spots Catra's ears, confirming she has found her, the song dies in her throat. Catra doesn't know how to swim and Adora was running on pure terror. She doesn't have the strength to continue her song now she has found Catra, but nobody should be trying to turn the cannons on them now.

The Black Garnet's stern is sinking low in the water, flooding the rest of the ship and dragging down her bow as well. She is a lost cause and sharks have appeared in the water. None of them have dared to get too close to the halfmoon with Adora circling it, but anyone on the Black Garnet should be scrambling for a lifeboat as they come to their senses. Adora can dedicate all her energy to Catra. She dives through the waves, surfacing right next to the board and reaching up to claw at Catra's arm, tugging desperately.

Catra's head whips around, panic in her face before she meets Adora's eyes and breathes out. The sigh of relief turns into a water-

logged cough. Catra is soaking and reeks of blood, causing Adora to swallow and release her arm, staring at the palm of her own hand. It is covered in Catra's blood – too much blood for Adora's claws to have done it on accident. Catra finishes coughing, raising up a little on the board and then collapsing against it when the movement causes it to rock.

"Lucky shot. It grazed me. I'll be fine. No need to drown me yet," Catra assures, her voice hoarse. Adora swallows. She doesn't have the magic to do that anyway, but all around her are souls. She reaches out, slipping her arm beneath Catra's torso, and carefully pulls her from the board. Catra groans as Adora flips onto her back and cradles Catra against her chest. She thinks otters do something like this with their babies. It doesn't work so well for Catra – the waves lap up, causing her to cough as they hit her face.

Adora beats her tail. She knows where to take Catra. She swims through the wreckage of the Halfmoon – now only her mast above water - until she reaches the lifeboat. Catra, struggling to keep her head above water, widens her eyes when she spots it. Adora swims up alongside it, holding still so Catra can reach for it and gratefully climb in. Her eyes go even wider when she spots Bonnie, hurrying to sit her up despite her own obvious exhaustion. When she sees Bonnie let out a breath, Catra sighs with relief, sitting down heavily on the water-laced bottom of the boat.

She looks exhausted, her fur, clothes, and mane plastered against her, making her appear thin despite how Adora knows she is muscled beneath it all. Her eyes are only half-open as she turns to look to Adora, reaching out with her good arm to thump Bonnie on her back and cause her to cough, more water dribbling out of her mouth as she does so. If she wasn't leaned against Catra's side, she would likely fall over with the movement, but Catra props her up despite her bloodied arm.

"The rest of my crew . Save who you can. And please, eat, you need it," Catra tells her , coughing a little. If Adora wasn't still panting to draw in her lacking air and calm her nerves, she would press her

mouth into a thin line, but as it is, she just nods and releases the side of the boat. Catra will be safe there. Anyone who might try to climb in that Catra doesn't want to join her would be as waterlogged as she is. Their guns would be useless, the gunpowder soaked, and Catra still has claws to fight back with. She's in bad shape, but Catra has always been able to defend herself.

Adora turns away, surveying the wreckage around her with her heart pounding. The night is filled with screams, curses, and the groaning of the Black Garnet as she sinks. They're floating just to the side of the whole thing, off to the side of the Halfmoon. The water is sprinkled with debris and, closer to the Black Garnet, pirates surfacing to tread water, but the men who accompanied Shadow Weaver spent too long bewitched by Adora's song and are now lost beneath the waves.

Adora has a massive crew of souls before her that are going to be lost anyway. She can finally refill her magic stores. She takes a moment to breathe, her head still spinning. She'll be okay, but it will take a few minutes for her to catch up on everything she let out in her song. With the water so agitated, there should be plenty of oxygen for her gills at least. Adora dives back into the waves. She'll work through the wreckage of the Halfmoon first, searching for Catra's crew, and then she'll move out to join the sharks in their feasting.

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She only manages to save two more. Scorpia is desperately treading water nearby, blocked from view from the lifeboat by a floating barrel. Adora almost gets punched when she pops up in front of Scorpia, but when she ducks and warbles, Scorpia recognizes her. She is clearly uneasy, but she lets Adora wrap an arm around her and

guide her back to the boat. Catra is tying up her bleeding left arm with a makeshift-bandage cut from her shirt when they arrive.

She perks up when she spots Adora dragging Scorpia. The idea of leaving Catra while she is injured pains Adora, but after Scorpia climbs in, Catra shoos her on. Adora reluctantly leaves her in the care of Scorpia and returns to her search. The Bellmoon is sinking quick, the hole in it massive, and it seems very few of the crew that were in the middle crew deck escaped after the cannon blast hit it. At least their deaths were likely quick.

Entrapta very nearly drowns. Adora finds her trapped beneath a piece of wreckage, her air so depleted she is no longer struggling. It seems she tried to flee from below deck too quickly and got stuck. A hook got her leg, trapping her by her clothes but also cutting into her flesh. Adora makes the wound worse pulling her free, but Entrapta needs air. Injured is better than dead. When Adora pulls her to the surface, she doesn't even breathe in.

Adora panics. She punches her in the gut. It probably isn't the right thing to do, but it still works, and water goes gushing out of Entrapta's mouth. She coughs, hacks, and spits water as Adora uses her arm strength to hold her above the waves for a few moments so she can gasp. As soon as she thinks she can risk lowering her again, Adora swims her back to the boat. Catra has gone limp on the bench now. She managed to get Bonnie to cough out the water still in her lungs, but that was all she had in her.

Scorpia is awake and uninjured at least. She pulls Entrapta out of Adora's arms and into the boat, setting on helping her cough out her water as well as Catra makes tired eye contact with Adora over the edge of the boat and nods her thanks. She is too tired to say it, huddling against Bonnie as the cold sea breeze threatens to bring sickness upon their soaked forms, but one crisis at a time. Adora nods to her, and then she dives again.

She spent too long on the first four. She doesn't find the others, not alive at least. Some of them float face down in the water, the sparks

of their magic already dead when Adora reaches them. Some of them are seemingly gone, lost amongst the wreckage. Those are the ones that still have hope at being alive somewhere at least. Adora is suddenly very glad they didn't bring Kyle. It didn't make sense with their plans anyway, but he was never a strong swimmer.

Crew lost, Adora turns to the men. Magic buzzes in the water, flowing from them and into her. Sparks dance through her skin, warming her as she feels her energy replenishing. Exhaustion was setting in as the immediate danger to Catra subsided, but with the boost from the magic, she easily swims amongst the wreckage, seeking more as she begins to feel *full* for the first time in weeks. She dives deeper, trying to stay relatively close to the lifeboat in case the sharks start circling this way and bothering them.

As she dives down in the deep, hoping to at least account for more of the crew, her heart plummets as she sees black hair rising like smoke. Shadow Weaver's body is too far down to be recoverable, though when Adora reaches out and touches her, she feels a small spark still within her. Adora recoils, beating her tail to flee back to the surface as quickly as she can. She can't save her, but she can't kill her either. She has enough magic to turn her, but she can do that no more than she can be the hand that ends her.

She flees, leaving the woman to her fate at the hands of the ocean which she ruled over for so long. It sends an unpleasant jolt through Adora's body, brimming with magic and easily swayed by her mood. She has feasted enough now. She feels alive, humming with energy. She can last a long time on this supply, and she even has enough to give Catra the kiss of life should she need it. Adora can't stand plunging through the depths surrounded by dead bodies any longer.

It's time to return to Catra and figure out what the hell they're going to do now.

Chapter End Notes

Sharks are good animals but everyone has to eat. They do swarm around shipwrecks and pick off people sometimes, causing a feeding frenzy if the conditions are right. Similar to humans at Best Buy on Black Friday.

Catra the Castaway

Chapter Notes

> It's important (well, to me) to note that when Bonnie calls Catra "cat," she is calling her the animal because she's a magicat and not shortening her name. She also calls Rogelio "croc" despite him not being that kind of lizard. She used to call Catra "kitty cat" to piss her off, but now they're a little less antagonistic towards each other, she calls her "cat" to needle her to a lesser degree (tho still purposefully needling XD). That Catra allows her to do it says a lot about their relationship.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra can't remember the last time she felt this exhausted. Every inch of her body is drained. The current dragged her down with the sinking ship and fighting it took every ounce of energy she had, especially with her arm bleeding after the fight broke out on deck. She wasn't expecting Shadow Weaver to just suddenly turn on her like that, but she should have been after how angry she was when Catra explained the situation on the bridge to the Black Garnet.

She suddenly calmed, asking Catra to show her. She was still insistent that Adora go in a tank, but it gave Catra hope that she was convincing her. Now she realizes it was all a ploy. She wanted Catra to put Adora back in the tank, muzzling her for the "safety" of everyone on the Black Garnet, and then she probably would have thrown Catra overboard and trapped Adora in a tank for the rest of her days.

Catra is too tired to do much of anything now. She is relieved that Scorpia seems no worse for wear. She still has energy, helping Entrapta to empty her lungs and stomach of sea water before she fully passes out again. Entrapta was below deck when the fight began and Catra feared she would be lost in the cannon blast like

the others. It would have been a damn shame. She is odd, yes, but she has a brilliant mind and a good heart.

"At least my three favourite crew members made it out," Catra jokes, her voice scratchy as she huddles into Bonnie's side. She is fucking freezing. Scorpia, searching the bottom of the boat, looks up to her and offers her a small, strained smile. Mentioning that everybody else is dead – or likely dead, Catra can see pirates floating, treading water, and clinging to wreckage throughout the field of debris, they just aren't her crew – isn't the cheeriest route to go, but she has always used humor to cope.

"We've got only one oar, but the emergency supplies box is intact," Scorpia informs her. Catra grunts. She swallowed a lot of salt water and her throat feels like shit. She isn't going to talk unnecessarily. The immediate danger is passed but she doesn't know how they are going to get out of this or how long they are going to be stranded. They're in the middle of the Sea of Sighs. She has no idea if any land is close and, if so, what direction it is in. It's a relief when Adora resurfaces beside the boat again, though her eyes are wide and guilty.

She is empty-handed. She doesn't need to speak for Catra to know she doesn't think the rest of her crew survived. She is practically glowing in the water, shimmering under the moonlight, so Catra hopes she has eaten her fill. These people are mostly lost anyway. Their only real chance at survival is drifting on wreckage or in a lifeboat until another ship finds them. The Black Garnet still isn't fully submerged, her bow higher in the water but slowly sinking along with the rest of her. Her stern has disappeared completely.

"It's okay, my love. You saved four of us already. You did well. If you can find us another oar, we can start trying to get out of this. Supplies would help too," Catra assures her, her head lolling onto Bonnie's shoulder as she talks. In truth, she doesn't feel up to helping Scorpia row at all, but she knows she is only going to get worse the longer they're stuck in this situation. She doesn't know

what state Entrapta and Bonnie will be in when they wake up. Catra has to lead them out while she still can.

Adora warbles a little, clearly upset, but she nods and sinks back below the waves. Catra watches her hair disappear into the darkness before she lets her eyes slip closed. Just a moment of rest before she has to return to being the captain. Scorpia is still shifting in the boat, rearranging Entrapta and prepping them for what could be a long journey, but Catra has to save her energy for once it's time to start rowing. She isn't going to sleep with the sound of screaming sailors in the background, but resting her eyes helps.

"You really love her, huh?" Scorpia says, the boat rocking as she sits down opposite from Catra and Bonnie. Catra feels her tail twitch. Karma hates her. She put off this conversation and now she is being forced to have it at the worst possible time. Scorpia doesn't sound bitter at least. A bit resigned maybe, and tired too. She could just be trying to stay awake by talking. Scorpia joined Catra and Bonnie when the skirmish broke out on deck. She had Catra's back. With a sigh, Catra nods a little against Bonnie's shoulder.

"We've been together for a decade. She's my wife. I thought she drowned in that shipwreck. I didn't want to talk about it, even think about it," Catra mutters out. Scorpia is silent. Catra peeks one eye open to find her nodding. She looks disappointed, but acceptance is there too. Catra sighs, closing her eye again. "I meant it when I said you were my favorites on the crew. You were a great quartermaster, Scorpia," she adds on. The unspoken *but I love her* hangs between them, but Scorpia should have known that even before they found Adora again.

"And you were a good captain. We'll get out of this," Scorpia returns. Catra goes a little limp with relief. She is really glad Scorpia is still conscious. She needs all the help that she can get, and Scorpia was always quick and eager to give it. She never second-guessed Catra's decisions, not really. Sometimes she would ask questions, but she would always follow through on her orders no matter what

they were. With her in the boat, they might just have the strength to get out of this.

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Adora doesn't find them another oar, but she brings them a flask of water, an inexplicable golden goblet, a measure of rope, two guns, a bowl for bailing water, and clothes. When Catra raises her brow at the clothes, Adora pointedly looks down at her torn shirt.

"Fabric is fabric," she explains. After singing so long, she seems to be having issues talking again. Her voice still sounds like her own – well, almost, but it doesn't sound any less like her own than it did before – but she is speaking infrequently and in short sentences. She might just be tired like Catra is.

"Have you eaten enough?" Catra asks her, checking the guns. One is half-loaded, the other fully. Catra lost her personal pistol in the waves, as did Bonnie and Scorpia. Entrapta's is still on her belt. Having means to defend themselves makes Catra feel a bit better. Adora sinks a little in the water, seeming ashamed, but she nods. Catra grunts, snapping the gun barrel back into place. She doesn't want Adora to be ashamed of what she has to do to survive.

"Good. I want you full and healthy. Guess it's time to pick a direction and row," Catra tells her with a sigh. The moon is low in the sky, the first paleness of dawn beginning to show on the horizon. They've been drifting in this boat for a while. Being off to the side of the main ship is all that saved them from other pirates trying to swim over and climb in. Privately, Catra suspects Adora has eaten anyone who dared approach. She has spotted her pale shape in the waters around them many times as she searched for survivors, supplies, and her own food.

The Black Garnet is fully sunken beneath the waves now , at least except for her rigging, always the last to go. There is still yelling from the other sailors, panicked and warped by the strong sea winds. There is a shark frenzy going on around the ship. The stern of the ship was hit pretty significantly, but the bow was intact. There's not much floating wreckage for people to climb on to save themselves. Many people never made it out from below deck before the ship was filled with water thanks to Adora's song keeping them from trying to save themselves.

"I know where to go. The rope,"Adora says from the side of the boat. Catra turns away from watching to wreck to blink at her. Adora looks matter-of-fact, pointing to the rope she brought. Scorpia set to work coiling it on the bottom of the boat while Adora continued to search for supplies. "Tie it around me, and to the boat. I can pull you,"she explains. Catra stares at her, and then she chuckles. The image of Adora pulling the boat through the water like a cart-and-horse is the bit of levity she needs right now.

"Okay , but don't overwork yourself. You've done enough already, and we'll be fucked if you run out of energy too. How do you know where to go?"Catra returns, bending to pick up the rope. She scrutinizes it as she waits for a reply, trying to figure out how she's going to hook it up to both Adora and the boat.

"Dolphins told me. When I lost the ship, I was following a pod. There are islands nearby. I think I know the way to go,"Adora tells her . Catra, along with Scorpia, looks up to gape at Adora. Adora, sunken down to her chin in the water, just blinks at them as a wave rocks over her head. "I can talk to sea life now . Which is why I prefer not to eat them. Also, their souls are too small,"Adora tacks on, blinking up at Catra slowly. Catra stares back at her.

"Anything else you want to mention? While we're sharing secrets and stuff? I've got a stick-and-poke tattoo that's so bad I tell people it's a birthmark. Okay, now your turn,"Scorpia says, gesturing to Adora in the water. Adora blinks at her – as does Catra. She didn't think Scorpia was that good at lying. She remembers Scorpia trying

to show her the distorted birthmark that resembled a rabbit on her thigh. At the time, Catra just thought she was trying to flirt.

"I watched Shadow Weaver drown," Adora returns after a moment of silence. Catra swallows, feeling her ears twitch as Scorpia winces. That's the end of story time alright. Catra doesn't quite feel bad about it, but she sure as fuck doesn't feel good either. She finds the end of the rope, threading it through the tow hook on the bow, and turns to Scorpia.

"Help me with this," she instructs. Scorpia hurries to do so.

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They tie the other end of the rope around Adora's shoulders and waist in a kind of harness. Catra worries about it hurting her and makes her swear not to overexert, reminding her they have an oar still and can also drift, but it's a relief when Adora agrees and they finally set out. Scorpia is ready with the oar to help, but for the most part they sit back and watch Adora swim through the waves.

Catra has spent a lot of time watching her from up on the Halfmoon's deck. The angle was better, but she was also further away. This close, Adora glitters in the light of dawn as she swims. She isn't going fast, following Catra's instructions and not over-exerting herself, but her stamina since transforming has allowed her to easily keep up with a brigantine for two weeks. Going slowly to accommodate for her extra weight – and avoid capsizing the boat – she seems to swim with ease.

Catra only pulls her eyes off Adora when Entrapta wakes up. She is shockingly cheery for someone who nearly drowned in a shipwreck. Tired, yes, but she talks about how *fascinating* it was to see and laments not that she almost drowned, but that she didn't stay

conscious to watch the whole thing. Her energy is a bit invigorating, lifting up the flagging spirits in the boat as the sun rises in the sky. At least they're all dry by now.

The emergency stash of supplies is soaked through, including the rations there. It's better than nothing, but they don't have a lot of water even with the flask Adora found. Scorpia uses the bowl to bail out the water gathered at the bottom of the boat as Adora swims, and then they just have to pray for rain or an island if they want to have enough water to last while eating the salt-logged food. Adora seems confident in her dolphin-based intel, though.

Catra was so scared when she realized how long it had been since she looked over the edge and saw Adora. A strong wind had picked up from the southwest, altering their course a bit. She tried not to worry, but she stopped the ship and still, Adora didn't appear. She only decided to sail on because she thought it was possible that Adora had scouted out the Black Garnet and would be waiting for them there.

The relief she felt when she saw her there only paled in comparison to when Adora got her voice and Catra finally knew she really had her Adora back. And when she saw her for the first time again, but that was a giddy jolt of adrenaline she has never felt anything else like in her life. She is possessive and needy, and as much as she knows it's wrong, she likes having Adora tied to the boat. She knows she won't lose her in the sea again. Their situation is *shit*, but they're together.

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Bonnie wakes up at noon. She is disoriented and groggy – she hit her head on the deck when the cannon blast hit, apparently, because that's the last thing that she remembers and she has a lump on her

temple – but Catra is relieved to have her back in the land of the living, even if she is bitchy. Given their situation, Catra doesn't really blame her.

"You really couldn't figure out another way to get us out of that, huh, cat?" Bonnie needles her. Catra scowls at the nickname – she's a *mighta*, not some stray – but she just shrugs.

"I wasn't letting Shadow Weaver lock her up like a tropical fish. You saw what happened last time," Catra returns. She isn't ashamed of it. She'd do it again in a heartbeat. Maybe it doesn't make her a good person to trade the lives of everyone on the Black Garnet for Adora's and her own, but it does make her in love. Bonnie scoffs, slouching down in the boat until she's lying on the damp bottom with the ocean spray.

"You know, I never planned to follow you until the death, but you're not giving me much choice here," Bonnie comments from the bottom of the boat. Catra snorts. It's a joke. Sure, Catra didn't have Bonnie's unwavering loyalty, but she was her captain and Bonnie was going to follow her as long as she had a ship. She just doesn't anymore. The lifeboat doesn't count, except that Bonnie has nowhere else to go. Silence stretches for a moment. "What's the plan now, cat?" she asks.

She isn't following her blindly, but she is looking to her for guidance. Catra doubts that Bonnie would follow an order if she gave it, but apparently she still has faith in her as a leader. Catra swallows, looking up at the horizon. Physically, every one of them is miserable. Entrapta has a gouge in her calf to match the one in Catra's arm, Bonnie is nauseous from the pain in her head, they all need a freshwater bath and bedrest, and they don't have all that much food or water. What they do have is a destination.

Catra worked all her life to go somewhere in the Horde. To earn a ship, a place in this world, a right to make a living. That's gone now. No pirate in their right mind would work with the crew that sunk the Black Garnet. They'll be hated amongst the others in the Horde. The

horde will rebuild or fall apart, but piracy isn't a way forward for any of them now that they don't have a ship. Catra was miserable the last time she was stuck on land, but she was working a shit job while in mourning.

"Adora's taking us to an island. As long as it's inhabited, an island needs sailors and fishermen. In these waters, maybe they even need defenders. We'll gauge their attitude towards outsiders and make up a story. Even if they only need dockworkers at the moment, we'll make a life. We can get passage back to the mainland instead if we need to, even if we have to steal a ship," Catra decides. Bonnie squints up at her for a moment before closing her eyes and grunting. It's acceptable to her at least.

They really can't plan more until they find out where they are landing. Scorpia nods, seeming considering. Entrapta isn't bothered – she can go anywhere with a dock. She has building expertise in boats and their equipment. She will be useful anywhere there is demand. They just have to hope they find a civilization that is willing to give four shipwrecked sailors a chance.

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They see another boat on the horizon midday, but it appears small. It can't take them in, but it could still help – especially because a boat that small can't be far from land. They practically cheer when they see it, Adora putting on the speed as she drags them towards it. As they get closer, they realize it's a sailboat. They call out to it, grabbing its attention, and watch the two people on board panic. For a moment, Catra thinks they're going to try to run – or worse, fire on them – but Scorpia grabs a mostly white shirt from the bottom of the ship and waves it.

They have nothing to surrender, but sailors stop scrambling and squint at them instead. As they get closer, it becomes obvious it is a fishing boat. They are so desperate for directions, Catra isn't even thinking about them panicking at the sight of a siren until they are already pulling up alongside the other ship and the two fishermen gape down at Adora in the water. Adora, seeming to have the same realization as Catra, sinks down a little in the water, but she can't go deep enough to disappear without pulling down the boat too.

"She's civil, I promise! She's my wife," Catra scrambles to explain, standing quickly and motioning with her hands for them to calm. The two fishermen gape at her instead. Catra winces. She thinks their gunpowder should be dry enough for a shootout now if the men turn on Adora, but they should have prepared for this and detached her first. The fishermen exchange looks before one swears under his breath. Catra swallows.

"Please, our ship was attacked by the Horde's Black Garnet. We don't want any trouble, just directions. Do you know the way to land?" Catra asks them. That gets their attention. The man on the floor's expression turns dark in a way that can only mean *memories* while the one still standing winces and nods. He glances down to Adora in the water. Adora blinks up at him with her wide eyes, moving her tail slowly to rise above the surface.

"I won't hurt anyone," she promises, her voice soft. To Catra's shock, that's all it takes. The man's expression softens and he looks down to his friend, who sighs but pushes back up to a standing position and turns to man the sail. The apparent captain smiles before turning back to them.

"If the Black Garnet is prowling the waters, it isn't safe to be out fishing anyway. Follow us. Our village is small, but people pass through the port often. There will be room for you," he promises. A wave of relief passes through Catra as she eagerly nods.

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The men's sailboat is hardly bigger than the lifeboat. They aren't far from the island, apparently. It quickly becomes visible as they adjust course to head straight for it. Catra has to consider the possibility that these men are actually intending to rob them, but as they sail side-by-side, they chat. The men are brothers, born and raised in Octopus Cove. Catra hasn't heard of it, but apparently the nearby port on the island has ships stop to resupply before they take the last leg of their journey through the Sea of Sigh. Most importantly, the men aren't that unnerved by Adora's presence.

"Imagine having a siren in the harbor! Those horde ships would think twice about getting rowdy when they dock," the captain, the younger of the two, speculates. His brother is more cynical.

"Yeah, and the traders would think twice about doing it at all," he returns. His brother isn't deterred. He turns to Catra and calls across the gap between their ships.

"What is your plan now?" he asks. Catra blinks across at him, unsure how honest she should be.

"Make a life," is the only response she can think to give. It makes him grin. The last way Catra expected their day of being shipwrecked to end was being escorted to a local home's dock, but it is a relief when they reach it. The others hop off the boat gladly, but Catra stops to untie Adora from the boat first. She kisses her on the forehead as she does so, uncaring about the two men eyeing them as they tie up their own boat.

"Guard the boat, okay? I'll be back before sunset, or something has gone wrong. You know what to do," Catra promises her. Adora nods, beating her tail to rise out of the water and looking at her hopefully. Catra grins, leaning down to kiss her properly. She is in fantastic

spirits with *l ead* stretching before her. The world has fallen apart, but just maybe, they can rebuild something here.

"Come on. W e'll take you to the local healer," the younger brother offers as she steps onto the dock. They need the help. Catra's arm hurts like a bitch, Entrapta is limping, and Bonnie has claw marks in her shoulder that made her narrow her eyes at Adora when she finally registered them. As anxious as leaving Adora makes her, Adora can more than take care of herself. It seems like a small island. Catra just has to hope they have good intentions.

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Generally , the world is kind to those who have been shipwrecked, or at least other sailors are. They all know they could be the next ones needing help. Other boats will pull them aboard, sometimes even giving free passage back home if you can help out on the way. The island isn't that small. It has its main port, the fishing village where they landed, and more small settlements scattered around. The locals know the ways of the sea. They welcome them with open arms.

After the brothers take them to see the healer, who properly bandages both Catra and Entrapta, they're brought to the mayor to tell their story. Catra does the talking. These people seem kind and open, and she wants to meet them with the same energy to earn their trust, but admitting to being pirates still seems like a bad call. Instead, she presents them as a ship that was looking to parlay with the horde to get them to call off their siren hunt when they realized they were trying to hunt the captain's wife. The horde didn't believe in tame sirens and tried to blow them out of the water.

Catra is honest about Adora sinking the ship to defend them. They would likely hear about such a large sinking nearby given the port,

and it would look far worse to lie about it than to justify it now as self-defense. It sounds unbelievable, but Adora is right there when the mayor insists on proof. As they walk back to it, Adora rises up at the end of the dock. She smiles hopefully up at Catra. After the day of hardship, Catra's sense abandons her. She kneels right there, leaning down to kiss her wife despite how it leaves her vulnerable to attack from the strangers behind her.

"Tell them you're nice, my love," Catra instructs Adora when she pulls back, unable to stop smiling as her eyes roam over Adora's face. It's been two rough days between losing Adora in the sea and then being shipwrecked. All she wants to do is wrap up in her lover's arms, but they have to do this first. Adora rolls her eyes, but she is smiling too as she reaches up to hold Catra's hand. She looks up to the mayor, hanging warily back, though he looks like he could be receptive. He wouldn't have gotten within earshot of a siren if he wasn't, at least not if he is smart.

"I just want to be with my wife. Be kind to her and you will never have any trouble from me," Adora promises him. Catra snorts, squeezing her hand before she goes to stand. Adora whines a little, looking up at her with big eyes. Catra feels herself blush. She can't help that she likes when Adora is blatantly needy, but Catra is asking a lot of this man, and she needs to look him in the eye as she does so. She turns back to him.

"We don't really have anywhere to go. We're just sailors. We can pull our weight. Fishing, repairing boats, working the docks, anything. And we're pretty good shots, too," Catra tells him. He looks her up and down, appraising, but then he looks down to Adora in the water. Maybe they wouldn't treat just any sailors with such kindness, but the mayor seems to see the benefit in befriending a siren.

"Ensure she won't attack anyone but Horde and Primary Navy ships, and we won't have a problem. We prefer the pirates to the invaders, honestly, but they are both a problem. If they come to raid us, she helps defend us," he offers as a deal. Catra will take that readily –

the locals seeing Adora as a defender rather than a predator is the best thing she could ask for. She nods.

The mayor definitely suspects something about their origins – he would be a fool not to – but if staying in Adora's good graces is enough motivation for him not to turn them away, then Catra will take it. This is what she wanted for them in the horde – Adora free and able to use her abilities in defense. Guarding the port will give her food, at least, and as long as Catra can get work, they will be fine.

Getting another ship won't just *happen*. Those opportunities are rare. For now, she is going to have to be a retired sailor. As the mayor leads them back to the village – half-built on the water, meaning Adora has plenty of pathways crossing over the ocean where she can follow them closely – she tells herself that of all the places to end up, it could have been far worse.

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They stay in the mayor's house that night. He feeds them dinner too. He talks with them during it, assessing their skills. Apparently he is determined to place them with someone in his village who could use their skills. Catra doesn't know if it is altruism, a genuine need for labor, or if he is just sucking up to the crew friendly with a siren, but no matter his motivation, it works out in their favor. As they eat, Bonnie clears her throat.

"With all due respect, captain, I do have a home. Back in Seaworthy. I'd like to try my luck finding a ship to take me there in the port," Bonnie tells her. Bonnie has *never* addressed her so respectfully before, even when Catra had a ship to captain. It must be performative for the mayor, but Catra still feels kind of touched. She nods her approval to her, looking to the mayor. He looks thoughtful.

"You can walk it, but not on your injury. Join one of the men sailing there with his catch in the morning. They won't ask anything of you," he returns. Bonnie looks relieved, nodding. She has a fair point. She has a family, if an odd one, and even a cottage to return to. Catra's only family just keeps her close to the ocean. Anywhere with a coastline is fine for her. Entrapta pipes up that the port would be the best place for her to stay, gushing about maybe getting to work on new ships. Bonnie laughs and says she doesn't mind having her along, and Catra gives her blessing again, but she feels a suspicion building.

After dinner, she goes out and sits on the mayor's porch – his house is built on stilts over the water, like most of the village seems to be – and tells Adora about dinner. She assures her that they will get by on the island before she is forced to retreat back inside when the mayor calls to her. Adora whispers that she'll be in the waters right under the mayor's house all night, and Catra feels a bit better. She sleeps at least, despite doing so on matts on the living room floor. In the morning, however, her suspicion is confirmed. Scorpia pulls her aside and tells her that she is going with Entrapta and Bonnie too, though like Entrapta, she isn't trying to leave the island entirely.

"I have nowhere to go, but I'm strong. There will be plenty of work for me at the port. And the three of us could still be together!" she says, a little too cheerily, as the ship prepares to leave. She looks hopeful, but Catra turns her face away, her eyes searching the water until she spots Adora lurking under a neighboring dock, her blue eyes blinking slowly back at Catra. Scorpia wants Catra to join her and Entrapta in living at the port, but she can't. She is staying. This fishing village reminds her of Seaworthy with how built on the water it is, and she has Adora to worry about.

The village leader is willing to accept her presence, but the larger port likely won't, and the ships passing through would always be a danger regardless. Catra feels, maybe, a bit paranoid. All her childhood, Shadow Weaver and the Horde were her personal boogeymen. She can't imagine attacking them not having

consequences. She doesn't want to go to the port where she could be recognized by a passing Horde ship. Growing up at Shadow Weaver's left hand, a lot of people recognize her face. Bonnie, Scorpia, and Entrapta can disappear in the crowd, but she doesn't feel like she can. Catra shakes her head.

"Take care of Entrapta. Keep her out of trouble or from spouting too much about sirens. That's my last order to you as my quartermaster. If you miss me, I guess I'll be here, but I'm staying where it's easy to be with Adora," she tells her, shaking her head. Scorpia deflates, visibly sad, but she nods – and then flings herself at Catra and wraps her in a crushing hug. Catra wasn't expecting a tearful goodbye, but given how emotional Scorpia is, she probably should have been. She and Bonnie leave it at a knowing nod, clap on the back, and a "take care of 'em," but they've known each other long enough that they don't need anything more.

"I'm sorry. I know all you ever wanted was to captain your own ship," Adora tells her as Catra sits on the end of the dock, watching the boat carrying her friends grow smaller as it sails down the coast of the island. Catra sighs, staring off at the horizon. Her legs are dangling off the edge of the dock and Adora has her hand wrapped around one of Catra's ankles, just hanging on for a bit of contact. It's been hard to come by ever since she transformed, but staying on the beach might actually give them more opportunities to be together than the ship did.

"It was, but it wasn't your fault," Catra responds with a sigh. Shadow Weaver was going to take her ship anyway. All Adora did was save their lives. Catra shakes her head, looking down to find Adora looking up at her with her wide blue eyes. "Besides, it wasn't about the ship. It was about the freedom and authority it would give me. At least now Shadow Weaver can't control us," Catra returns. Adora blinks up at her, but after a moment she nods.

Spending her days fishing on the coast doesn't sound exciting, but given her sudden anxieties, it sounds peaceful. She can pull up her own dinner and get coin for anything else she catches. The mayor

introduces her to a local fishing couple who are starting to slow from age and could use the help. There's a shack near an inlet, just outside the village, that he offers to her as a place to stay on the condition that she works on fixing it up herself. Catra can do that – she likes to be self-reliant.

It's a glorified storage shed and it doesn't have any windows, but she can string up some fabric across one end of it as a hammock. More importantly, there's a flat bridge across the inlet, just barely above the water, where she can sit with Adora, together and alone. They're out of sight of the village proper, but only a short walk from it. It's more than she expected, so it's all she can ask for. She spends her second night on the island in the shack. The sea breeze blows throw the gaps and holes in the wood, leaving it chilly inside, but the sound of the waves is calming.

A few times, when she is struggling to sleep and her heart starts randomly racing, Catra stands and stumbles over to the door, opening it and peering out to the inlet. Every time, she sees Adora there, mostly lurking under the bridge or wriggled up in the edge of the shore, just inside the water , seemingly sleeping. She's there, is the point, and Catra isn't alone despite her foreign environment. She returns to her hammock, shivering a little in the poorly insulated shack, but eventually she falls asleep and wakes again to sunshine shining through the gaps in the wood.

After stretching and chewing on a bundle of leaves the mayor gave her and assured her she could eat, Catra walks to the village to join the fisherman. Adora follows behind them as they head out to sea. She stays out of sight inside the village, but the mayor warned Catra's apparent new boss, and he just whistles at the sight of Adora in the waves. She sings a cheerful note back. He comments on how beautiful she is, but he sounds like he's admiring a ship in fine trim. From an objective standpoint, Catra can't argue. She just sighs a little wistfully and nods before they return to work.

Catra never pictured herself as a fisherman – it sounded *boring* – but after the "excitement" of the shipwreck, it might be just what she

needs. Adora is right beside her in the small boat, and even when she returns to land, the shore is right there. Catra helps the fisherman haul his catch around, catching glimpses of Adora in the water below the walkways, but she refrains from singing in the village proper. Catra doesn't know how many people know there's a siren here now, but despite not really being hidden at this depth when the water is this clear, it's best not to cause a panic.

When Catra walks home that night along the beach, a small sack with her dinner and a few coins dangling from one hand, Adora is in the water, calling happily to her when she goes to cross the bridge and popping up beside it. Catra drops down, sitting and reaching out for her. Adora reaches back, smiling like the sun despite the circumstances. They have each other, and in Catra's state of goal-loss following the destruction of both her current ship and the one she was raised on, she fixates on that. It's the only goal she had before that she can still pursue.

"What do you think of the shack? Is it better on the inside?" Adora asks her. Catra chuckles to herself. She has only stayed there one night, so she doesn't know how it will hold up to rain, but she can confidently answer *no*, it's not. It needs to be rebuilt in almost every facet, and expanded too, but it's a roof over her head for now.

"Building supplies will be my first priority . It's a piece of shit, but it's mine, and more importantly, this bridge is," she tells her , reaching down to stroke Adora's cheek. Adora looks up at her with wide, soft eyes, leaning into the touch gladly. Catra doesn't care how much of a piece of shit the building is – it's right next to the water. Nothing else matters, in the long run. Maybe she'll end up at the port too eventually, seeking passage back to the mainland, but she imagines it would be hard to do so with Adora at her side.

She is unlikely to find a ship captain that would be accepting of a siren following them, and Adora following them so far without getting spotted would be near-impossible. She supposes they could always agree to part ways and just meet back in Seaworthy , but if this island will accept a retired pirate amongst its fishermen, then there's no

reason for her to go there, especially not if they will accept Adora too. It's all the same to Catra, and she knows people in the port if she gets truly lonely. She lays down on the side of the bridge, dropping her to eye level with Adora, and breathes out a sigh.

"I'm scared. I don't know what I'm doing, or if it' s really safe here, or if the Horde will come for revenge. But I know I love you, and the way this village is built is perfect for us. So I'll try to make something here," Catra tells her . Adora's breath hitches, her expression softening with a rush of emotion. She hooks a hand on the edge of the bridge, using it to steady and pull herself up so she can press a soft kiss to Catra's forehead. Catra purrs a little, nuzzling into the touch.

"After I fix up the shack, I'll see about getting a shovel or something and digging you a little trench so you can get closer to it. It will be a nice place to rest," Catra promises her . Adora responds by shifting and kissing her on the mouth. Catra rumbles happily. She'll take that as approval.

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The people of the village are kind. They find out she was in a shipwreck – and worse, that she has no other home to go back to – and they help her. They give her anything old they can spare. The tools are rusted, the sail torn, and the cutlery bent, but it all still *works* and that's what matters. An old lady flags her down as Catra is walking through the village one evening on the way home. She has Catra help her totter out to her shack, sitting on her doorstep and giving her instructions as Catra builds a clay oven beside her shack.

The rumors of the siren have spread through the village. Catra is pretty sure the woman helped her only so she could catch a glimpse

of Adora lurking beneath the bridge – she waves excitedly to her as Catra helps her back across and giggles when Adora sings a warm note back – but Catra can bake bread now if she wants, so she doesn't really care about her motivations. The woman gushes about hearing mermaid stories her entire life and never thinking she would get to see one before she died as Catra walks her back. Adora, as always, follows from the water.

Catra only leaves sight of it to fetch water from the river. She can always look to the coast, or beneath the walkways, or to the inlet, and see the flash of gold and white there. Often, Adora surfaces and sings to her. Her songs are beautiful now, joyous and bright. When Catra returns to the privacy of her shack, they meet on the bank. The bridge is convenient if Catra doesn't want to get dirty – which is kind of important, considering the only clothes she has are the ones Adora grabbed in the shipwreck – but she prefers to meet Adora on the shore.

Catra lays parallel to the sea, and Adora lays with her tail in it. The waves are minor in the inlet, so she can lay with most of her body in the water without Catra having to get close enough to risk the water touching her. Catra lays out on the sail she was given, using it like a blanket to help avoid the damp, silty sand of the bank getting in her fur. They hold hands or cuddle, sharing slow kisses as they lay beside each other. It's the most comfortable way they've found to be together since this all began.

"Do you miss the sea?" Adora asks, quietly, as she nuzzles into Catra's chest. Catra is naked. Her clothes were still wet from being washed in the river when she went to bed and she hasn't redressed. Adora lit up when she saw Catra exit her shack naked. Catra smirked, assuming her thoughts had turned dirty, but Adora admitted she was less interested in sex since she lost the ability to have it herself upon her transformation, though she still enjoys taking care of Catra. No, she wanted to bury her face in Catra's fur apparently. Catra doesn't know why she was even surprised. Adora has always been like this.

"Yeah. No. It's complicated," Catra returns, reaching down to cradle the back of Adora's head. Adora has her arms wrapped around Catra. The top of her hair is mostly dry, as is her face, and no matter how Catra used to feel about getting wet, she loves having Adora in her arms, and she'll deal with a lot of things if she gets to have her. She bends down, kissing the top of Adora's head and sighing as she lays her cheek against the sail again. She has been on the island for a week. Aside from the first day where she saw her friends off, she has been out on the sea every day.

It's a different kind of *sea* though. Catra grew up on the Black Garnet. She only saw land every few weeks, and often only stayed for a few days. She isn't used to the ground being solid beneath her. She has decent land legs after spending an unusual amount of time on it over the last few months, but sometimes she still stumbles, expecting a shift with the breeze and just not finding it. Being in a small sailing boat is nothing like walking through the halls of a man-of-war or even a brigantine.

She still sleeps in a hammock just because it' s cheap and she is used to it, but even that isn't the same when it is still. She is used to rocking with the sea as she falls asleep and she isn't sleeping well because of it. That is probably why Adora is asking, actually. The moon is high in the sky, but Catra just couldn't sleep. When she came wandering out of her shack, Adora was still awake too. She was surprised to see Catra up, but she happily flopped onto the bank to be with her.

"I don't miss a lot of things. I don't miss sea biscuits, or any of the food honestly, or having no privacy, or living in fear of losing everything. I don't miss you being so far down in the water and only getting two or three hours together a day," Catra tells her , waving her hand vaguely before she returns to petting Adora's hair. Adora shifts up, finally pulling out from where she was burying her face in Catra's chest to look her in the eyes. She is frowning a little, waiting for the rest. Catra sighs, looking away.

"I do miss being captain. I miss people finally trusting me. I miss the freedom of being able to go anywhere. I miss the boat rocking beneath me. I miss ducking into closets with you. I miss the idea that one day we would be the ones in charge of the Black Garnet. A lot of dreams died when you did," Catra ends in a whisper, unable to hold Adora's gaze anymore and looking away. Adora lets out a trembling note that breaks Catra's heart in an instant. She flinches.

It was a rough few months. Catra always knew what she was working towards. She tried to adjust her course to the closest she could come once Adora was gone, and then again once she was back, but now there is no chance of any of their plans. She has to let them go. She isn't unhappy fishing, but it is a big change, and she has a lot to let go. She is only able to do it because she has Adora with her, especially in moments like this when it all feels like too much, but Adora shifts up and cups her cheek to rest their foreheads together.

"I'm right here. I'm always going to be," Adora promises her, pressing a kiss to her cheek and then, when Catra doesn't pull away, kissing her properly. Catra's breath is trembling. She leans into the kiss gladly, squeezing her eyes shut and kissing back a bit desperately. She knows Adora is here now, but she lost her once. Adora seems to understand she needs grounding. She cups her head and kisses her firmly, nipping at Catra's bottom lip to keep her in the moment. Catra lets out a shaky exhale, pushing forward and reaching down to Adora's back, tugging insistently.

She isn't in the position to move Adora – she's heavy as shit now with her massive fish tail, and the weight of her hair when wet doesn't help either – but Adora moves for her, splashing the water a little as she wiggles to lay parallel to Catra. Adora can't stay like this for too long without drying out, but for a moment, Catra wants to press their bodies together. She takes charge of the kiss, exploring Adora's mouth for herself. She knows the changes she has gone through, but she still catalogs them, refamiliarizing herself with this Adora – the only Adora that still exists.

She pulls back panting. Another change is Adora's lung capacity, and Catra catches her breath as Adora just keeps going, ducking down to nip and kiss at her neck. Just as Catra sets aside her dislike of water, Adora doesn't hesitate to latch on and suck a love bite against Catra despite her fur. Adora is a freak who always seemed to have the *opposite* of a problem with Catra's hybrid traits, but the point stands that it's something most would have to make a concession for.

Any dream Catra has ever had involved Adora, and the rest of it – the power, the freedom, the only life she has ever known – pales in comparison to her. She is a deadeye shot. She may be wasting her talents on a quiet retirement of fishing, but she can glance back and see Adora in the water behind her. When they have hauled in their catch, Adora swims up to the edge of the boat and Catra can kneel to kiss her wife. Her shack is a piece of shit, but it's functional, it's hers, and even when she can't sleep on the solid ground that feels so foreign to her that it makes her heart randomly race, she can walk out and find Adora right there.

Adora has a whole open ocean before her, but she came back to her. She only thought of Catra during their time apart. Catra wouldn't give up this kind of love for anything. She purrs, whimpering and gasping, as Adora happily marks her neck, leaving the traces of herself on her. Catra can't help but think of the ring that Adora intended to give her. She wants it – she wants *that* ring in particular – but the last thing she wants Adora to do is leave to get it. Maybe one day she'll leave this island and they can go find it. Catra would like to visit Seaworthy eventually to make sure Bonnie made it back home. For now, Catra doesn't need a ring to tell her that they belong to each other.

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"Do you miss the sea?" Adora asks her , floating down in the water. Catra, sitting on the edge of one of the wooden walkways of the fishing village, blinks and looks down at her. It is sunset, so they decided to stay in the village to admire the view. The village is around a bend in the island's coastline that affords them privacy at their inlet shack, but it means the view of the sunset is better here. Adora is mostly hidden from view just because of how close she is to the walkway, but it isn't like her presence isn't an open-air secret in the village anyway.

"I was out there an hour ago," she returns, looking back out to the sunset. This has to be the third time Adora has asked her that. The first time, she seemed worried. Catra is pretty sure she felt guilty over ostensibly being the reason that Catra lost her ship. Though Catra is still conflicted over it, she is making a nice enough life here. As soon as she successfully convinced Adora of that, however, the way Adora asked the question changed.

"Yeah, you were. Not the same, though," Adora agrees, sinking down in the water a little. She doesn't seem disappointed, but there is an air to her that makes Catra suspicious. She narrows her eyes at the oranges staining the sky. Adora wanted a different answer. Why would she want Catra to say yes? Her ears twitch at the distant sound of a lizardfolk child hissing as she plays on the other end of the village. Adora sinks a little lower in the water. She avoids the children if she can. They can't be trusted to stay quiet like the adults, and seeing a mermaid is *exciting* for them.

"I'm a magicat. We're built for land," she returns, just as cryptic as Adora's initial question. Adora snorts, sending up bubbles. She has sunken down to her eyes in the water. She looks up at Catra, her eyes dancing with a playful spark. Catra realizes what she is about to do just a moment before Adora reaches up for her dangling ankle. Catra squeaks, scrambling back away from her and hissing. Adora laughs, a few melodic notes that warble as they rise out of the water.

"Don't you *dare*," she hisses down at the water beneath the walkway which she is now firmly in the *center* of, out of the reach of

mischievous sirens. Adora just laughs harder, ducking fully beneath the water and circling beneath Catra, either feeling energetic or acting as if Catra is prey. She sure as hell isn't. Magicats are also predators. She flattens her ears back, her tail lashing and a growl rising in her throat as she watches for glimpses of Adora's gold and white between the boards of the walkway. It's a play growl as much as it is a warning.

"You want me to brush your hair tonight or not?" Catra asks, watching Adora freeze in the water. A moment later, she swims away, settling at the walkway's edge. Catra approaches it cautiously, prowling on all fours, but she finds Adora has popped up above the waves again and is giving her wide, innocent eyes. Catra needs a brush to deal with her own fur, so the purchase wasn't superfluous despite there being other things that should have been higher priority, but it turns out to also work wonders on Adora's hair now it is golden and *gi ant*. Adora likes lying on the shore with her head in Catra's lap as Catra brushes it.

"I'll behave," Adora promises her with an angelic expression. Yeah, Catra doesn't believe that for a *second*, but she does believe Adora at least won't try to pull her down from land into the sea to prove a point-

Oh. That's why she keeps asking.

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Catra is, generally, okay on the island. Sometimes – usually times when she is with Adora – she is happy. When she is alone, leaving sight of the coastline to get fresh water or trying to sleep in her shack, she feels a little less than okay, but the island experience hasn't been bad. She thinks it will mellow out – or at least, she hopes her emotions will – and she will spend more time on the *hap* side

of the scale as her body adjusts to living on land. Despite all that, she knows why Adora is asking.

The shipwreck was terrifying. Catra could have died – Adora could have lost her. Catra has been through losing Adora once. She knows what that fear is like. Adora told her about how she found Bonnie and Entrapta. They would be dead now if Adora hadn't rescued them, and Catra very well could have wasted away on her board in the middle of the sea if Adora hadn't freed the lifeboat and pulled her to it.

Adora wants Catra to be a siren too. She already told Catra that before, but when Catra dismissed it, Adora agreed it was a backup plan. In Catra's mind, that was the end of it, but clearly not for Adora. Catra knows the last thing Adora would do is force it on her – if that is even possible – but she is hoping that Catra grows to want it, clearly. That is why she has been asking if Catra misses the sea – there is no safer way to be out on it again than as a siren, moved by the tides but unable to drown in its waters.

Catra hates the ocean. She always has, but she has to put up with it regardless to be with Adora. Back on the Black Garnet, it was distant despite living on a ship. The interior was removed from the water lapping at its hull. Once she moved to the brigantine – and again here, fishing from the small sailboat – Catra had to deal with it constantly. It's still different from *living* in it though. The idea makes her anxious, her tail puffing up and twitching as she stares down into the black water one night while sat on the bridge.

"It's okay. I'm right here," Adora assures, her voice soft, as she reaches up to pet Catra's bushy tail. Catra swallows, still staring down at the water that Adora swims through so effortlessly. Adora's hand on her feels nice at least. That would be the one benefit to joining her: they could finally meet on the same plane again, free to kiss, touch, and hug as they wished. There would be the magic powers too, but Catra is pretty sure those don't outweigh the whole *ocean* thing, so the deciding factor is down to Adora.

Catra knows that to Adora it seems like she suddenly got scared for no reason, but she has been thinking all day about her realization on the docks last night. Adora keeps petting her tail as she opens her mouth and begins to sing. The song isn't sad, nor is it happy. Catra thinks it is meant to be calming. She closes her eyes, breathing in slowly. A year ago, she never would have even considered this. She doesn't know that she really is now, but she is thinking about it. Adora's petting and soft song calm her, her fur eventually lying flat as Adora winds down and finishes the song with a gentle kiss to Catra's tail. Catra takes a deep breath.

"You want me to be a siren," she says. She doesn't open her eyes. Then she'll see the dark sea and think about being in it, living in it, getting dragged down to its dark depths where monsters lurk. She wouldn't suffocate and she would be one of the monsters that people tell stories about, but the fear is still there. Adora is silent for a moment before she reaches up. Catra's heart leaps into her throat when she realizes Adora is trying to pull her into the water. She whimpers, her face screwing up, but Adora keeps going, pulling her down off the bridge.

It's a fight to get Catra to uncurl from her protective ball, and she still refuses to open her eyes, whining and growling a little as Adora coaxes her against her chest, but eventually they end up chest-to-chest, Catra's arms hooked over Adora's shoulders and Adora's wrapped tightly around her, holding her close. The waves in the inlet are calm, and they just lap lightly against her shoulders as Catra quivers a little in Adora's arms. If she wasn't already panicking, water this deep wouldn't bother her, but she clings to Adora for safety.

"You're safe. I'm protecting you. See? The waves aren't hurting you. It's okay," Adora encourages her, nuzzling against her cheek. "I'll never let the sea hurt you. You can open your eyes. Nothing bad is going to happen," she adds, her breath warm against Catra's face. Catra still has her eyes screwed shut. Her clothes tug around her with the current and the water is *cold*, but Adora's body has some warmth to it, and her arms are solid. They are only a few feet from

shore, Catra reminds herself. She takes a deep breath and then she forces herself to open her eyes. She finds Adora's enchanting blue waiting for her, a soft smile spreading on her face.

"There you go. That's my brave captain. Always facing your fears," Adora tells her, kissing her cheek again. Catra wants to get indignant, puffing up and scoffing and *f i ght ng* Adora, but instead she melts beneath the praise, clinging to Adora tightly. Adora hums a little. Her voice is her own now, but sometimes there's a weird undercurrent to it. The hum has a note of a song in it, and it causes her earfins to flex as she cradles Catra tight in her arms. The water is cold, and Catra still hates the way the ocean tugs at her clothes and fur, threatening to pull her away, but Adora holds her tight, keeping them right beside the bridge with slow movements of her tail. Adora looks her in the eyes, her gaze burning in the dark of the evening.

"When you're ready for it, I'd like you to join me. I want to be able to hold and kiss you all the time. To share everything with you like we did when we both lived on land. Sirens don't age and die, and I don't want to outlive you. But it's up to you, and it doesn't have to be now. You can think about it for years if you need to," Adora says, her voice low and intense, entirely sincere. Catra swallows, feeling her ears quiver a little. She shivers with the breeze, swaying closer and pressing their cheeks together. Adora immediately squeezes her close, tilting her head a little to give Catra better access to rub their faces together.

She can't really scent mark Adora anymore. The waves just take it away. She can't easily hug her even. The water enforces so much distance between them. Catra hates it. She got Adora back, but with new barriers between them. Even a few weeks ago, she wouldn't seriously consider this, but in this moment, she just wants to be held by Adora. She *i s* being held by Adora, but the waves make her shiver and she is going to be miserable when she returns back to her drafty shack. If she was a siren too, would she feel less afraid?

There would be nothing the ocean could do to her anymore, but fear isn't always logical.

"We have time," Catra whispers back. It isn't a promise, really, except for how it is – she will think about it. What will come from that thinking, she doesn't know, but for now, she is getting by. She closes her eyes again as Adora nods against her cheek. No decision has to be made tonight while she is scared, cold, and shaking in Adora's arms. She can shove these thoughts aside and just enjoy Adora's embrace for a while. Despite the ocean around them, Adora is warm and safe. Catra nuzzles into her, breathing a bit easier.

They have time.

Chapter End Notes

I'm kinda imagining those little fishing settlements from Assassin's Creed Valhalla for the village.
People taking in sailors really is a thing that happens IRL! I like stories of shipwrecks and you'll find sailors being pulled out of the water by other boats, boats deviating from their courses to search for another boat that has mysteriously vanished, people who were shipwrecked with no belongings in South America being ferried home to Boston, etc. I find it heartwarming, so I wanted to showcase it.

Adora the Local Oddity

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora likes Octopus Cove. She tries to stay out of sight, but the people are nice – or at least merely wary – when they do spot her. She can be with Catra all the time, lie in the sand with her on the beach, and be close when Catra awakes in the middle of the night or can't fall asleep at all. She isn't sleeping well. On the nights when she comes wandering back out of her shack after trying to go to bed, she is often too tired to lay out the sail as a blanket, but she can ball up on the bridge while Adora swims below to keep them close. Sometimes, like now, Adora can still hear her heart racing.

"Go back to bed," Adora tells her, keeping her voice low as she uses the edge of the bridge to pull herself up so she can press a kiss to Catra's forearm where she has it wrapped it around herself. Catra's gaze is distant, but she pins her ears back and wrinkles up her face at Adora's words. Her tail twitches a little where it is wrapped around her as she turns her gaze on Adora. She looks exhausted despite her racing heart.

"I won't sleep. I'd rather be with you," she returns, her voice low and tired. It must be past midnight now, and Catra rises early. She needs the rest. Some nights she manages to go to sleep right away, but Adora hates seeing her sleepless like this. Catra always slept easily when they shared a hammock, utterly wrapped up in each other. Catra always ran hot like a furnace, soft and purring in Adora's arms. Adora shakes her head, sending Catra her best assuring look.

"I love you too, but you will. Go back inside. Please, for me," Adora asks her, still petting along her tail. Catra just looks back at her, but apparently she is too tired to really argue, because she sighs and shifts to lie on her stomach on the bridge. It's a silent request, one

that Adora happily fulfills, leaning up and kissing Catra softly now she is low enough to reach. When she pulls back, she gives Catra an encouraging smile. Catra sighs, but she pushes up, plodding across the bridge and up the short distance to her shack.

When she turns to close her door, she pauses and turns back to look at Adora for a long moment before she finally closes it. Adora gives her a minute to get settled in her hammock, swimming to the bank and setting up in the corner beneath the bridge where she likes to wedge herself while sleeping. She doesn't need sleep like a human does, not often feeling tired, but it makes her feel rested regardless, so it's good to do when Catra is asleep herself.

Her hair always gets tugged out from under the bridge by the current, so she is far from hidden here, but she doesn't have to worry about washing away. Adora settles down for a few moments before she opens her mouth and begins to sing, low and calm. Her song almost has a sleepy hum to it, warm and affectionate as she pictures all the times she and Catra fell asleep together. Catra always liked to sneak into her hammock, but at one point her own got torn and she permanently moved into Adora's bed.

She pictures Catra's warm fur against her now as she sings, trying to give Catra something comforting to focus on, hopeful the song evokes in her the same warmth it does in Adora. She is quiet – she doesn't want her tune to carry to the village – but Catra should hear it clearly and hopefully will fall asleep quickly . She sings for a while to be safe. When she finally winds the song down, she pauses for several long moments, listening to the night. The waves crash and crickets sing, but the door to the shack doesn't open again.

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Adora and Catra are around each other for nearly every hour of the day, but Adora also needs to swim. If she just stayed next to the shore, she would probably start cramping up like she did in the tank. She mostly wanders when Catra is fishing, ducking down beneath the waves to visit the ocean floor, going as far out in the waves as she dares without losing sight of the sailboat, and then returning – always returning – to find Catra smiling and reaching for her so they can have a moment of connection before she returns to work.

When she first gained her voice, Catra voiced her fears that the Adora who came back to her wasn't the same one who drowned. Adora was quick to assure her she was still herself. She has the same soul, but her body has transformed significantly. Despite her promise, she is well aware from growing up with Catra that differing biology can come with an entirely different set of biological instincts. Those instincts drive her to explore as much as her exercise needs do. They drive her to do even more.

When Adora was caged in the tank, her mental state deteriorated and she needed to carve in order to cope, but the instinct never went away once she was freed, she just no longer needed a vice. She can resist it now, but a part of her is always looking for a good medium for carving as she swims. She feels her fingers twitch, or spots a particularly smooth rock that immediately catches her attention, and the urge rises in her, but it doesn't feel much different than her reaction to sweets back when she was human.

The sirens in Salineas said it was normal for them. Adora doesn't feel bad for the impulse, but it's new, and weird, and she especially doesn't want to vandalize anything. She starts collecting rocks while she is out exploring, or occasionally pulling driftwood from the shore, and settling in to carve them while Catra is around her shack or shopping in town. She feels weird about it when Catra can see her, but after an initial round of twenty questions about the carving, Catra doesn't seem to bat an eye at it, and sometimes she even compliments Adora's finished pieces, often finding a place for them around her shack's area.

In her wanderings, Adora also finds trinkets for Catra. She supposes the very first one was the goblet she rescued from the shipwreck. Its glint caught her eye, floating in a stream of bubbles rising from a hole in the Black Garnet. At the time, she justified grabbing it with the logic that they could sell or trade it to get back on their feet when they reached civilization again. Catra, apparently feeling secure in their position in the village, gave it to Bonnie before she left so she could do just that when she reached the port to help the trio on their way.

The goblet was somewhat practical, but Adora's draw towards shiny things is less so. She just likes the way they glint. It' s probably something about it emulating the flash of fish scales in the sea, or some other perfectly logical explanation, but she can explain her drive to then gift them to Catra less so. Adora finds things on the ocean floor, even things she knows are useless trash, and she feels the stupid, illogical urge to gift them to Catra. It doesn't even make sense – she just *knows* it's a wooing technique, and Catra is far from needing to be courted.

She is already Adora's wife. Everybody in the village knows them as such, and given Adora's claws and Catra's fur, no one has questioned their lack of rings. The carving urge results in something that Adora can almost call art. She can't say the same for the flash of an urge that crosses her mind when she sees a fishhook glint on the ocean floor. Despite how she always wants to turn towards it, she keeps swimming. She is transformed with new biological urges, but she is still herself. She can fight them.

--

Sirens don't have sex. They make more sirens via the kiss of life. Since her transformation, Adora hasn't really been interested in it anymore. She doesn't have the biology for it, nor seemingly the drive

to have it. She is, however, very interested in Catra. Adora can't feel pleasure herself anymore, but no change in the world could make her stop loving Catra's post-orgasm purr with all her heart. Hearing Catra sigh her name and moan from the pleasure that Adora gives her is still a high, even if it doesn't light a fire within Adora anymore.

She might not often start this anymore, but when Catra laid out on the bridge naked to dry off in the sun, Adora couldn't help but remember how good she *was*. Adora may just be a giant lesbian in any and every life, but she loves everything about the experience of burying her head between Catra's thighs as Catra gasps, her tail lashing above Adora's head and her claws dug into the bridge for dear life as she lays on it facedown. Adora pulled her hips over the edge and braced her legs on her shoulders to get access without Catra having to get too wet again.

Catra's legs are in the waves, but she certainly doesn't seem to care as she mewls out her orgasm. Adora gives herself one more moment to enjoy having Catra against and around her before she pulls back reluctantly. Sex drive or no, it took her about a *day* to realize the possibilities afforded by her new tongue and it seems Catra is as appreciative of the change as Adora hoped she would be. She pants as Adora helps her scramble her legs back up onto the bridge.

Catra flops out on her side, lying parallel with the bridge so she can look over its edge at Adora as she recovers. She is purring like an engine. Adora trills, swimming closer again as she licks her own face clean with the extended range of her tongue. Catra's eyes dilate watching it, a satisfied rumbling already pouring from her. Adora reaches up – her hand is mostly dry from being out of the water while she held Catra's legs up – and pets down Catra's back as she recovers.

Catra's eyes slip closed, her tail twitching as if she *wants* to sway it happily but is too sleepy for it. Post-sex Catra is adorable, a satisfied puddle on the bridge. Adora is glad for the privacy they have here. She wants to be able to enjoy listening to Catra' s purr and pet her

while she is boneless. There is no hurry for Catra to head back inside and put on fresh clothes before someone sees. Her rumbling very nearly drowns out the sounds of the waves.

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Adora has resisted for a frankly absurd amount of time. She blinks up at Catra with wide eyes as Catra stares down at the jawbone Adora has placed in her hands. Adora managed to resist bringing her a piece of shiny trash, but she doesn't know if this is better. Catra looks caught between confusion and concern as she looks up to Adora as if her expression will contain an explanation. Adora doesn't *have* one. She spotted the jaw on the ocean floor – white and bright compared to the black silt in which it laid – and had her usual urge to bring Catra something shiny.

This time she could justify giving into it to herself because it was tied into her more logical urge – it was bone, and she wanted to carve on it. It is a perfect material for carving. The resistance is just right. She has carved on a few larger fish bones she found before, though they usually ended up snapping in her hands. The jaw held up, now decorated in swirling patterns. Tiny stars dot one corner of the bone. It's only half a jaw , but Adora wasted no space, only leaving the necessary gaps between lines that made them stand out.

Now that it is done, she couldn't resist thrusting it out to Catra first thing when she came down to settle on her sail blanket along the shore after dinner. Adora worked hard on it, even though she knows Catra doesn't *eat* it. It's not even shiny outside of the context within it was found, and Catra probably doesn't want to have a piece of human head amongst her possessions, carving or no. Catra looks down to the piece of bone, squinting as she turns it over in her hands to inspect. Adora feels stupidly nervous, as if she is waiting for her work to be approved.

This is so *bad*. She doesn't need to woo Catra, they're already together. They had sex on the bridge just three days ago. Her new instincts are dumb. They are cosmic balance for weighing out her ability to talk to sea life, probably. She watches Catra examine the carving closely. After several moments of turning the bone over in her hands with a pinched expression, Catra seems to give up, lowering the bone into her lap and looking back to Adora.

"Alright, I give up. What is this?" Catra asks her. She is surprisingly blank. She is mostly confused, none of the disgust that Adora feared present, but also none of the joy that she wants her to have over the gift. Probably because it isn't a gift and is just trash to anyone but a siren. Adora doesn't consciously choose to fix a pleading expression on Catra, but she knows she does it anyway, because the corner of Catra's lips twitch.

"Yours," she replies. Catra blinks at her, visibly thrown for a loop as she glances down at the bone. When she looks back up at Adora, she has her brow raised.

"It's mine," she echoes. Adora nods. Catra narrows her eyes at her. Adora holds her breath, blinking back innocently as she waits for judgement. She just wants Catra to keep it. After a moment, Catra sighs and gestures down towards the bone. "I'm trying here, Adora, but you have to give me more than that. If it weren't for the fact that it's *you* and you're giving me that kicked seal pup look, I would think this was a threat," Catra tells her. Adora feels her heart rate spike instantly.

"No! No, it's not," she rushes, almost yelling from her haste to get the words out. Catra's tail twitches. She has an oddly fond look on her face as she eyes Adora. Adora flushes, ducking down in the waves to gather herself. Siren or no, she was human first – she was Catra's *lover* first – and she knows that face means that Catra thinks she is cute. She isn't rejecting Adora. Adora sighs, sending up a stream of bubbles, and then rises in the water, wiggling her way onto the bank and laying out on her stomach with her arms folded in front of her.

She props her chin on them as she searches for the right words to say.

"I do the carving thing now ," she says, hesitantly . Catra just nods, still looking confused, though Adora doesn't doubt it is because she can't guess where this explanation is going. Catra understands the carving. She took one look at Adora carving into a rock and solved the mystery of the urge for her. *Courting gift?* she asked, explaining a drive that has confused Adora ever since she started it with just one sentence.

"It' s a courting gift I think," Adora mumbles into her arms, looking down and thoroughly inspecting the sand right in front of her. She could explain the entire thing, but that's what it boils down to: Catra is her lover, despite them having gone through the courting process already – well, okay, they skipped it with a prior decade of friendship, but that isn't the point – Adora now has the urge to do it the way her body tells her she should now. She just needs Catra to accept this one gift. Catra's tail twitches – amusement, which at least isn't disgust over being given part of a dead thing as an act of supposed *love* – in front of her.

"I can't give you the ring I got yet, so I just..." she trails off, the realization hitting her that this is an *engagement* gift. That is why it has tugged at her mind so hard. Sirens are creatures of magic, so most their nature seems to be encoded in that magic as well. Part of Adora knows that if Catra accepts this weird, gross, illogical gift, then they really will be in it for life. It wasn't important at first, but now they are on the island and it is looking more unlikely that Adora will be able to go fetch their wedding rings soon, she wants something solid to tie them together.

"Adora, what do you want me to do with it?" Catra prompts, her voice soft. Adora swallows, bracing herself before she looks up to meet her lover's eyes. Catra's expression is as encouraging as her voice as she picks the bone up in one hand, *holding* it now, and reaches down with the other to pet over Adora's hair. Adora feels herself flush, her heart rate picking up. Catra has picked up on Adora's

conflict over this, but she seems unbothered herself. A little needy, Adora leans into the touch.

"Keep it. Any siren who sees it will know what it means. Somehow I do," Adora explains, oddly flustered. Catra's eyes sparkle with warmth and amusement. Adora can practically *see* her holding back a tease about what, exactly, the bone means, but Adora has said enough already for Catra to know, and she clearly knows this is something that Adora can't really handle being teased about. Catra leans down, tucking the bone against herself and pressing a soft kiss to Adora's forehead.

"Okay. I love you," Catra promises, and then she shifts her legs beneath her and stands. Adora blinks, watching Catra walk up the bank and back to the shack, disappearing inside. For a few long minutes, there is nothing but the waves crashing, and then Catra comes wandering back out, the bone missing from her hands. Catra's smile is small and fond as she settles back down on the sail, reaching out to pet Adora's hair again.

"Just don't go bringing me the rest of whoever that was, and hopefully no one will spot it and accuse me of murder or something. I don't get a lot of guests at least," Catra jokes. Adora chuckles in response, closing her eyes as she wills her heart to settle down. The nerves are gone now, but they have been replaced with bursting excitement over Catra accepting her despite how that was already a given.

"I'll eat anyone who accuses you of murder," she assures her. Catra's answering laugh is soft, but it's the brightest music Adora has ever heard in her life.

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Adora singing to Catra has become a thing. It started to soothe her to sleep, but then one day Catra requests it while they're lying on shore together, and from there it just blossomed. Adora loves singing – in general, but especially for Catra. All her songs have meanings, even if they don't quite have words. They carry emotions, commands, and secret signals within their decibels, only a small portion of what Adora says audible to most other creatures, Catra included.

Adora sings quiet, breathy , besotted love songs to Catra when they lie in each other's arms. She calls to the oceans to celebrate when she surfaces in the waves and spots Catra's fishing boat. The ocean answers, fish attracted by her call getting caught in Catra's nets. When Catra sleeps, Adora croons out memories to warm her in her drafty seaside shack. When Adora loses sight of Catra, she lets out a low, mournful note, asking for her lover to return to her and feeling her heart break with every second that Catra isn't there.

"Sing to me," Catra requests, shifting to kiss Adora' s cheek. She is lying half in the water so Adora can hold her, soaked and shivering a little, but she has made no move to leave. Adora can sense internal conflict coming from her, so she assumes Catra is staying amongst the waves despite how unpleasant they are for her because she needs the comfort of Adora's touch more. Adora squeezes her tight, shifting to kiss Catra's temple before she opens her mouth and heeds the request.

Adora's speaking voice is her own now, but when she sings this time, it's a bit scratchier than usual, reminiscent of when her voice was still adjusting. She sings low and warm, whispering to Catra all the warm, sleep-soaked memories of contentment in each other's arms to her. Catra shivers, pressing closer with her tail lashing as an uneven purr begins in her chest. It's the self-soothing kind. Despite having a seemingly normal day out fishing on the sea, Catra is in need of comfort now.

The song seems to help. Catra closes her eyes, soaking in the sound and rumbling her arms. The shivers don't stop, though. She

wants comfort, but it's getting to be too cold for her to be in the waves. As winter approaches, them meeting halfway like this is going to become impossible. Adora's heart thuds, realizing that could be what is causing the worry in Catra's mind. She winds down her song, finishing it with another kiss to the base of Catra's ear.

"You need to dry off. You're going to catch a cold. I don't want you to get sick," Adora murmurs to her, her voice low. She watches Catra's expression tinge with sorrow as she blinks her eyes open and looks up at Adora with conflict in her gaze. Adora tries to send reassurance back, but Catra's expression still settles in disappointment as she reluctantly nods. She starts to pull away – made no easier by how Adora doesn't actually want to let her go – but then she pauses, turning to face Adora fully again and kissing her firmly.

Adora kisses back, trying to keep the embrace steady and comforting. It seems to help some, Catra's body relaxing in her arms until she finally pulls away and forces herself to stand, shivering and hissing from the cold breeze. Adora can't help but smile a little as her bedraggled lover sprints back to her shack. She has earned enough coins fishing to get herself towels so getting in and out of the water is easier on her, but the changing of the seasons is still going to be harsh.

Catra emerges after drying off with fresh clothes on and a blanket – another one of her new purchases – thrown over her shoulders. She walks to the bridge and Adora swims to join her, popping back up beside it as Catra sets down and tightens the blanket around her. She smiles at Adora, soft and fond when Adora chirps a greeting to her, but her gaze is still distant. It quickly skitters out to focus on the distant sealine, watching the waves crashing before the dark sky. Adora decides to wait.

Catra is clearly having some kind of internal struggle and prompting her too early could result in her shutting down. For several quiet moments, Adora is happy to just swim alongside the bridge where Catra sits, hoping her presence alone is enough of a source of

comfort for her lover. Eventually, Catra speaks, choosing the exact moment that Adora has her back to her as she swims down the length of the short bridge before she can turn back to rejoin Catra in its center.

"Do you think my singing voice would be as pretty as yours?" Catra asks when Adora surfaces, her voice soft. Adora freezes, turning slowly to blink at Catra. Catra isn't looking at her, still focused on the horizon. Her expression is thoughtful, but tinged with conflict. Adora swallows as she thinks over her answer – and the *reason* . It is clear what Catra means. Adora's heart wants to leap, the image of spending the winter swimming in the ocean together rather than separated by the shore already blossoming in her mind, but she knows this is merely an indication that Catra is thinking about it and not a request for Adora to kiss her right now .

"No. It would be better . You already sing so well, even if you pretend not to," Adora returns after a long moment. Sea shanties and pirate songs were a part of their lives growing up, even if Shadow Weaver wasn't a fan of her crew's fondness for them. When a group was going, Adora could always pick out Catra's voice amongst all the others. Sometimes they would sing quiet versions of the songs while alone, music for just the two of them. The words seem to break Catra out of her reverie, at least partially. She snorts, shooting Adora an amused look.

"Flattery won't get you into my legs. Okay , that doesn't work. I'm just wondering about the realities of it, is all. I still hate the ocean," Catra returns. Adora can't help but chuckle, shaking her head a little as she swims back to settle in the water right in front of Catra and look up to her, inspecting her. Catra looks back, her gaze unchallenging. She doesn't seem defensive, and the conversation seems to be shaking her out of her funk.

"Okay . I can wait. I'm happy with every moment we do get together. It would just give us more," Adora tells her . A tinge of thoughtfulness enters Catra's gaze as she nods and looks back out to the waves. Adora sees the slight shiver that the sight of them sends through her

too. She bites her lip. Despite her own fears of ever being without Catra, there is more to their situation than how lovesick Adora is for her. "Your happiness in those moments matters too. If you would be miserable in the ocean, there's no point to it," she adds on, because it has to be said.

Catra is silent for a long moment, just looking out to the sea with a thousand-yard stare. Adora can see her tail tightly wrapped around her legs under the edge of the blanket, which Catra pulls tighter around herself before turning her gaze up to the sky, where the stars are beginning to peek out now the sun has set. The tightness of her shoulders eases without her oldest enemy stretching out before her. Catra misses being on a ship in the waves, but she certainly doesn't miss the sea.

"I know. But sometimes I feel like every moment I'm not in your arms is pointless anyway," she whispers. Adora draws in a sharp breath, her heart hammering as she blinks up at her. They've spent so long being forced apart. Now they have the option to just be lovers – to truly be nothing else but what they've always wanted to be – she understands Catra wanting to pursue it whole-heartedly. It isn't like she ever *wanted* to be a fisherman, but Adora also doesn't want to curse her to an unhappy life in the sea.

She reaches up, offering Catra her hand. Catra blinks at it for a moment before her gaze softens and she reaches down, placing her hand in Adora's and holding it. They can't thread their fingers together ever since Adora's became webbed, but they can still hold hands. Adora squeezes back. It is the contact that she can offer without getting Catra too wet in the cold of the evening. She can't say anything really – she agrees, but she isn't pressuring Catra when it comes to this.

She needs time to think. If she ends up not wanting it, she will be glad to have taken it. If she agrees, they'll have forever regardless. For now, they can hold hands as Catra looks out into the night. Adora opens her mouth, and she sings all the things they could do together if Catra joins her.

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"I want to go visit Scorpia and Entrapta," Catra tells her. Adora gives a questioning trill, rising out of the water to blink at Catra. It wasn't until Catra pointed it out that she realized she now speaks with a mixture of speech and her new vocalizations. It was useful while she was still adjusting to her voice, trying to cobble together her intent with a throat unused to talking anymore and the speech that came naturally to her, but she assumed that she would grow used to talking again eventually. Since Catra understands her perfectly fine this way, it hasn't needed to changed. Catra smiles, glancing down at her in the water.

"I want to make sure they're doing okay, and I think it will do me some good to talk to another pirate. The village folk are nice, but they aren't my crowd, you know?" Catra explains. That makes sense to Adora, but she feels herself pouting regardless. Catra sends her a fond look, shifting to reach down and extend her hand. Adora reaches up, happily holding Catra's hand in her own. "It will be one day apart, that's all. You can go hunting for more fun bones while I'm in port. Just try for something non-human this time," Catra teases her. Adora flushes, rolling her eyes, but she nods.

"I'm still going to miss you," she tells her. There's no way she can follow Catra to the port. It's too big, and everyone from traders to pirates to the Primary Navy sails through. If she gets spotted, it could kick off a siren hunt. She will have to stay back at the village. A day of exploring out in the ocean sounds fun, but she would prefer to do it with Catra by her side. That isn't an option, and Catra has other friends to visit. She smiles softly at Adora as she squeezes her hand.

"I'll miss you too. I'll be back at this bridge by the evening, though," Catra promises her. The words soothe Adora a little. She stretches

up, kissing the back of Catra's hand softly. No matter what, they'll always come back together.

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Catra walks to the port on her next day off, just two days later. Adora follows her just to the village where she will take a road back to the port. Catra gets instructions from mayor to be sure she won't get lost, but apparently the road is clearly marked with few deviations, and the ones that are there are all labeled.

"He said it's so any foreigners who wander out from port can get back without bothering the villages," Catra tells Adora, her lip twitching as she kneels down on the edge of the dock to say goodbye. Adora chuckles before turning pleading eyes on Catra. Catra rolls her eyes, but she leans down. Adora grins, beating her tail to rise out of the water. Her hands hooked on the edge of the dock steady her as she kisses Catra. The embrace is slow, a soft goodbye kiss for her wife. It soothes Adora's fluttering heart. When they pull apart, they are both grinning.

"I'll see you tonight," Catra promises her, reaching down to squeeze her hand on the dock once before she straightens. Adora watches her stand with just a touch of hunger in her eyes, drinking in every detail of her wife before she has to go a day without her.

"I'll be waiting at your bridge," Adora returns. Catra's answering smile is soft and wistful – she's looking forward to their reunion. That knowledge calms Adora as Catra waves goodbye and sets across the dock to return to the land. Adora follows along beneath the water walkways until she can't anymore, watching Catra cross over onto real roads and disappear around the sides of building.

She has a day to herself stretching out before her. She turns away, ducking beneath the waves and heading out to sea. She shouldn't waste the time she has – she wouldn't want to spend some time she could be with Catra on another day combing the ocean.

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Adora swims out further than she has ever gone. She has never had so long to explore before. She is determined to go for distance, exploring parts of the sea she doesn't normally get to see. She absolutely doesn't miss being alone, just *wondering* how Catra was doing and if she was thinking of Adora, but she does miss the freedom of exploring and going anywhere, at least within the seas where the Horde operated, as she searched for Catra.

If Catra still had her ship, Adora could see more of the ocean. Now they are tied to one spot on land, though, Adora mostly stays in the same portion of the sea. She enjoys seeing new landscapes, searching them for a souvenir as she travels. Her instinct to bring things back to Catra has calmed down again now she has accepted the jawbone, but Adora might find something nice out here that she wouldn't normally be able to get her hands on.

She still likes to carve, after all. It keeps her claws in shape. She doesn't actually know if it wears them down, sharpens them, or dulls them, but she is certain it is good for her, and she likes the results too. Catra seems to think they're pretty as well, so Adora is happy to continue it on whatever she finds on the ocean floor. If she can find something better than rocks, though, this day will have been worth the distance.

Adora loves her wife, but she can go a day without her. There's an entire ocean before her.

--

Adora alternates between getting caught up and desperately waiting for time to pass, but she manages to find an odd collection of bones that makes it all worth it. She finds a rock formation – maybe the remnants of a sunken island – that jabs up high in the sea. There is evidence of a long-past shipwreck around the rocky spires, and she finds a collection of bones near the base. They're wedged into the rock formation as if gathered there by a predator, but Adora doesn't care how they ended up there. They seem perfect for carving, so she selects one – an arm or leg bone, she thinks - and hopes their gatherer won't miss it too badly.

It is midday now, and with something accomplished, it seems a good time to return to the island. She notes the location of the formation so she can return to it to see about pinching another bone in the future, but she wants to be back before sunset, and she knows her cargo will slow her down, so it is time to turn back. The bone is far from heavy, but it occupies one of her hands and increases the drag of the ocean on her as she swims.

Despite the slight delay, she arrives back just as the top of the sun is dipping behind the horizon. She swims to their inlet eagerly . She feels herself wilt when she sees no form standing on the bridge. She pops above the water, feeling her ears twitch as she looks around. Catra said they would meet back on the bridge and Adora sees no sign of her, but she calls out with a few chirps in case Catra had to duck into the shack for something. She gets nothing in response but the crashing of waves on the nearby shore.

The sky is quickly darkening. Catra will have to be back soon. Adora reluctantly sinks down in the sea, settling in beneath the bridge to begin to clean the bone. Hopefully Catra will return before she is

even ready to carve, but in the meantime she can work on prepping it. If Catra doesn't arrive in time, at least she has a project.

--

Adora hates her anxiety. Catra doesn't arrive in time – Catra doesn't *arrive*. Adora cleans the bone, and then she digs her claws into it, carving out shapes and telling herself with every line that it will be the last one before she hears footsteps on the bridge above her. They agreed to meet here. Adora can't leave. She can't stop the movement of her fingers either, not until the bone that she told herself she would merely get started on is completely covered in carved patterns. Every inch she covers feels like agony, but eventually there is nothing left to carve without destroying her previous work.

Adora stares down at the decorated bone in her hand, her heart racing. Above her, the bridge is silent. Catra isn't there, or in her house. Even if she got back early and immediately laid down for a nap, she would have woken by now and come out. Adora's arms twitch as she tightly clutches the bone, unwilling to let it go or even look away from it and acknowledge what she has known for a long time – Catra isn't here, and she isn't just a moment away from returning. Adora closes her eyes, screwing them up and taking a deep breath before she emerges from beneath the bridge and swims to the bank.

She takes the bone and drives it into the bank, one carved end sticking out from the silt. She doesn't care about it anymore, she just needs her hands free. She stares at the shack door and calls out again, a song this time, loud and desperate for connection. The night is silent. The moon is sinking low in the sky now, night stretching into dawn as the hours have passed. Adora's eyes scan the surroundings of the shack, the bridge, the beach, and even the tree

line, searching for any clue to Catra's whereabouts, but the only thing out of place is Catra herself.

She simply never returned, it seems. She should have by now – she should have *already* . Adora swallows, glaring at the shack door. She slinks back and then puts on a burst of speed, using the momentum to throw herself as high up on the bank as she can. She has never tried to do something this ambitious before – being out of the water like this isn't *good* for her – but she has to find Catra, which means she has to check. She drags herself through the sand, mud, and dirt up to the shack door.

She can hardly reach the doorknob. Adora manages to stretch up from her position on her stomach and open it, flopping inside with a hiss of pain as her chest cushions her landing as much as it amplifies the impact against it. She takes a second to breathe before pushing up with her arms to lift her torso again and craning her head around, searching the room. Catra lying on the floor, knocked out from an unfortunate fall, wasn't a *good* scenario, but it was better than some of the other hypothetical ones in Adora's head. Catra isn't here, however.

Adora has never been in the shack before. She can't begin to guess if this is how it was when Catra left this morning, but nothing seems oddly out of place. The far end has a hammock stretched between one proper mount and one makeshift hook in the wall. A spare crate with wide slats stored beneath appears to contain clothes. Next to that is a small pile of fabric, blankets and towels neatly folded. There are a few crates along the walls, all appearing to be dilapidated enough to have been in the shack since before Catra's arrival. On them are some stacked dishes, tools, and other belongings, but Adora recognizes all of them from when Catra first brought them back to the shack.

There is only one object that even catches Adora' s eye, and it isn't a hint as to what happened to her lover. Her gaze lands on the mobile that Catra appears to have made for herself above her bed. The jawbone Adora so carefully carved for her is tied up in fishing line so

it can hang from the crossbeam of the shack's roof above the hammock. It must be the first thing Catra sees upon waking up in the morning and the last thing she sees when she falls asleep at night. Adora swallows, watching it gently sway in the draft produced by the sea breeze.

She has to find Catra.

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The villagers know Adora is here, but according to Catra, she should still try to stay out of sight. The more blatant she is about her existence, the more likely word is to get out to the other inhabitants of the island, or even worse, to those passing through the port. Catra was afraid of a siren hunt beginning. She has kept the lifeboat from the half moon stashed in a pile of fronds down the beach from her shack and services it weekly in case they have to flee. Adora checks the boat, but the leaf pile is undisturbed. It leaves the village as her only option.

Dawn is just beginning to break. Adora swims beneath the walkways, popping up to peer up at them intermittently to search for signs of Catra, or even traces of a fight. She startles a few early risers walking along the paths, but she doesn't spare a glance for them despite how some attempt conversation, or at least greetings. They aren't talking about Catra, so what they're saying doesn't matter. Nothing else is important, but Adora finds no trace of her. She doesn't have much of a choice now.

She swims to the stilted house where the mayor resides and settles beneath it, calling up in a soft warble. She doesn't want to make a scene among the other residents, but she needs him to wake up. She pauses after the call, listening intently, but she hears no movement above her. She calls again, a bit louder and more

insistent this time. Still, nothing. She bites her lip, unsure of what to do. She really shouldn't cause a panic by singing too much in the heart of the village. It will only make it harder to get help.

She beats her tail, rising out of the water and pounding the side of her fist against the bottom of the house. She hears a few things rattle and an utterance that is probably a curse. Relieved, she warbles again, doing her best to beg while ensuring she keeps the magic out of her song. A moment later, there is a soft thud above her. Adora eagerly swims out beneath the house, popping up on the other side of the walkway in front of it. She waits a few moments, her anxiety building again as she waits, but luckily the door swings open to reveal the mayor eventually.

He blinks down at her, clearly surprised by her presence. Adora has seen him a few times since the first two days, but mostly in the distance. He came wandering over to Catra's shack last week to check on how she was settling in, but it was a very brief visit. Afterwards, Catra joked that Adora unnerved him – which wasn't much of a joke, since it seemed to be true given his shifting demeanor around her, but then Catra leered that not many could handle a woman like her and the whole thing devolved into a posturing flirting session between the two of them.

"Do you need help, ma'am?" the mayor asks her, glancing around. He is looking for Catra, no doubt. The men in the village tend to get anxious when spotting Adora, though the women are usually excited. No one is used to seeing her without Catra – Adora knows Catra is her keeper in their eyes – and the mayor seems just as unnerved now as he had been entering their little home space uninvited. Adora suspects he gave Catra the shack more to keep Adora away from the village proper than out of the kindness of his heart, but he still saw the benefit of her presence.

"My wife is missing," Adora tells him, her voice low. She watches his eyes widen, a bit of his anxiety seeming to vanish now he knows her purpose. His brow pinches as he frowns. He looks around again, as if Catra is hiding behind a barrel and Adora just has spotted her yet.

Adora clears her throat. "She walked to visit her friends at port yesterday morning. She never came home. I can't look for her," Adora elaborates. The mayor – who she is realizing for the first time is only half dressed in pants and a nightshirt – presses his mouth in a line and glances in the direction of the port. The other houses are blocking the sightline, and it's barely visible down the coast anyway, but there is anxiety in his gaze.

"We've had a few get roughed up by docked pirates there before. Stole their things and such. If she doesn't know the island's interior, it's possible someone ran her off into it and she got lost," he offers. When he speaks of the past, his voice is darkened by long-present anger, but he ends with a hopeful lilt. Whether he wants to believe that Catra is merely lost or he is just trying to keep Adora calm by leading *her* to believe it, she doesn't know, but she knows it is wrong regardless. She scowls at him, ignoring the way it makes his shoulders instantly tense.

"She can handle herself in a fight. If she had gotten lost, she would have picked a direction and walked until she reached the coast. It has been half a day since she was due to return. She would have made it home by now. Something *happened*, and I can't go to port without causing a scene," Adora shoots back. She tries not to glare at him, but it's insulting to insinuate that Catra doesn't know how to survive. Something happened and she needs help. Suggestions like this only delay it.

The mayor winces and raises his hands as if to placate her. Adora restrains her annoyance down to a low growl and forces herself to relax a little, sinking lower in the water until just her eyes are above it. The mayor raises his hand to rub at the base of his neck, thinking it over for a moment with a frown firmly settles into his features. He looks like he is having unpleasant thoughts, but welcome to Adora's last day of hypothetical disasters running through her mind.

"I can walk to the port this afternoon and check the path. I'll ask after a magicat fisherman who didn't show up for work, but if it's possible it could invite trouble, I can't keep pursuing it and possibly bring

trouble for the rest of the village,” he tells her. Adora tightens her grip on the edge of the walkway, digging in her claws as annoyance flares within her. Catra needs help, and this mild-mannered avoidance could leave her in danger, but it’s also the only option she has right now.

She can’t go looking herself. She needs this man’s legs. He has seemed to suspect something about their origins ever since they arrived, and his words only reinforce that now. Catra’s possible enemies range from everyone in the Horde if they knew she had a role in the sinking of the Black Garnet to anyone with a problem with pirates, but Catra’s career was short and largely crimeless. No one should recognize her. Adora glares indistinctly at the man’s bare feet, eye level with her, forcing herself to pull in her annoyance before she speaks.

“Just find out what happened to her. Please. She wouldn’t vanish like this unless something bad happened. She needs help,” she tells him, finally looking up to meet his eyes. She knows there is a hard edge to her gaze, but she can’t soften it. He nods nervously, shifting from foot-to-foot. Reluctantly, Adora pries her claws from the edge of the dock and lets go, sinking a little down into the water. The mayor gives her a nod goodbye, apparently taking the opening the second Adora gives him one, and then retreats into his house by backing into it, seeming unwilling to turn his back on her until the door is closed.

Reluctantly, Adora turns away, plunging beneath the waves and swimming away with her chest aching. At least someone will go looking for Catra where she can’t. She just has to hope that he finds something. Concern, anger, and the worst kind of fear mix in her chest. She will have to wait a few hours at best to hear back. In the meantime, she will follow the island’s coast and see if she can spot anything amiss.

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She sees nothing along the shores. She swims along the bottom of the port harbor and finds many lost items, but nothing belonging to Catra, nor a body. She doesn't dare surface there and risk getting spotted. All her searching turns up nothing. When she returns to the village, she finds the mayor shortly after sundown. He jumps with a start when Adora rises out of the water. They are on a walkway in the middle of the village, in eyeshot of a few people, but Adora doesn't care.

"Where is she?" she asks. The mayor's expression darkens. He sighs, looking down and rubbing at the back of his neck. He is nervous, shifting where he stands. Adora growls lowly, a threat to start talking. He knows something. If he has bad news, Adora would rather know it than picture a thousand scenarios in her head.

"I didn't find her. There's a Primary Navy ship docked in port. It will leave tomorrow and then I can ask after her, but I can't draw their attention onto the village by going poking around while they're docked," he tells her. Adora can't help herself. She hisses, not necessarily angry at him, but more at the world in general. She knows about the Navy – it's hard to *not* know about a force set on invading your home continent, even if no one knows where in the distant seas the fleet sailed from – but they shouldn't be a problem when it comes to searching for Catra.

The Navy are invaders, but they generally don't take on Horde pirates. Apparently they know better than to fight on two fronts by challenging both the Horde and Etheria's crown at the same time. They have parleyed with the Horde in the past, but they were far from allies with them. They shouldn't care enough to be interested in vengeance on Catra if they somehow found out about her past or role in the Black Garnet's sinking.

The Navy should have no interest in a mayor looking for a fisherman who has wandered off anyway. Asking around after a local shouldn't draw attention unless the mayor has reason to suspect that they are

involved. Adora narrows her eyes at the man, anger bubbling up inside her. She has always tried to be a nice person despite being a pirate and now living off the souls of men, but his gaze skitters away and Adora knows he is lying to her, even if it is just by omission.

"You have a *heck* of a lot to tell me the truth before I command you to throw yourself into the sea," she threatens, her voice low and gravely. She hates how similar her voice sounds to the slaver she originally stole it from in this moment, but he knows something about what happened to Catra and he is withholding it from her. She wouldn't eat him, but he doesn't need to know that, and she might pull him into the waves and let him panic a bit if it became necessary.

She watches his skin tint green as he pales, raising his hands to quickly gesture for her to calm. She can hear his heartbeat racing like terrified prey as he glances around, but no one is close enough to have overheard the threat, even if his demeanor is enough for the intent to get across. He is obviously scared of her. He just has to decide if he's more afraid of whatever he is hiding than of her. She digs her claws into the walkway, growling lowly.

"I don't know, I didn't ask questions!" he rushes, glancing around before swallowing and taking a cautious step closer to her – a bold move – to whisper his next sentence so it can't be overheard. "All I know is that I overheard a dock worker grumbling about picking up the slack for his co-worker the Primary Navy arrested for piracy last night. I have no idea who it was- *Wait!*" he cuts off with a yell, desperate and loud enough to cut through the waves even after Adora has turned and flung herself into the water, preparing to make a mad dash for the harbor.

She growls to herself, surfacing and turning to look back to him. She should get all the information she can before taking on the ship, but he has to be talking about Scorpia. Catra heard from a fisherman who sails to port regularly that she was working at the dock and wanted to pass on a greeting. If they arrested Scorpia, then Catra

either got swept up in it or is lingering and planning to break her free. She needs Adora's help regardless.

Adora wants to go straight to the port, especially now that the night will provide her with some cover. She glares at the mayor. He is still anxious, but he motions her closer. Adora darts her gaze around the area first, but though they have drawn eyes, no one has dared to approach the scene, just watching it unfold from where they were already standing. She swims back, glaring up at the mayor as he bends to whisper to her again, his expression pleading.

"Please, I can go back after they leave and find out exactly what happened. If a Primary Navy ship is sunk in our port, it could bring the fleet down on us. You'd be endangering the entire island if you rush in headfirst after her," he begs. Adora narrows her eyes up at him. It doesn't seem like a good enough reason to lie when a life – *Catra's* life – could hang in the balance. The Navy had one of their man-of-wars stolen once by deserters and got over it. She doubts a ship sinking to a siren would draw their ire onto nearby villagers.

The fact remains that she can't sink it while it is port, though. It wouldn't work well, it would endanger everyone in town who could also hear the song, and it would bring scrutiny down on her and Catra once she rescued her wife – the list of reasons why it would be a terrible idea goes on even longer. She hates the idea of leaving Catra in the ship - at best in prison and at worse in danger or *extend* - overnight, but he is right that she can't sink the ship right now.

"You rise at dawn and head to port. The moment it undocks, you ask around. When you know what happened, meet me at the longest dock. If she is onboard, I will follow it away from the island before I sink it. The retribution for lying or letting her get hurt will be worse than anything the Navy could do to you," Adora instructs. The mayor looks scared shitless, but he nods. He doesn't have any other option.

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As much as Adora wants to go investigate the ship, she is worried about the mayor running. He is her best chance for finding Catra, especially if she isn't on the ship. Adora follows his path along the walkways of the village, swimming beneath his footfalls and ghosting him until he retires to his house. The urge to swim to port only grows with every hour of the night that passes, but she can't lose him. With the first tinge of color to the sky, the front door opens.

Adora follows him along the walkways back to land, turmoil raging in her as she watches him take the same path that Catra did. He glances over his shoulder anxiously as he disappears onto the island proper. Now Adora can resist no longer. She turns away and swims along the coastline, heading straight for the port. She stays deep enough in the water that she shouldn't be spotted, circling the ships in the harbor until she finds what she guesses to be the navy ship.

It is hard to tell without surfacing. If she rises high enough in the water to read its name or see its colors, then she risks someone above being able to see her as well. There are only two ships painted black in port, however, and one seems too small to belong to the Navy. Adora dives down and investigates the harbor floor beneath the ship, but she finds nothing and didn't expect to. Even if there was a clue, the sea could have carried away.

She returns to the ship, not daring to leave it alone. She knows it is highly unlikely for the ship to be able to sneak away without her noticing, but she still lurks beneath it until the ship shudders with preparations and begins to pull out of the harbor. Adora quickly swims to the long pier she noticed while searching for Catra the day before. She surfaces beneath its end, peering up at the gaps in the wooden slats. No boots are waiting for her.

She resists the urge to growl as she instead turns her gaze on the navy ship. She was right – it flies the Primary Navy colors, a dark

beast cutting through the bright morning sky. It seems especially out of place in the bright, almost tropical climate of Octopus Cove. It isn't a man-of-war, not quite as large as the Black Garnet nor boasting as many canons, but the ship is huge. Adora's body aches from tension as she watches it sail away. It will be in sight for awhile yet, but with every moment that passes she wants to go after it more.

She doesn't need food. She is still bursting with magic from the Black Garnet's sinking. It would be a complete waste of life to sink it if Catra wasn't on board, even if they are invaders. Adora knows little about the reality of the conflict between Etheria and the fleet. It came in a small, exploratory force nearly three decades ago. A few years later, a greater fleet arrived with the intent to conquer. Hordak defected then, used to the life of semi-piracy he had begun to enjoy as a member of the initial fleet just trying to get by in a foreign land while they waited for the rest of the fleet to follow them to the land they discovered.

The islanders don't like the Primary Navy, and that is almost enough to convince Adora to swim after it and sink it just in case, but boots sound on the dock above her before she can commit and she startles. Conspicuously, the mayor hisses *psst*, sounding nervous as he stops to stand near the edge. Adora tears her gaze from the ship, beating her tail and surfacing just past the end of the dock. She looks up to find the mayor standing there, glancing around nervously. His expression is dark as he makes eye contact with her.

"I couldn't find the shipwright who arrived with you either, but a dockworker told me a magicat pirate got arrested and one of the other workers got swept up in accusations of piracy as well when she defended her as a friend," he tells her. Adora's heart pounds in her chest. That doesn't make *sense*. The Primary Navy has never given a shit about pirates. The Horde avoids them and they avoid it. Unless they're trying to earn goodwill with the people after years of attempted conquest, suddenly turning on the pirates that are mostly harassing their enemies doesn't make sense.

Adora turns her head, staring out at the Navy ship. It truly is a ship from the Navy, bearing no resemblance to a Horde ship masquerading as a part of them for protection. And yet someone from the Horde must have put them up to this. There is no other way for them to even know Catra is a pirate. She has never raided before, her only job quiet work on the Black Garnet and one failed siren hunt. Someone must have survived the Black Garnet's shipwreck.

Shadow Weaver is dead, there was no way for her to survive when she was so far gone, but Adora never saw Hordak. Has he gone crawling back to his original master now he has no ship or crew to dominate with? If so, why would they take him back and help him seek revenge? There has to be more going on here, but Adora can't see the answer. Maybe Catra will know when she finds her. Adora can't delay further – she turns back to the mayor, nodding once to him, and then flings herself into the waves, swimming after the ship.

She will stay true to her word and follow it out of sight of the island, but then she is going to get her wife back.

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Sinking the ship – the Velvet Cove, according to the painting on its hull – is more complicated than sinking the Black Garnet. She wanted the Black Garnet sinking to be as destructive as possible as a distraction so Catra could escape the fight on the Halfmoon. Adora needs to bring the Velvet Cove down, but she can't sing the twisted song she summoned then. It would put Catra – and Scorpia, if she is indeed the worker who got swept up with her – in more danger at the hands of the crew than they already are.

The good news is the Primary Navy must come from seas where sirens aren't common, because they don't allow women within their

ranks. There should be none on board – other than prisoners – to stop the crew from drowning themselves. The Horde only had women as part of its structure due to it already being a tradition amongst the pirate crews who were joining up and Shadow Weaver's insistence that it was necessary.

Hordak was willing to listen, but he never implemented more than a one-woman minimum on Horde ships, and he *should* have paid the ultimate price for it. Adora doesn't know. She never knew, she supposes, who actually perished in the Black Garnet's sinking, but she certainly hoped he was amongst them. Shadow Weaver was their personal tormentor, but he wasn't kinder – he knew what cadets on his ship went through, after all, and didn't give half a shit to stop it.

Adora follows beneath the ship, scratching absently at the hull to see if she could claw through it. She thinks she can, but it would take her a while. She could sing the crew docile as the ship slowly filled with water, but letting it sink that way would put Catra at great risk if she is trapped in a cell and Adora doesn't reach her in time. It might be more dangerous than the destruction of the warsong from before. Adora's best chance is a traditional sinking, luring the ship to dangerous waters and letting rocks damage it as sailors jump into the water.

Adora's exploration of the seas around the island is suddenly paying off. The rocky outcrop where she found the bones to carve is not far from here. It rises high enough in the water to trap a ship. The Velvet Cove isn't heading that way, but it doesn't matter. With no women on board, there is no voice of reason to turn them around when all the men become gripped by the urge to follow a song leading them off course. Adora swims to the bow, taking up position as she takes a deep breath. This song will be lighter than her warsong, but she will still be light-headed by the time she is done.

She opens her mouth, and she begins to sing.

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Without hesitancy, the ship follows her. Adora swims along the surface, rising above it and ducking just beneath again, leading the ship away. No yelling breaks out on deck, no one scrambles to the bow to fire on her, and no alarm is raised. Unlike every one of the horde ships she sunk, this one follows her passively, the crew made docile by her tempting call, promising heaven at the end of the journey. That they believe she means bliss and not death is their personal undoing.

The rocky outcrop is a distance from Octopus Cove. Adora has never had to sing for this long before. She knows where she is going, but she begins to feel a bit dizzy as the song stretches on. To be safe, she flips over to float along the surface, propelling herself with her tail so she doesn't get disoriented diving beneath the waves and start swimming in the wrong direction. It helps with her spinning head, but it also slows her down, stretching out how long she has to keep up the song for.

She can't take a break and risk the crew turning tail and running or firing upon her once the fog clears. She can't stop singing until Catra is freed. Catra has to be able to hear it and know Adora is coming for her, so hopefully she is working on trying to escape her cell so she doesn't get locked in it with water once the ship sinks, but it is likely she can't do anything. She would have escaped already if she could. Adora gazes up at the sun above her, midway through its daily journey across the heavens, feeling hazy as she sings.

Her song is growing weaker. She has to force the continuous notes spilling forth. They are fueled by magic and not really her diaphragm, but the effect of holding it for so long is similar to oxygen deprivation. Her head spins and her chest buzzes, her limbs feeling heavy as the beating of her tail turns sluggish. They are close to the rocks, she knows they are, but she doesn't know if she can *make* it. Even

worse, she knows she can't manage a warsong without resting first now, so she doesn't have any option but to keep pushing on.

Her eyes drift closed for a moment as she sings, just wanting to rest some part of her, but the disorientation instantly takes hold of her. Despite not moving position, her heart races as her body desperately warns her that she is lost and needs to twist wildly to reorient. Her eyes fly open as she gasps for air – and the song dies in her throat. Adrenaline pounds through her as her body tries to calm now it can see she is floating on her back, perfectly safe except for the song pausing and putting not only her but Catra in danger. She opens her mouth, gulping in a breath to prepare to sing again and hope it isn't too late-

The song starts again. Adora closes her mouth, blinking up at the bright sky. She- she isn't doing that. She swallows, the adrenaline calming a little, though her hands are trembling from a combination of it and all the effort she has expended already. It took her a moment to realize, but the song is coming from beneath her and growing louder. Adora turns her head and looks as, to her left, a head surfaces from the waves. Adora blinks at the other siren.

Adora has never seen her before, but the siren gives her a slight smile around the song. Adora takes in the tanned blonde, a mass of curls spreading out behind her like a cape. The siren flips over to join Adora in swimming on her back, slowly beating her vibrantly pink tail. Adora knows she is disoriented, but she can't figure out where this siren came from or why she unquestioningly picked up Adora's song when it died in her throat. She doesn't even know what the odds of running into another siren out in the ocean is.

The blonde reaches for her, taking Adora's wrist in her own hand, and then begins to beat her tail in earnest, picking up their pace. Adora swallows, shifting awkwardly as her arm twists a bit painfully, but after a moment, she gets readjusted and blinks up at the woman as she adds a warm, encouraging note in the midst her song. She is not only picking up where Adora left off, but helping to tow her to the rocks where Adora has been leading them. She knows of them-

actually, Adora realizes, the shipwreck around the rocks and collection of bones probably wasn't a *coincidence*.

She stumbled upon another siren's lair and stole from her. Hopefully this bounty of souls – and bones – will incline her to forgive Adora. She is kind enough to help Adora after she overextended herself, after all. Adora knows she must look bad, dazed and confused, her magic discordant. She might be struggling so much because she is trying to sing an inviting song when her emotions and magic are so darkened with worry for Catra. She didn't even know that she was capable of the warsong until she sang it, but it came naturally to her in that moment.

The other siren might just be helping her under the mistaken impression that she is starving and needs this – she doesn't doubt she looks it – but Adora is grateful for the help regardless. The relief would well up as tears in her eyes if she was physically capable of crying anymore. Instead, she takes a moment to close her eyes and let her body just relax before she opens them and gently pulls her wrist from the other woman's grip. She is already helping Adora. Without the song shaking her body, Adora can swim on her own. They aren't far now.

The woman glances down to her to check, but when Adora offers her a small, grateful smile, she nods back and flips over onto her stomach, beginning to swim just beneath the waves like Adora was at first. It is faster and safer for them, limiting their sun exposure – something Adora has to be careful of given how much time she spends on shores. Adora follows her, wondering if Catra can detect the change in the song and if it has her worried. At least it won't be long now. When they reach the rocks, they'll be together again.

Chapter End Notes

Catra seeing siren Adora for the first time: tits 😳
Adora meeting siren Perfuma: *quiet hair jealousy*

Catra the Chained

Chapter Notes

CW for implied/referenced drowning & character death.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It's fucking degrading eating without utensils, but she has no other choice shackled to the wall of the cell without use of her hands. She can't move her hands or forearms at all. The shackles are the exact kind that slavers use on hybrids to prevent them from using their claws. Her hands are curled into fists and locked in position so that unsheathing her claws would only result in stabbing her own palms. In her awkward position, she can't get any leverage at all. Scorpia got lucky. They had shackle bands to clamp her pincers shut in a vice, but they aren't made to attach to the wall and she can still move somewhat.

"At least they fed us," Scorpia tries. Catra growls back. They have been here for over a day and this is the first time they have been given anything to eat, even if it is *something*. Scorpia is trying to look on the bright side, but her stinger is capped and shackled to the wall as well and she only has a few inches of radius granted by her tail's length to move. They're both in a shit position. They mucked Catra after she bit the hell out of them in the fight.

Her gun, picked up from the wreck of the Black Garnet, was fucking useless it turned out. She hadn't tried to fire it before because she only had a handful of bullets and didn't want to waste them until she could get more, but she had cleaned and cared for it in hopes that it would be in working order. It jammed the instant she tried to fire it. She and Scorpia did damage before they were taken down – Catra left men bleeding from her claws and Scorpia dropped them with her stinger – but it seemed like the entire fucking ship descended on them and no bystanders were sticking around to help.

Catra walked past some men in Primary Navy uniforms as she entered the docks to look for Scorpia, but she didn't think twice about it. No one should know she was a pirate, and even if they did, the Navy shouldn't *a*. The enemy of thy enemy is thy friend and all that. It turns out they were a little more friendly than anybody ever knew. The Black G*a*rnet wasn't in the Sea of Sigh because the Primary Navy was getting too aggressive claiming the area – H*o*rdak was cutting a fucking deal to re*j*oin. Or maybe he never left in the first place. These sailors know way too much.

H*o*rdak is on board the ship, pulled by the Navy out of the wreckage of the Black G*a*rnet along with a number of his men, though Catra only recogni*z*ed one or two amongst the crew on board. Still, even that few have j*o*ined the Navy suspiciously q*u*ickly. Catra isn't a fucking idiot – she can pick up the distant voices of the crew and put together the pieces of information, especially after H*o*rdak sneered to her that she and her lover will never get their dream of usurping him when she was brought before him in his tiny closet – clearly a makeshift cell pretending to be private q*u*arters – to confirm her identity.

He has been passing information to the Navy for a long time. H*o*w staged his defecting was will never be known, but it allowed him to gain trust with the criminals of Etheria and eventually command and coordinate them in a way that they never would have if the Navy approached them outright. Shadow Weaver had to have known – she was a bitch, but a smart one. Suddenly all her preparation for Adora to become the q*u*artermaster of the H*o*rde makes sense. She wasn't meant to replace Shadow Weaver upon her death, but upon her promotion when she inevitably stabbed H*o*rdak in the back and became the pirate king herself.

Catra is kind of fucking furious for never seeing any of it. It's obvious to retrospect, especially after having a day to stew in the hold of the ship. The Navy never bothered them. The H*o*rde would don *t*hei*r* colors to scare off other ships rather than "false" Etherian crown ones. It worked, but it also made the Navy seem like it was a larger,

more widespread force around Etheria's coasts. It would lead to false reports of Primary Navy sightings when the ships they crossed reached mainland and reported them to the authorities. Etherian colors would have made them feel safe, and any downside like inviting trouble from the Primary Navy went the other way with using Navy colors instead since Etherian warships would still be inclined to fight them.

Bordak miraculously convincing most of his crew on the man-of-war to take over the ship completely and run off to live a life of piracy was always a ridiculous story to begin with. Other pirates have successfully captured similar ships in the past, so people bought it, but Bordak doesn't have the fucking charisma to pull that off. The man has the personality of a desiccated plum. Catra comforts herself that the Navy doesn't seem willing to welcome him with open arms at least. His quarters were tiny. This crew, at least, isn't sure he is truly an ally.

They are still willing to seek revenge on the pirates that sunk their man-of-war, though. Catra knew others had to have survived, but fuck does she wish it had been anyone but Bordak. He was the one person who could have pieced the whole story behind the sinking together. He knew that Adora was lost to sirens, that drowned women supposedly can become them, and that Catra was sent to hunt them. He is always notified when a ship tries to dock with the Black Garnet. Even if he didn't see a glimpse of them in the wreck, he could have pieced together some of what happened when the Halfmoon docked and then a siren shortly sank them.

His words made it clear that he believed the act was deliberately malicious, an attempt to take out the heads of the Horde and install Catra in his place with her siren enforcer at her side. Catra would have spat back that she doesn't give enough of a shit about him to murder him, but she was already muzzled. She would certainly like to kill him *now*, every inch of her aching as she shifts to rest her forehead against the cool surface of the metal-enforced wall she is shackled against.

The only thing she has to be grateful for is that Entrapta didn't get swept up in this too. They were spotted when Catra arrived at the docks in the morning. Scorpia had the day off, but she found Entrapta in the shipyard. After getting directions to where they were staying, Catra bid her goodbye with plans for them to meet up at the tavern after Entrapta finished her work. Catra found Scorpia at their house, and they got to hang out for a good portion of the day, but just as they were about to head to the tavern to meet with Entrapta, she noticed men had started tailing them.

Catra quickly changed their direction, lying that she wanted to see where Scorpia worked before it got too dark. She wanted to check if they were truly being followed, and the docks seemed like a good place for a scuffle. The men were in casualwear. Catra was paranoid about possibilities, but she was hoping they were regular criminals and didn't realize who they truly were until they set foot on the dock and were suddenly surrounded. She hoped that Entrapta would be concerned when they didn't show and go to Adora in time for her to reach the harbor, but the ship has undocked and there has been no sign of help.

Catra feels fucking miserable. She didn't suspect the entire conspiracy, but she *knew* she had reason to be paranoid. She thought she was starting to relax and fight her fears when she decided that she wanted to come visit port, taking the first step toward moving on, but it turned out that missing her crew made her let her guard down. Stupid fucking weakness. She always told Adora that all they needed was each other and she should have stuck to that. She bought into her own retirement act, trying to act like she was a normal person. She was never going to be, not when her first memory starts in iron shackles just like the ones caging her now , misery all around her-

Singing. Catra's tail puffs out as she jolts as upright as her binds allow her to, her ears twitching and swiveling to *listen* for the voice she knows so well. It is hard to track time in the hold, but it has been long enough since they undocked that Catra lost hope for Adora

finding them. Her heart races as Scorpia perks up beside her and looks to her, hope in her eyes. She looks to Catra, clearly bolstered by Catra's reaction.

"Is that her?" she asks, a bit breathless. She has heard Adora's singing voice plenty, but it has been a while. Catra can't reply, but she nods wordlessly, elation flooding through her body. Now they just have to wait.

--

Catra is shocked by how long the singing goes on. Nothing happens. The ship keeps sailing as if it isn't there. No alarm goes up, no one runs down to threaten her to shut her wife up, and the ship *doesn't start sinking*. It doesn't make sense. It is as if the crew are ghosts. She heard lots of footsteps – though unhurried – heading up to the deck when the singing started, but nothing ever since then. When the song stops, her breath catches.

It must only last a second, but it is the longest second of Catra's life, waiting for all hell to break loose. It doesn't, but Catra's heart plummets anyway when the song restarts. That isn't Adora's voice. Even when it was twisted into a hateful and violent song during the sinking of the Black Garnet, Adora's voice never sounded anything like that. That is someone else singing. Catra tugs on her shackles despite how she knows they are solid. Her heart and mind are racing with the possibilities of what happened to Adora.

"That was weird," Scorpia mutters, shooting her a questioning look. She hasn't realized that not only has the song changed, but the *singer*. Catra lets out a desperate whimper in her muzzle, tugging on her arms again despite how it fucking hurts. She is bruised from a day and a half of being locked up. She wants to scream and shout, screaming out for Adora, but she can do nothing as the new song

stretches on around them. Her head was starting to pound from the noise, but this new song grates against her in a way that Adora's voice didn't.

The ship just keeps sailing on. It is equally effective against the sailors, it seems, whether that means *very* or *not at all*. Catra wants to fucking cry. She hurts from the injuries sustained in the fight, only worsened from being trapped in this uncomfortable position for so long. Her stomach is empty from the singular meal, and she is dehydrated too, even if they have been given water more often. It is difficult to drink with the straw they fashioned to slide beneath her muzzle.

She is in misery, and she still doesn't know what happened to Adora. She yanks at her shackles again, the pain flaring. She collapses forward against the wall. She has no strength left. At this point, the ship sinking would be worse than being stuck in it. She has desperately paddled on the surface of the water in the inlet as Adora circled her to be sure she was safe, but she doesn't know how to really swim, and she doesn't have the strength for it if the cell managed to break open in the wreck.

It is lined with metal bracings, a cage high up in the center of the ship's layout. It's unlikely it would be damaged. After what feels like an eternity, the ship rams into something, knocking Catra painfully to the side, yanking her against her restraints. Scorpia yelps behind her as Catra groans, also thrown by the ship shuddering and groaning, although at least she can catch herself with her arms. Catra's heart drops as her ears pick up the sound of the hull tearing and water beginning to flood.

This is her second time being on a sinking ship in *weeks*. This time she isn't up on the deck, throwing off pirates trying to subdue her quietly. Then, she was able to leap up into the rigging to survey the situation around her. When it was clear her ship was going down, she scanned the water and spotted a piece of wreckage that looked like it could keep floating even with her bodyweight on it. She leaped

down to plunge into the water close to it, paddling over and climbing on until Adora found her. She doesn't have that option now.

This time, she is locked in a metal box headed for the ocean floor, unable to move. She screws her eyes shut and pins her ears back. She is really glad that she spotted their tails before she led them straight to Entrapta too. If Adora is even still here after whatever happened with the song changing, Catra and Scorpia are still going to drown side-by-side if she doesn't get inside the ship and search it fast enough. Catra can't imagine having to watch Entrapta die too.

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The damage to the ship is nothing like what was done to the Halfmoon or the Black Garnet. This ship sinks more slowly, the quality of the song changing outside the hull. Catra can tell it is laced with temptation, perhaps ordering the sailors to throw themselves into the sea. The song comes and goes in bursts now, but Adora's voice never pins it. The sound of water grows louder, their ever-encroaching demise becoming inescapable before Scorpia swears – well, she mutters *damn it*, but the intention is the same – and scrambles back against the wall.

"I hope that girl of yours knows what she's doing," Scorpia half-spikes, half-pleads, anxiety in her voice. Catra turns her head to see the water lapping up the floor towards them. The ship is sinking at an angle, her bow lower than the rest of her. Catra doesn't bother trying to scramble to the higher end of the cell as the water begins to rush in. She would gain a few centimeters at most with her shackles pinning her. Her heart races as the water laps around her ankles. In moments, it is knee deep around her, and then lapping at her thighs as it reaches Scorpia's feet.

The ship has been slow to sink, the damage probably minor at first, but as the water has poured in either the holes have widened or the increased pressure alone was enough to force it through, because the cell floods fast. Maybe she just underestimated how large the ship is in her brief glance at it as she was dragged aboard. Catra screws her eyes shut and refuses to watch as she feels it steadily rise up to her hips, and then her waist. The singing is gone completely now with no sign of Adora. Bitterly, Catra curses her hatred of water. Without it, she could have taken Adora up on her offer to make her a siren. They wouldn't be *here*.

"Wildcat, I…" Scorpia begins, her voice lost and desperate. Catra doesn't open her eyes as the water laps over her chest, cold liquid enveloping her hammering ribcage. What is there to say? Catra can't reply anyway. She should probably apologize for getting half her fucking crew – Scorpia now included – killed, but the muzzle has been uncomfortably jamming her teeth clenched together for over a day. Scorpia sucks in a deep breath as the water laps over Catra's shoulders.

"Bonnie and I had a rebound fling after Seaworthy and wanted to tell you as our captain but I insisted we hide it from you," Scorpia rushes out, like a *confession*. That actually startles Catra. She blinks her eyes open, squinting at Scorpia as the water reaches her throat and she very nearly screams from panic. She is actually grateful for the nonsensical confession if only for a distraction. Scorpia's expression is caught between a sheepish smile and a grimace.

"Might as well go without secrets," she says, her voice low. Her gaze is loaded with sadness as she looks down at Catra. The water is only a few inches lower on her than it is on Catra. Catra tries to send Scorpia a reassuring expression back – if that is what Scorpia is worried about, then Catra wants her to know that she doesn't *care* – but then the water reaches her muzzle. She knows her immediate panic must be obvious in her face, because Scorpia's eyes tinge with pity as Catra takes a huge breath just before the water covers her nose too.

There is plenty of air room left in the cell, but Catra can’t move to reach it. It seems that she will be the first to go.

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The water covers her head and fills her ears. Catra hates the sound of it rushing in. She can hear Scorpia thrashing – trying to swim up to the air gap, probably – in the water beside her, but neither of them can escape the cell or outrun their fate. Adora has been gone for a while. Catra is alone, water all around her. She can hear its movement and her own racing heart, everything sounding weird underwater as she holds her breath. She doesn’t really know why she is bothering. She is just prolonging the length of her panic before she blacks out.

She is so scared of what drowning will feel like. As much as this is hell, she can’t make herself get it over with. She wants to sob, her head spinning and lungs aching for air. Her heart is racing so fast, she must be using it up quickly. She reels when Scorpia kicks her in her desperate swimming. It would startle her eyes open if it didn’t make her briefly black out. For a moment, everything goes quiet before a note pierces the blackness.

She opens her eyes again, hazy awareness creeping back to her, but she can’t feel anything. Her air is gone. Her lungs feel like fire. She must have gasped out while unconscious because saltwater is everywhere. She can’t register it on her fur anymore when it is inside her, flooding her nose and filling her lungs. She is filled with burning liquid, unable to thrash and scream like she wants. She squeezes her eyes shut, but it doesn’t stop them from stinging.

Scorpia kicks her again, she thinks. There is a harsh tug at her shoulder, at least. A second one follows. Catra tries to scream around the gag, but nothing happens. It is locking the water into her

mouth, throat, and *lungs* as everything slowly falls away to numb blackness. The gag falls away too, yanking her head harshly with it. Something replaces it, pressing against her and breathing a different kind of fire into her as the blackness pulls her down.

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Fire. Hell, probably. It's not just in her lungs anymore, spreading through every inch of her as her body falls. At least in death she can thrash wildly and scream. Mostly, anyway. Her legs are bound and demons keep clutching at her, but in the darkness of death, Catra screams, an earthshattering sound that feels like it can pierce anything and make it feel her pain with her. She tries to fight the burning fire within her, vaguely aware of something colder around her that could soothe her, but it overtakes her and drags her down as she finally falls into the pure blackness of death.

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The memory of Adora's gentle song, sung with soft affection and love to lull her to sleep, wakes Catra. She shudders, every inch of her aching as she opens her eyes. The song cuts off in an instant. Catra blinks up, expecting to see- well, she doesn't know. She doesn't believe in life after death, it just felt like she was experiencing it for a moment of half-awareness there. What she expected to be greeted by was *nothing*, never forming another thought. Instead, she blinks up at Adora, who blinks back down at her.

Catra is in her arms, wrapped up in her embrace – and *her*. Adora's hair is floating around her head, a golden halo tugged gently

by the ocean currents surrounding them and pressing against Catra's own eyes. Catra desperately gasps out, expecting to be met with the same terrible feeling she just nearly died to, but instead she just *breathes*. Not air, there is no air, but the sides of her neck burn a little, like an ache, and her body pulls in oxygen. Adora's expression is anxious and concerned as Catra vaguely registers the arms tightening around her.

"You were too far gone. I had to, I'm sorry. I couldn't get the shackles off, much less pull you to the surface before it would be too late. I barely got the muzzle off in time to give you the kiss of life," Adora tells her. Her voice sounds weird, distorted by the currents surrounding them. Catra has done everything she can to avoid submerging her head in water for her entire life. Everything about this is foreign even before the words hit her and she realizes that she isn't in the same body as she was before. Well, it isn't the same as she left it, anyway.

She stares up at Adora as she spends a moment breathing and *feeling*. They are in the water, pressure bearing down on them that tells Catra they probably aren't even close to the surface. She twitches her ears. They feel stiff, less mobile or sensitive. Her legs were never bound together – they were *fins*, a long tail to match Adora's trailing down from her waist. Her claws, at least, don't feel much different. Breathing has changed completely though. Catra's heart races. Some of her panic must show on her face because Adora's expression become even more pinched with concern as she hugs Catra close.

"Shh, you're safe. Don't try to talk or move. Just breathe. It will even out and then everything will be okay. We're together," Adora assures her. Catra has residual terror still in her limbs, but she shakily jerks her head in the semblance of a nod.

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Despite her body naturally doing it, it takes Catra awhile to get enough of a handle on breathing that she doesn't feel like she is hyperventilating anymore. It takes her even longer to tear her eyes away from Adora to look down at herself. Despite there being the obvious major changes, every inch of her is still different. Adora's gaze follows her own and she reaches down, petting through the fur on her stomach. It is either meant as encouragement or just to help her adjust to its new texture.

"Like a seal's, right? It reminds me of how Oswald felt to pet. You're still so soft, but you're built for the water now," Adora tells her. Her voice still sounds so odd in the water. She cradles Catra with one arm, the two of them tucked in against a rock formation, as she pets through Catra's fur. Catra makes a soft noise – oh, fuck, that's *new*. The sound reverberates through her in a way she isn't used to. She forgot she can't talk anymore. So that's what it feels like when Adora sings.

"Shh. We'll find a voice for you. You'll get used to communicating through song, too, but one thing at a time. Body first," Adora promises, twisting a little to press a kiss against Catra's temple. Adora beats her tail, absently pushing them back against the rock formation as they start to drift from it in the current. She is used to the pull of the ocean and adjusting to it. Catra is still working on breathing, though her body is slowly calming as it settles into itself.

Adora said the process was uncomfortable, but Catra didn't grasp how much so. She flexes her hands in the water – they feel largely identical, though it seems her skin has faded darker around her fingertips – and moves them cautiously to pet through her own fur. The quality of it has changed dramatically – she sees what Adora meant about feeling like a seal's – but at least it didn't fall out and leave her as naked as Adora or anything. Her clothes are gone, so her tits are out, but it would have felt far more exposing if she was robbed of her fur.

She takes a deep breath and experimentally moves her tail, watching the brilliant array of what appears to be yellows and neon hues cut by dark purples flash with the movement. Her tail fin is different from Adora's – it is an entirely different shape, reminiscent of a heart and smaller – but it doesn't seem any less effective. Adora coos an approval as Catra's movement shifts them back, another kiss pressing softly against her temple.

"It's the most beautiful red I've ever seen. It suits you," Adora tells her. Catra down to her tail. That explains the odd myriad of neon shades she can't quite place, fading into a golden yellow . Everything looks weird now, even her vision changing. Distantly, she feels grateful for that. The salt against her eyes stung terribly. She needs them to be different to handle it. Now, nothing about the water hurts, even if Catra feels unsettled.

"When you feel confident enough to move, there's still some of the crew bobbing on the surface. We saved some for you. Eating will make you feel better," Adora tells her . Catra's ears twitch. She looks up, staring at Adora with wide eyes.

Whether I like it or not.

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Adora takes Catra's hand in her own, speaking and singing encouragement to her as she leads Catra up towards the surface. Catra is still unsure about moving at all, much less swimming this far, but her body adjusts to the depth changes with ease. The water gets lighter, less pressing. Catra knows that should make her feel better, but oddly, she misses the pressure. It was quickly becoming comforting, like a blanket wrapped all around her.

It turns out that she didn't need to get over her fear of the ocean before becoming a siren. The transformation did it for her. She still feels deeply unsettled, but she just fucking died and woke up with her body transformed. From what Adora told her about her first few days as a siren, discomfort is normal. Catra doesn't know if she feels up to soul-eating yet, but if it will make her more comfortable, she is open to trying. Adora talked about feeling ravenous in her first few days. Catra should take this opportunity while she has it.

Adora's hand in her own, steadily tugging Catra up with her, is comforting at least. She follows her wife up to the surface, watching the light flood the water around them until the surface is visible. Waves look *odd* from below, an inversion of something that she has seen for her entire life, but Catra is grateful for the sight. Above water, Adora's voice will at least sound normal.

They surface, Catra squinting at the light. She feels her ears twitch, but they don't pin back like they want to. She felt along them with her fingers before she tried to properly swim. They are similar to Adora's earfins, but the shape is a bit more elongated to match Catra's old pair, and they are similarly larger. The transformation changes depending on the species, clearly. Adora gained claws, but Catra already had them, and they even still retract, though they are a bit longer than before.

After a moment of adjusting to the brightness, Catra takes in her surroundings. They're in the middle of the ocean – the middle of fucking *nowhere* – but the wreckage of a ship stretches before them, scattered by the waves. Boards, some floating cargo, and what appear to pieces of lifeboats float in the ocean before them, along with men both alive and dead. Catra can see – or maybe just *feel* – another siren swimming below the wreck.

"We couldn't risk anyone getting away and telling the tale like they clearly did with the Black Garnet. It would bring scrutiny on the island. They're going to die anyway. If you feel up to it, you should try to eat. I'll show you how," Adora tells her , wrapping an arm around her waist and kissing the side of her face again, gentle and

encouraging. Catra swallows. She really doesn't feel like it, but she should. It's just a waste of life otherwise.

She nods jerkily. Adora's smile is soft and encouraging as she takes her hand and leads her forward.

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The other siren is deeper in the wreck. No one but the souls who are already going to be lost sees as Adora shows her how to pull a soul from a heart. Catra is unsure, grimacing as she tries for herself, but fuck is it a high when she pulls in the magic and drinks it down. She suddenly understands what Adora meant about feeling ravenous. Her body used everything it had transforming and now that it has gotten a taste of magic again, she is desperate for it. Adora leads her through the wreck, seeming to sense which bodies still have life in them and yanking them down for Catra.

With Adora helping her, they make short work of it until the raw hunger has subsided. Catra tries to tell Adora that she is done and a scratchy chirp comes out. She is pretty sure she flushes. She fucking forgot she can't talk. Luckily, Adora seems to understand. She lights up a little, her expression one Catra knows well. It's fond, the look she gets whenever she finds something Catra does cute. Adora swims closer to wrap Catra up in her arms, smiling down at her.

"I understand that, Catra. It will take getting used to, but we speak the same language," she assures. Catra nods, though the movement feels odd with the enormous weight of her wet mane billowing behind her. Catra's hair has always been heavy, but now it pulls uncomfortably at her neck. She doesn't know how Adora stands it. Maybe Adora senses her thoughts, because she slips a hand up along the back of Catra's neck and squeezes gently. Catra melts a

little in her grip, a happy buzz running through her . Adora grins and leans forward.

Kissing underwater is a whole new experience. Kissing with her new tongue is. Adora has, generally, felt cool to the touch since becoming a siren, but as they meet like this, her mouth is warm and inviting. Adora doesn't care about the souls Catra has just eaten, kissing her with ardent attention, the hand on her neck firm but gentle. She cradles Catra now just like she did when Catra first woke up, careful attention focused on her lover.

With her new lung capacity, Catra knows she shouldn't be breathless when they part. She still is.

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Adora expended everything she had turning Catra and needs to eat as well. Catra gets used to swimming with her new tail as she follows Adora through the wreck at a bit of a distance. Adora is hunting and it feels wrong to get too close. She can more than handle herself, filling up until there is nothing left to feast on. She takes Catra's hand again, leading her back down towards where Catra can sense the other siren as she explains.

"This is Perfuma' s lair. I'd stumbled across it before, but she was out and I didn't realize anyone lived here. I thought it was my best chance for running the ship aground without causing too much damage and risk you getting hurt. She heard my song and came to help when it got weak. She doesn't mind sharing. She's really nice," Adora tells her as they descend. Adora stops them about halfway down, turning and taking both of Catra's hands in her own. Catra blinks in surprise at Adora's earnest – and anxious – expression.

I’m sorry I couldn’t get to you sooner . I know you weren’t ready to be a siren and I didn’t give you a choice-”she starts, only the first tenth of what Catra can already tell is a longwinded apology. She cuts Adora off with a sharp note. Adora draws to a halt, blinking with wide eyes at her, but Catra meant it when she said to stop . She sighs, frustrated, turning her head to look away and growling when her mane floats in front of her face. Yes, she was the furthest thing from ready , but she is alive. She is with Adora.

She can’t speak. She doesn’t know if she trusts her song, but she tries. She tries to open her mouth and pour out that it wasn’t Adora’s fault. Adora saved her, even if it was terrifying as the ship sank. Catra wouldn’t be better off locked in that hold with a mule on. The only reason for the Primary Navy to keep her alive was to punish her, maybe even torture her. Wherever she was headed isn’t more hospitable than the bottom of the ocean, and regardless, it doesn’t have Adora.

Some of it must come through, because Adora looks a bit like she wants to cry, and touched too. She nods, tugging on Catra’s hands and pulling her into a tight embrace. Catra clings back. All of this is still sinking in, but she would rather be in Adora’s arms than anywhere else.

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Perfuma is sweet, though she is hissing despite the water all around her. Adora seems to remember Scorpia moments before they reach the hollow near the base of the rocky outcrop where Perfuma is lurking. Truthfully, Catra kind of forgot too. She was kind of focused on becoming a siren, and though her brain should have remembered her companion in the cell by now, she didn’t want to. She doesn’t want to think about how desperate Adora was to save her and how little time she had to help Scorpia too, if it was even possible.

It wasn't, it turned out. Adora couldn't have given Scorpia the kiss after using everything on Catra, but she wasn't the only siren at the shipwreck, and Perfuma swam into the ship after she picked off a few sailors to see what was up with Adora. She found her tearing open Catra's cell, too hurried to explain as she swam up, tugged on her shackles once, and then broke open her muzzle to save her. Perfuma says she took one look at the slaver equipment and knew she had to help the other women as well, but given the way Perfuma is massaging Scorpia's shoulders now, Catra can guess her real motivations.

She is hopelessly flirty with the newly-awakened and seemingly dazed Scorpia. Scorpia settles down at the sight of Catra and Adora, though. She trusted Perfuma's sudden appearance enough to let herself be led up to eat as Adora helped Catra adjust down below – she was further gone and out for longer as a result, apparently – but the sight of a familiar face helps. Scorpia knows a bit about how this works from traveling with Adora for awhile, but having someone who can explain it with words rather than sing is helpful.

Perfuma doesn't have a voice. She has never had need for one – and she has been worried about trying to acquire one and it fitting awkwardly around her Adam's apple. They still understand her. All of her meaning pours into her songs seemingly regardless of if she wants it to or not, hence Catra knowing about Perfuma's concerns over another woman's voice not working for her despite her own bursting magic identifying her as one when she was given the kiss of life. The songs are feelings and thoughts rather than words, conveying a depth of meaning.

Catra feels more settled in her body now it has a proper reserve of energy, even if she is still adjusting to this *magic* thing. Her sounds are small and tentative as she feels it out. She feels weirdly embarrassed to sing, but Adora wraps around her in a near-constant hug, seemingly unwilling to let her go after being parted, and she is only encouraging as Catra works on mastering her new method of

communication. Scorpia's songs are disasters – her voice is beautiful, but they only come out in quiet whispers.

Scorpia only starts singing properly when Perfuma encourages her to do it along with her, her voice steadily growing more confident until they are singing together, the sound filling the hollow where they are all resting. Everything about the world is different now – Catra had it easy, it turns out, Scorpia is getting used to having *hands* for the first time, though her fingers resemble armored claws still – but the songs are beautiful even when they aren't coming from Adora, it turns out.

Catra still prefers Adora's song to every other, but she closes her eyes and lets herself just breathe as Adora holds her and the sound surrounds her.

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It took Adora weeks to adjust to her new body and abilities. Catra knows it will take her time to settle. Adora holds her hand and helps her learn to swim for the first time ever. Catra has new senses and a new environment to contend with, but with Adora by her side, she knows she is safe. Adora won't let her get hurt. She doesn't need to constantly be on guard as she adjusts. Catra can defend herself, too, her voice growing stronger as she becomes more confident in her song. She has her claws like she always did, and now she can command men if she has to.

There was a part of her always looking out when she was on the island, and it wasn't just general paranoia about the Horde catching up with her. Her true fear was being separated from Adora again. It would be so easy to do, pulling Catra inland and trapping her. It can't happen now. No matter what happens, they're together. They swim side-by-side, Catra steadily growing bold and swimming around Adora in a slow spiral as they travel back to the island. Scorpia didn't

feel up to the journey, but she was also flustered as she conveyed that.

Every ounce of intent doesn't have to slip through in the song. Catra suspects that is down to who you are as a person before the transformation, because she has no trouble keeping her thoughts and feelings to herself when she is trying to convey information, but Scorpia's songs are earnest, and Perfuma spills out a lot when she sings. She isn't used to there being anyone else who can understand her, though. She didn't want to leave the islands she grew up on after being transformed, apparently, so she has stayed here, largely alone.

She is eager for the company, even if she clearly prefers Scorpia's to theirs. Catra gets the impression that goes both ways though. Scorpia is practically making heart eyes at the other woman. If Scorpia wants to stay with the stranger while Catra and Adora visit the island, that's up to her. Perfuma certainly doesn't seem malicious, and apparently Octopus Cove is a few hours of swimming away, especially with them going slow to accommodate Catra. Adora already knew how to swim when she was transformed and had no problem with getting in water, but Catra isn't used to any of this and she is slow for the moment.

She is growing more comfortable, though. Everything felt foreign and strange and maybe reminded her a bit of *dawning* when she first awoke, but it has been a few hours, and she is adjusting now. She is settled enough for her need to check on Entrapta to outweigh her discomfort. They don't have a way of reaching her directly though. On the journey, Adora explains her day and a half of panic and how the mayor – however reluctantly – helped her. They decide to return to the fishing village to see if he can get a message to Entrapta.

They stop at the shack first, though. Catra stares at it from the water, thinking about her mostly-peaceful month of living there. She thought she would build a life for herself and Adora here, somehow, despite the constant shivering from the sea breeze that was only growing worse with the approaching winter. Her living conditions were

basically built from garbage, but Adora was there, so she didn't really care. She quietly had dreams of reinforcing and rebuilding the shack bit-by-bit until it was a proper cottage.

It isn't happening. She isn't a fisherman – she was never meant to be. All she has ever wanted was a life with Adora, but her time on the island felt like it was on a clock until the next thing tried to pull them apart. Her heart heavy, she sings a quiet, gentle song. It is mourning – it is telling Adora that this was never right, but she misses it anyway. The only thing she has of value here she can't even *eb* anymore. Adora lays a hand on her shoulder and squeezes, shaking her head.

"We'll have the mayor get it. I'm touched you want to get it back, Catra," Adora promises her, pulling her close and kissing her face for the hundredth time since reuniting. Not that Catra is complaining – she leans into the touch happily, comforted by the assurance.

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The mayor looks like he is going to shit himself when he comes stumbling out of his house after Adora bangs on the bottom of it – it's not quite dawn, so Catra can't really blame him given the sudden interruption – but he seems equally disquieted and relieved to see Catra beside Adora. He gapes at them a bit, clearly wanting to ask what the hell happened, but he thinks better of it.

"Your boatwright friend came yesterday, just after you left. No one in town would talk to her when the Navy was still docked and she was hoping you had decided to come back here instead," he tells them when Adora asks him to take a message to Entrapta. It's a relief to know that she truly managed to escape it all. He agrees to tell Entrapta that Catra and Scorpia have *j oi ned Adora* and are okay. He blinks in surprise when Adora asks if he can fetch something from

the shack for them, but he agrees when Adora tells them it is something they can't leave behind on the island.

Catra thinks he is just glad he won't have to worry about sirens hanging around anymore. Adora always unnerved him. He goes back inside to put on proper boots and a coat, but then they follow him along the shore as he makes his way to the shack. Catra is startled when Adora tells him it is hanging from the rafter above the hammock. She blinks at Adora as he disappears inside. Adora tilts her head at her for a moment before seeming to realize the source of her confusion and smiling sheepishly.

"I panicked when you didn't come back. I managed to drag myself into the shack to see if there was anything there and saw it hanging. This is a lot easier, though," she explains. Catra nuzzles against her shoulder, not wanting to sing her affection and panic the mayor, though he seems disconcerted enough when he comes out of the shack carefully carrying the jawbone by its cords so he doesn't have to touch it. Catra rises up in the water eagerly, reaching to pull it from his hands. He seems happy for her take it, letting it go like it has burned him. Catra, in contrast, cradles it against her chest and chirps a vague thank you that Adora translates for her.

"Thank you for this, and for all the help you gave us. I'm sorry about threatening you before, but I couldn't be without my wife. We may visit the island occasionally, but we're leaving now. We won't bring you any trouble," she tells him as Catra traces her fingers over the swirling patterns on the bone. They exchange goodbyes as Catra examines it with all new eyes. She always appreciated the craftsmanship, and especially the fact that it was important to Adora, but she *understands* now.

She sinks down in the water, using the movement to lift the mass of her mane from the back of her neck so she can carefully tie the cords together there, creating a necklace for the jawbone. It will drag in the water, but no more than her massive mane will. Catra is just about sick of it already. She wants to cut it off so the ocean won't pull at it. The sensation feels less menacing than it always did before -

probably because she is in no danger of drowning should she be pulled out to sea - but her mane is even larger than Adora's. It's *ridiculous*.

Adora coos happily when she ducks back down from waving goodbye to the mayor to find the jawbone resting against Catra's heart. She looks at her with wide eyes, reaching up after a moment and cupping Catra's cheek to pull her in for a kiss. It is loaded with as much affection as all her songs are. They embrace for a long moment, slowly drifting in the inlet but nothing mattering except the other. Catra swears she can taste sparks of magic when they kiss now, their souls intertwining as they embrace.

Even when they pull apart, Catra can still feel the cracks in her heart where Adora's pieces slot in like a perfect fit. Adora's eyes are bright, dancing with happiness as she keeps holding Catra until they drift enough to crest the surface. Catra wrinkles her nose at the sensation of her hair going from being in water to truly *wet* once it hits the hair. The expression makes Adora laugh, beating her tail a little to raise her head above the water. Reluctantly, Catra pins her ears, her hair plastering down around her ears. Yeah, that definitely has to go.

"What do you want to do now? Where do you want to go?" Adora asks her, her voice light and filled with hope – with *joy*. The question surprises Catra, but she supposes she should have been expecting it after saying goodbye to her shack. They will probably return to Perfuma's outcrop now, but Catra has no intention of living there forever, she just needs some time to adjust to the transformation, as does Adora. In the grand scheme, they can go anywhere on water now. They could go back to Seaworthy, or to that siren city Adora has told her about, or to go searching for their own lair.

As she thinks about the options, Catra realizes it doesn't actually matter. She wraps her arms around Adora's waist, opening her mouth and singing a low, breathy song, meant just for them. She sings that she doesn't care – that she wants to adjust to her body, and then go to Seaworthy to make sure Bonnie made it safely, but anything after that they can take as it comes. She sings that she

wants to cut her hair, watching amusement dance in Adora's eyes in response, though it is replaced with a flood of love as Catra continues and sings her *pi nt* .

They can go anywhere in the world, *b* anywhere in the world, and it won't matter, not as long as they are together. Catra knows the weight of the bone she wears, and she wants every ounce of its implications. She wants it to be them no matter what happens. She wants anything in the world as long as she gets to share it with Adora.

When her song dies, Adora kisses her forcefully, like she has barely been able to hold herself back as she waited for Catra to finish. She kisses her like she is the only thing in the universe. She kisses her like she agrees with everything Catra said and is overjoyed that Catra feels the same. She kisses Catra like she is her wife and she will never grow tried of everything that means. She kisses Catra exactly like Catra wants her to – like Catra is everything. *They* are.

Catra kisses her back. She does it for a long time. She knows this isn't what their increased lung capacity is for, but it is the most important use it could have. She is pretty sure dawn breaks around them as they kiss, but the sun means little compared to Adora in her arms. She has always been Catra's guiding light. They will go anywhere and do what comes to them. They don't need a plan. They'll never be lost as long as they have each other.

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bnnie does a doubletake when she sees them. Catra smirks up at her from the waterway running beside Rogelio's house. bnnie stares back, unblinking, for a long moment. In the darkness of the night, she can't see Catra's tail trailing down into the water beneath her, but thanks to Catra's new pixie cut, she can see her ears

decorated in red scales. Catra has adjusted to the pull of the tides around her, but she just couldn't stand it on her hair , and it was getting in the way. Now that it has been cut, she feels more comfortable.

"I can't believe I'm even surprised," Bonnie says eventually . Catra can't help it – she laughs, loud and musical. Quickly , she ducks beneath the water to mute the sound as Adora huffs. They have been waiting for probably two hours, lurking at the edges of the Seaworthy lagoon to wait for it to be dark enough to swim to Rogelio's house. Things look different from down in the water, but Catra was able to find her old temporary house regardless.

"Listen, if there had been another option, I wouldn't have kissed her ," Adora defends as Catra surfaces again, letting her eyes rise above the waterline while keeping her mouth below it. Her amusement is contained down to twitching ears, but she has a feeling she'll need to muffle more noises. It has been a few weeks since the transformation and Catra is now confident in her new "voice," but still she needed time to adjust before making a journey like this. Bonnie raises an eyebrow and fixes Adora with a flat look.

"You two suck face at every opportunity," she returns. Adora huffs as Catra snickers again. Adora rolls her eyes and crosses her arms as she pouts up at Bonnie in response. Bonnie is *right*, even if they limit themselves somewhat because Catra still prefers kissing when their heads are above the water.

"It's a different kind of kiss. Scorpia had to become a siren too. Turns out Hordak was still working with the Primary Navy and they wanted revenge for the Black Garnet," Adora tells her . That truly surprises Bonnie, her eyebrows shooting up as she gapes at Adora for a moment. A second later, she swears. Catra snorts, a small stream of bubbles coming up from her nose. Catra chirps to Adora, reminding her of more she has to say.

"Oh, Scorpia is staying around Octopus Cove. She met another siren and they're. Something. Or they are going to be, at least. Entrapta

is still a shipwright at the port and she and Scorpia meet up regularly on the docks at night now, so they're keeping an eye out for each other. We wanted to make sure you made it back in one piece," Adora adds, inclining her head a little towards Catra and squeezing her hand beneath the water in silent acknowledgement. Bonnie snorts, rolling her eyes at she straightens up a little.

"I'm glad Scorpia found someone instead of always barking up the wrong tree, I guess," Bonnie comments, eyeing Catra for a long moment. Catra resists the urge to narrow her eyes back, silently daring Bonnie to say anything. "You can't talk anymore, huh? Like Adora at first?" she asks, apparently piecing together her silence. Catra feels her ears twitch and nods. At her side, Adora looks a bit sheepish, sinking lower in the water. Bonnie immediately looks to her with suspicion.

"We were hoping you could help us with that, actually. Help us find someone for her to take the voice of. We didn't want to do it with the villagers back at Octopus Cove. They're just trying to get by," Adora explains. Catra feels her ears twitch, but otherwise tries to remain passive. She hates asking for help, but especially with *mother*. Bonnie gets a distant look in her eye. It worries Catra for a moment, the fear of being turned away not even the strongest one.

She has few friends and doesn't want to lose Bonnie as one. Sure, they can't exactly hang out like they used to, but given the layout of Seaworthy, she and Adora could pop in to visit Bonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle whenever they are in the area. It would be nice to still have people – with legs, especially – to call their friends, not to mention the fact that Catra wants to keep *these* friends in particular. They've been through a lot together as children growing up in the Horde, after all.

"Remember Oswald?" Bonnie asks, finally looking down to meet Catra's gaze. Catra blinks, surprised, but she chirps and nods. "The fucker is growing *fast*. Take him to where he can safely adapt to the wild and I'll help you get your hands on a voice. You can use it to convince Kyle that he'll be fine. He won't let us release him because

he ‘doesn’t have the skills to survive’,” Connie tells her , making air-quotes as she parrots Kade and rolls her eyes. Catra can’t help it – she ducks her entire head beneath the water and cackles for a moment. Adora looks equally amused when she surfaces.

“Deal,” she agrees.

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“It only took three months, but the news has finally spread that the Black Garnet is gone and the Horde is fucked. It’s been every man for himself ever since. Finding an uppity fucker trying to prove they’re bad enough to make it on their own wasn’t hard,” Connie explains, rolling her eyes, as she sits on the edge of Rogelio’s dock. Her shoes are off and her pants rolled up so she can dangle her feet in the water. Catra snorts, unused to the feeling of using a normal voice again.

Connie had a rather different approach to luring someone into the lagoon than Catra did. Namely, she showed up at the shrine with Rogelio in tow, carrying a barrel that he then rolled into the water. They’d knocked a lady out and hidden her inside for transport. Catra thought it would take Connie longer to find her a female magicat, but after two evenings of lurking at the shrine hoping Connie would find someone, Catra finally has a voice again. Oswald swims in the water around them, occasionally being reined back by a gentle chirp from Adora calling for him to stay close.

“I have a hard time imagining Seaworthy as more lawless,” Catra admits, snorting a little. She did keep to some of the worst parts of it when she lived here, but it only took her a few minutes to find an obvious slaver the last time that she was here. It’s hard to imagine people getting more blatant. She thought, given the rarity of magicats this far from their homeland, it would be harder to track one

of them down for Catra to steal a voice from. Bonnie shakes her head a bit ruefully.

"I kind of like it. You can get the full pirate experience without ever leaving the dock. Everybody is trying to puff themselves up and brag about their crimes so they seem too dangerous to be fucked with even without the Horde at their back," Bonnie explains. Catra snorts. Yeah, that actually tracks. Seaworthy was a pirate port long before the Horde and it will be one long after, but there were people here who were afforded a certain amount of protection from the others just by being part of the Horde. To mess with them would have meant messing with something far larger.

It made them complacent. They aren't actually as tough as the others because they never had to be, and now they're finding that out the hard way. The Horde is splintering. It will break into smaller coalitions like it was before, with some choosing independence or even going straight. Very few members knew the truth about who they were working for – even Catra isn't sure how closely the Horde was working with the Primary Navy – and very few will know now. Adora explained it to the group on the first night they arrived in Seaworthy, but aside from explaining some things in retrospect, it doesn't really matter now.

"It's made the town scarier, but they usually keep to the rougher parts during the day. This corner of the neighborhood is quiet," Kyle adds, pulling a face at Bonnie's words. Of course he wouldn't like it, but Rogelio is a carpenter and Kyle is just his assistant ever since he got banned from being around anything explosive – and thus being a powder monkey - so they don't really have to get involved with the more unsavory types in town. Kyle can stain wood and stay inside after dark. Rogelio comments something in lizardfolk that makes the corner of Bonnie's mouth tilt up. Catra didn't understood the word, but the gentle teasing in his tone was obvious.

"We've got a good little house and things will calm down eventually. It's not bad. Working the docks is actually exciting now. You never know when there's going to be a shootout, so the pay went up, and

the dockmaster hired me to be an enforcer as much as a laborer. I get a good scuffle in here and there,” Bonnie returns, shrugging. Rogelio is currently leaned against said little house while he sits on the stoop, watching Oswald down in the water sadly. He was cheery when he and Adora were chatting this morning, Bonnie already off to work and Rogelio busy, but as their departure has grown closer, he has gotten quieter.

“He’s been a real bright spot in all of it, you know? Even if he eats like a horse now,” he says, gesturing down to the seal in the water. Oswald, currently trying to hide inside Adora’s trailing hair, doesn’t acknowledge he’s mourning. He is a seal after all. Apparently he is generally amiable, but after a few weeks of living on blubber stores, he began eating a lot. He has a ton of energy and is getting less docile as he grows and molts repeatedly. He isn’t meant to be living on land, and they can’t let him loose in the lagoon for fear that someone will catch and eat him. He needs the open ocean anyway.

“We’ll take him to where it’s cold enough for him to live and we’ll hang around until he gets the hang of hunting,” Catra promises him, rolling her eyes. It was too warm for him to even be where they found him, but give that the injury to his fin looked like it was made by a fishhook, he suspected he ended up there due to intervention by people. It meant that he had likely grown up in captivity and made he want to release him even less, but he isn’t meant to be this far south.

“We’ll take him to some beach in the Kingdom of Snows. We’ll give you an update the next time we swing by Seaworthy,” Adora promises him, reaching back to pet Oswald as he nuzzles at her hair, lost in its forest. Oswald remembers her. She’s the soft one, the one who understands him. He doesn’t recognize Catra since her transformation, but that’s probably for the best considering that she caught him like a fish and then spent a few days tripping over him and yelling for he to come get him out of her way the last time she saw him.

Oswald rubs his face against Adora's hand, like he's trying to snuffle her but can't while under water. Catra, totally not jealous in any way, drifts closer and bumps their shoulders together. Amusement dances in Adora's eyes, but she shifts to wrap an arm around Catra and absently pet through the fur on her side. Now Oswald is molting, Catra is softer than him, her coat more akin to the one he had as a fluffy white pup than the one coming in now. She might be less streamlined, but she still feels a sense of victory over him for it. Adora hums as she through Catra's soft fur. It's better for petting.

"Where are you guys going to go after that?" Kyle asks, up on the walkway. No one wanted to stick around to watch Catra take her voice, so they agreed for all of them to meet up back at the house after she and Adora were done at the shrine. The shrine's bank isn't just Adora and Catra's meetup spot now. If any of the trio gets in trouble, or they have to move for some reason between Catra and Adora swinging by for a visit, they will bury a message in a bottle in the soft dirt of the reed-lined bank. Catra and Adora can check it to find out where to find their friends if they aren't at the house.

They can roam as far as they want without worrying about losing their friends. Despite the bank being their usual drop point, it seemed best to meet up at the house instead to say goodbye. Kyle was waiting there with Oswald anyway. It would have been difficult – and conspicuous – to get him out to the little shrine island. They will travel north along the coastline with him, using their magic to call him back when he tries to wander. Hopefully he will have the hang of hunting by the time they reach the northern beaches where he is meant to live and Catra and Adora can move on to their next destination.

"Salineas. It's a siren colony underwater. They'll be able to teach Catra more about her abilities than I can, and I have more to learn for myself. We'll visit you guys and the crew over in Octopus Cove even if we decide to stay there long-term, though," Adora promises them. Bonnie raises her brow at the mention of the siren city, but she

nods. For a moment it is silent, the only sound water lapping against the side of the house and Bonnie kicking her feet a little in the water.

They all know that it's time for goodbye, but even though they need to take Oswald away now, these are still their friends, and it's hard to leave them knowing they won't see each other again for weeks, probably months. Catra sighs, reaching out and welcoming Oswald into her arms when he tries to nuzzle against her chest. He's getting too big to be held. He's still a giant baby, but soon he won't fit in the tub she has been using for him anymore. He really has to go.

"We'll come see you again by spring, alright? We'll bring you something shiny from a shipwreck and good news about Oswald," Catra promises them. Bonnie and Rogelio both smile a bit ruefully, nodding. She looks like he might cry as he watches Oswald cuddle against Catra's chest, but he already agreed with Rogelio and Bonnie that this would be the best thing for Oswald. It is just hard for him to say goodbye. The kid got attached.

"You guys stay safe, alright?" Adora adds on. The crew can look after themselves, but given the rowdiness of the port lately, they are words that need to be said.

"We'll look after each other. You just take care of that guy so she doesn't talk my ear off in the meantime," Bonnie promises them, rolling her eyes, but her smile is fond. Catra snorts, but she knows the feeling. The time Adora could spend in the trough up on the Halfmoon's deck during the journey to the Black Garnet was limited, but she spent an entire one of those sessions talking about how she *could never eat a seal pup* and pouting about Catra thinking her monstrous enough to do so.

Catra defended that they had eaten seal before, but given that she can now sense Oswald's thoughts too, she doesn't think she could do it again either, even if a seal's soul were large enough to sustain her. At least the men they drown she knows are garbage. Oswald is just an animal trying to survive. He doesn't know about choosing kindness, or mercy, or deliberate cruelty. Catra and Adora will have

plenty to eat if they stick to Primary Navy and slaver ships. Hopefully Oswald will learn how to fish before they even need to eat again for themselves.

It takes a few more moments of awkward not-quite-goodbyes before Rogelio comments something in lizardfolk, Bonnie rolls her eyes in response, and she makes a shooing motion at them. Catra chuckles, but she and Adora both wave before Adora chirps at Oswald for him to follow them and they finally duck back down into the lagoon. They swim through the pathways of Seaworthy, quietly saying goodbye to the city as they go, before they reach the land spit that crosses into the ocean proper.

It's annoying to drag themselves over – Catra can't believe Adora put up with being on shores and banks so they could be together without ever saying a word about how much it fucking *sucks* to drag yourself out of the water and get covered in sand and silt – but watching Oswald's blubber bounce as he follows them over is pretty funny at least. Catra breathes better on the other side, taking a deep breath of the fresh, clean ocean water. The moon is still rising up in the sky, but it is bright, reflecting off the water of the calm sea.

Adora turns to her when Oswald finishes crossing, smiling and reaching out a hand for her. Catra lets herself be pulled in, meeting Adora in a soft embrace. The kiss is slow and thorough, leaving Adora softly sighing and Catra, still unused to the new voice in her throat, humming a high note as they part. Adora's expression is loaded with affection as they pull apart to prepare to swim again.

"North?" she asks. Catra smiles a little, glancing out at the open sea, before her lips twitch up in a smirk. She is feeling energized by suddenly having the lively water of the ocean against her again. The lagoon is saltwater, and it is even well aerated, but it is missing the ocean's spark of life and magic. It feels stagnant in comparison.

"Race you," Catra declares, and then she throws herself into the waves and begins speeding away, Adora's startled laugh trailing behind her. Adora doesn't hesitate to follow.

Chapter End Notes

And that's it for btD! Fic notes will go up on my Tumblr tomorrow.
I've drawn Siren Catra and will post her on Tumblr this evening when she's less of a "spoiler", but I already have her posted on Pillowfort if you want a look now. I'm imagining Siren Scorpia as looking like this awesome art from the waist up.
I'll be back sometime in the next two weeks (or next few days lol) with my next AU ✌ I will probably do some one shots between now and then, so subscribe to my profile if you haven't already and don't want to miss them!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!